Wild at Heart

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Wild at Heart

by TheWillOfMythal

Summary

"It will be universally admitted that instincts are as important as corporeal structures for the welfare of each species, under their present conditions of life. Under changed conditions, it is at least possible that slight modifications of instinct might be profitable. For it is not the strongest that survives, nor the most intelligent, but the one most responsive to change."

When speaking of adaptability, Catra has always found a way no matter what in order to survive.

Following her instincts has been a crucial part to ensure that.

...she never would have thought that one day she'd have to surrender to them though.

Fortunately enough, she doesn't have to do it alone.

Or,

When dealing with perpetual changes, Adora has always been Catra's constant.

Notes

These poor kids never got the chance to go through puberty and properly explore their bodies like horny teenagers are entitled to.

Such crime warranted an intervention.

Read the tags, folks.

Insert Big Mouth's opening song here

Enjoy

Instincts and Variation under Domestication

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There was a time, not so long ago, when hurting Adora was all you dreamed about.

It was all you wanted in the world under the pretense of simply achieving power, glory, and reign over the crushed bones of all of those who ever dared to stand up against you or had disrespected you in some way.

It was the sweet thought that gave you comfort. The exquisite fantasy which flames kept you warm at night and fuelled your resolve in the moments you were struggling.

Nothing had ever made you feel more powerful than the thought of seeing her broken and anguished, desperate, forced to her knees in defeat and bent over in pain, suffering, having lost everything and every*one* she loved.

Heavens...

The mere thought used to send a pang of arousal between your legs each damn time. The euphoria only comparable to the rush of falling ten stories in the air and feeling all your organs flutter and sink with the drop at once.

There was absolutely nothing else that had ever made you relish so deeply in the joy that such sight would have brought to you.

Of course, needless to say, that was *before.*

Before you found yourself on a Counquerer's ship, with an empty victory and feeling so utterly alone.

Before you did some overdue introspection and realized what was truly feeding those sick, depraved, vengeful fantasies.

Before you had the guts to finally, genuinely admit to yourself how you truly felt about her.

"I'm so, so sorry."

And right now, the sight of her hurting, of seeing her in pain - in knowing that *you* are *the reason* for her pain - is so sickening that your head spins with dizziness and your own stomach churns, threatening to empty its contents on the bedsheets, bile rising and burning in the back your throat, already swollen and closed off with the tears pricking in your eyes, which remain fixed, unblinking, *horrified* on the side of her neck.

The bite is deep.

Your fangs, razor sharp as they are, have done more damage than you thought they were capable of.

Her skin, already so pale and delicate as you know it's always been, is already bruising.

The deep punctures left by your teeth are already swollen red and tender-looking. It's not bleeding, but it still hurts just looking at it. An unsettling sight that is only made that much worse by the realization that you *did that.*

It all happened in a blur.

And the fact that it did right at the apex of your lovemaking, somehow, has you think that it wasn't coincidental.

Whatever it was that had possessed you to do it though, is now gone. And that's precisely the right word for it. Possessed. Because as soon as you sank your fangs in her pulse point and tasted the sweetly metallic essence of her blood on your tongue, that something inside you that had compelled you to do it, had roared with triumph and then promptly, and rather conveniently, receeded back from the most primal part of your brain where it had first emerged from.

Claim her, you remember that voice thundering in your head with the same urgency of your approaching climax. The compulsion thrumming in your very veins. Boiling deep in your core. Something ancient and primal embedded in your DNA *demanding it.*

But now...

"Hey, it's not so bad."

"Adora."

"It's okay, really."

She still sounds a bit giddy from the orgasm you just shared, and you kinda feel grateful for that, because you can't imagine her - no matter how strong and brave she might be - having to endure having a chunk of her flesh being torn off her neck like that without the endorphins and adrenaline to at least numbing some of the pain.

"I barely felt it." She admits after a moment of hesitation. Her cheeks flushing into a warmed shade of pink as she reaches up with one hand to feel for the bite. The fact that she winces only slightly when she presses, gently, tentatively, her fingertips there, is not so comforting.

Not comforting *at all*.

The sight of her suppressing the pain she clearly is in by choking down a whimper and biting down on her lip only has you grind your jaw, shut your eyes, and clench your fists so tightly that the tendons in your forearms stand out even under the layer of fur. Your claws digging into the meat of your palms, the thick callouses of your metacarpal pad providing the only cushioning that is preventing you from actually drawing blood, which is frustrating. Almost infuriating.

You are so lost in stewing in your own anger and shame and guilt that you are only partially aware of the way the bed shifts beneath you as Adora pulls herself up into a sitting position.

In fact, it's only when you feel the softness of her fingers grazing tentatively your knuckles that your eyes snap back open, only to find her- beautiful, stunning, and oh so prettily flushed - smiling that soft little smile of hers that has some of that tension coiling all your muscles melt away.

"I'm okay, Catra." She reassures again, so quietly, so genuinely, still smiling at you that unfairly beautiful smile, that it's hard not to believe her.

But the facts speak much louder. And a lot more accusingly.

"I hurt you." You mumble, voice rough with so many emotions, ears flat against your head. "I didn't mean to."

Your fists tighten further but the hand resting upon your own gently pries them open. With the kind of care that you are utterly undeserving of, and yet, are unable to fight.

"I know." She simply says, far too calm and understanding. "It's okay." She assures, again. "*I promise.*"

That does it.

Your ears twich up and your gaze lifts, tentatively, to meet hers.

She knows how much you value those two little words. And she wouldn't have said them if she didn't mean it.

You take a few moments to search for signs of deceit, for the shadow of a lie lurking in the openness of those deep blue eyes of hers, only allowing yourself to release the breath you have been holding for what felt like a full minute when you find none.

Hard as it still is sometimes, you decide to trust her judgment on this, allowing her to drag you out from the spiraling dark thoughts that were threatening to drown you, and into the safety of her arms.

You would be ashamed for how easily you melt into the embrace if it weren't for how comforting it feels... and how grateful you are.

"I don't know what came over me." You admit in the crook of her neck. And you truly don't, but the fact that Adora pulls away just enough to look at you like she believes you, with such open trust, only serves to make you feel more guilty and mortified by the whole... *accident*.

Your eyes flit back down to the ugly bruise and teeth marks marring the side of her neck and you almost flinch away, only prevented from recoiling by Adora's arms still wrapped loosely around you.

"It doesn't even hurt anymore." She says, a poor attempt at a lie to which you simply respond with a flat, unimpressed look and an arched eyebrow.

She bristles a bit and sighs in defeat, caught. "Fine. But only a little, I swear. And you know... if seeing it upsets you so much I can just transform and heal myself."

Upon hearing that, the most peculiar thing happens (which is really saying something considering all the weird shit you are subjected to on a daily basis). Because while the suggestion has some of your guilt receed, at the same time, unexplicably so, it elicits a low, really unhappy, really threatening *growl* and an involuntary twitch in your expression that you don't have to look in the mirror to recognize, way familiar to the feeling of your lips peeling back to expose your fangs in an angry snarl.

And just like that, the moment you realize what you just did, you recoil, throwing yourself off of Adora's loving embrace as if a bucket of icy cold water had just been poured over you.

The movement is so fast and sudden that your legs end up tangled in the sheets, sending you tumbling over the edge of the bed with a squeal in a messy, ungraceful heap of silk and thrown pillows that, unfortunately, don't soften the fall.

Great.

The once dreaded Force Captain, the fearsome second in command to the Horde Lord Himself, the majestic, elegant, dexterous feline, landing on her ass.

Just... wonderful.

"Catra!"

Luckily, Adora appears to be too worried to make fun of your rather undignified landing, scrambling after you and peering down over the edge of the bed.

"Are you okay?!" She almost shrieks, eyes wide, looking so concerned and earnest. Your heart gives such a heavy throb at the sight that it almost hurts as much as your bruised, furry butt.

"Ugh, that was embarrassing." You say, bitter with the humiliation you just suffered.

Adora just shakes her head and reaches out to help you untangle your legs from the sheets.

"Please, have you met me? You'll have to work harder than that to dethrone me from my klutz-of-the-millenium throne." She jokes with that dumb, dorky, half smirk of hers, and again, your heart flutters wildly at her attempt to make you feel better by making fun of herself. A chuckle slips past your lips and she beams, the half smirk stretching into that full, brilliant smile that never fails to make you fall just a little bit deeper in love with her and, right now, even manages to ease some of your own previous worries.

"Are you sure you are okay?" She asks again once you make back it safely back onto the bed, a frown of concern crinkling her brow as she fusses over you. "That looked like it hurt. You didn't land on your tail, did you?"

You swat at her worried hands and scoff, rolling your eyes. Because that's just *so Adora*. Worrying about others even when she is the one hurt the most.

Instinctively though, you find yourself reaching for the appendage in question anyway, absentmindedly smoothing out the bristled fur there.

"I think my ego was the main casualty." You assure her, rubbing at your bruised butt cheek.

She laughs, and with it another wave of relief washes over you.

It doesn't last long though, for the sight of her throwing her head back in laughter has your eyes zeroing once again on the angry bruise marring the side of her neck.

Another nasty mouthful of bile rises in the back of your throat and you swallow it down. Hard.

It's unsettling.

But the thought of her healing it causes a riot of emotions within you that you lack the energy to sort through at the moment.

Claim her.

You barely manage not to startle at the memory of that voice echoing once more in your head, resembling so very much your own, only deeper. Darker. The feeling attached to it demanding that the mark you left on her *stays*. That you put it there to be seen. That it is meant to scar and remain permanent.

Good Heavens...

After all the work you have done on yourself... are you *still* that fucked up?

Is that what all of this was about?

Hurt her and leave a sign on her that the rest of the world will know you have left?

It all seems like a plausible explanation; that last rebellious part of you refusing to accept these new dynamics, this reality you are living in, or some other equally profoud, psychological shit.

And yet...

The more you think on it, the more you consider such thought... the more you have the impression that that wasn't quite the reason why you *did it*. Which is as relieving a thought as it is deeply confusing. A tangle of feelings far to complex to describe and put into actual words.

"Catra?"

You blink back into focus, being met once again with the sight of Adora assessing you with a curious tilt of her head and a slightly concerned frown on her brow.

"Sorry. Just spaced out a bit." You assure her, flashing her a little smile, hoping that it will be enough to placate her.

Fortunately enough, it is.

Either that, or she decides that it is best not to push you for more.

A small blessing nonetheless.

You are far too exhausted to even try to sort though the thoughts crowding your head right now, so you doubt you would be able to conjure up the strength and clarity of mind necessary to explain her what exactly it is that you are feeling, choosing instead to be hauled further up into the bed and lay down, snuggling back into Adora's loving, forgiving, safe arms when she beckons you in her embrace.

"It's okay." She reassures, patiently, for what feels like the hundredth in the past five minutes.

The closeness helps a great deal in soothing some of that anxiety that had spiked inside you. But that's not surprising. And with the way she starts rubbing slow, comforting circles on your back, sliding her fingers through your fur and scratching just slightly, it is only a matter of time before your brain gets shut off and your diaphram and larinx start vibrating in unison to emit a loud series of purrs.

It must be the cuddling thing, you realize. Because suddenly, you don't feel so crippled by that deadly mix of guilt, shame and apprehension anymore. Just relief and a profound sense of rightness in laying so close together.

Maybe it was nothing.

Just a lust-induced act sprinkled with a bit of possessiveness.

As for Adora being unbothered by the pain itself... Well...

Taking into account all the times you have either fought her, tied her up, pulled her hair, sliced her open with your claws... it's no secret that she's kind of a freak in the matter.

And it's not like you have never enjoyed a bit of pain yourself when mixed with the right amount of pleasure. It just makes things so much more enjoyable and intense.

So, in the coziness of the moment, in this newfound peace, with her constant string of reassurances soothing your doubts and acting like a balm on the deep grooves of your guilt, her arms wrapped safely around you, her hands stroking the fur on your back oh so lovingly, and sleep slowly reaching out to welcome you into its realm, you let the thought slide away.

That, however - the willingness to ignore such a major sign, downsize it, pin it on lust and possibly forget about it - as you will shortly come to realize, is your first mistake.

. . .

You can't exactly pinpoint the moment things change.

As a matter of fact, you don't even think about attributing it to *what happened* that night.

But things do change. Inevitably so. And faster than you realize.

. . .

You want her.

And yeah, all right, *fine*, you have always wanted her, true.

But... never like this.

Never so much.

Not with the kind of intensity that has your skin crawl under your fur, your palms sweat and itch, your insides twist and the rest of your body thrum with restless energy that can't be contained.

Now, you just want her all the time.

Like... every second of every minute of every hour of every day.

It would be beyond pathetic if it weren't for the fact that it almost physically *hurts*.

There are days when being apart from her becomes almost unbearable.

You feel it keenly, as if a part of your body had been taken from you.

The silver lining in this agony that you have started experiencing on a daily basis? The thing that makes you feel less needy and a lot more blessed and fills you to the brim with relief?

Adora feels the exact same way.

Or so she timidly confesses to you whenever she flings herself into your arms as soon as you step out of a meeting, as if you had been apart for months rather than a few hours.

Or the way she greets you with a deep, passionate kiss, that never fails to leave you dumbstruck and breathless, after you return from a half-day-long travel spent helping Scorpia reclaim her kingdom back in the Fright Zone.

The times you have to split up for days in order to perform your respective duties and take care of both political matters and logistics about rebuilding on opposite sides of the planet, are nothing short than excruciating.

But the distance, for how harrowing, it's also what makes the reunion taste that much sweeter. And you more than make up for the time apart when you find yourselves in bed, taking comfort in each other's arms, and seeking pleasure in each other's bodies.

"I've missed you." She whispers to you one night when you are both back in Brightmoon, your limbs intertwined under the sheets, your bodies - sated and aching exquisitely with exertion of previous, rather enjoyable activities - slotting against each other so perfectly that it's hard to discern where you end and Adora begins. "I never want to be apart from you ever again." She says, breathing the words ever so quietly, as if they were a secret. A wish.

And oh... what a wish it would be.

But that's the cost of victory, isn't it?

It's just wishful thinking, you both know it, hoping that you'll never have to leave this little nest of safety. But there is still so much to do, and more often than not your skills are rarely required on the same kingdom.

"Me neither." You tell her, hugging her close to your chest, gazing out the tall window of your bedroom and willing this night to never end.

She hums and shifts in your arms, burying her face in the crook of your neck and inhaling deeply.

"Heavens." The shiver that runs through her body revibrates within your own when she says, "You smell so *good*, Catra."

You scoff.

Listen who's talking. The one who smells as exquisitely as those vanilla dipped fried dough thingy with the hole in the middle that you've tasted at the town festival shortly after your victory over Prime.

Damn, they were delicious. And you remember the smell of it lingering on your clothes for *days* afterwards.

...huh.

And upon having that thought, your ears swivel up, your eyes widen, and a smile slowly stretches across your face.

"What is it?" She asks propping herself up and eyeing you curiously.

Your smile shifts into a devious little smirk. As simple as it may be..."I think I've got an idea."

. . .

"I know it's not the same thing," You tell her just a few days later when Adora is, yet again, preparing to leave. This time, you'll be the one holding up the fort for the next five days, escorting visiting dignitaries around. "But I believe it may help with... you know." You give a half shrug and scratch self-consciously at the back of your neck, trying not to blush too hard when Adora takes and then *nuzzles* the shirt you have just offered her. The very same shirt you have been wearing while training and running around and *sleeping in* for the past two days in a row.

It should be disgusting, really.

But Adora burrows her nose in it, closes her eyes and inhales deeply, as if she were smelling freshly baked bread and ripe strawberries rather than a mixture of sweat and dirt (and a little bit of morning drool, too) all rolled up together.

For a moment there, as you get suddenly struck by how awfully *disgusting* an idea that was, you start to reconsider what were originally some good intentions, but then...

Then those doubts get completely evaporated into oblivion when Adora opens her eyes again and you see them *shining*.

She still tries to play it cool though (as do you, holding back a satisfied smirk and willing your excitable tail not to give you away). Neatly folding the shirt and placing it into her dufflebag on top of all her clean, perfectly pressed clothes. She zips it closed and then... she launches herself at you, throwing her arms around your neck and hugging you tight.

"Whoa!" You nearly stumble back at the force of the impact, laughing. "Easy there, oh mighty Princess of Power." You tease her, but you are already taking some mental notes.

Because if this is the thank you you'll get, then you should *definitely* gift her less dead birds and *a lot* more dirty laundy.

"I don't have anything to give you, though." She says when she pulls back, pouting, sounding sincerely apologetic and looking oh so disappointed, almost pained at the thought of not being able to reciprocate.

You can't help but grin at her. She is *such* a sweet idiot.

"You kidding? Your scent is all over the bed. And... I haven't sent your spare workout shorts to be washed yet."

Predictably enough, (hilariouly enough) she blushes brighter than a laser beam and splutters, more embarrassed than reprimanding. "Catra!"

"What?" You fold your arms across your chest and fix her with a seductive, challenging look. You simply *refuse* to feel embarrassed by what you have been implying. She just... smells delicious after working up a sweat. And she knows it, too, for you've told her. *Multiple times.*

"You are disgusting." She says, shoving you, but there is still that lovely flush tinging her cheeks and that timid smile curling on her lips. Her eyes crinkled in amusement and shining with affection, so you feel pretty confident when you meet her insult with a shrug and a statement of your own. "You still love me though."

Her eyes grow impossibly soft then.

Like... *Gooey* soft.

It makes your very heart melt inside your chest and the rest of your body turn into jelly as well when she steps closer, nuzzles your nose and whispers against your lips, "I do."

Neither of you seem to care about obligations and time restrictions when one kiss leads to another.

And then another.

And another.

And *another*, followed by roaming hands already busy working on taking clothes off of each other.

You may scar a noisy Swift Wind for life though when he, impatient as he is to get going, for some reason decides that it's safe to fly by your bedroom window to see: "What's the hold up, She-R-*AHHHH!!!! My eyes!!*"

But really, that's *his* fucking fault.

Also. *So* dramatic.

He's already used to having Adora's ass on his back.

So what if he saw it naked, up in the air?

In your opinion, it's a damn fine piece of ass.

. . .

You stumble through the seemingly endless, darkened hallways of the Palace on your way back to your chambers, trying to right one another, giggling all the while and sneaking in a shadowed alcove to exchange heated kisses whenever you come across one. (Which, in your opinion, are far too rare, especially considering how marvelous Adora's lips feel against your neck, where they are keen to keep latching on).

The harvest festival was *fun.*

All the lights, the food, the music, the *dancing*...

...and those frizzy, fruity drinks you had, have contributed in making you delightfully cheery and a lot touchy.

Adora, too. (And she only had one. The lightweight.) Although she is feeling more tonguey than touchy right now.

You tell her as much and she snorts, throwing her head back in laughter, her hair falling down her back like a curtain made of spun gold. Her blue eyes crinkled so prettily at the corners. But what gains your full attention and holds it in a steely grip that also tightens even more viciously around your insides, is the sight of the white, scarred little punctures showing oh so proudly on the side of her neck.

For how breathtakingly stunning she looks in her silky white and gold dress, she wears your mark even more beautifully.

Something inside you preens at the sight of it, your blood roaring in your veins, feeding the flames of arousal already ignited in your belly.

Flames that grow into a full roaring *fire* the moment Adora tilts her head down and meets your gaze once more, her still smiling, earnest eyes so very, very blue. Darkening even further the moment she sees you looking at her *like that*, with a mixture of awe and pure, unadulterated desire.

There is no saying who kisses who first this time, and honestly, it's of little importance. As it becomes everything else in the world the moment your mouths touch, your lips part, and your tongues meet in a deep, warm embrace.

The so-called battle for dominance is more like a half hearted sparring match focused on the elegance of the steps taken rather than brute, careless force, making it all the more enjoyable.

Your heart gives a painfully hard throb and your core clenches on itself, in a way it never fails to do in these circumstances.

She pulls back first, but only to sink her teeth on your lower lip, and the sharp, exquisite sting of pain tears a low, guttural growl from deep within your chest.

A sound so primal that has Adora moan in your mouth and shiver in your arms. Her body - which your hands itch to explore without clothing in the way - arches encouragingly into your touch, and that's all it takes to fuel you with enough strength to pick her up and *stride*, without breaking off your kiss for a second, towards your chambers.

Far more alert than you were but a minute ago, you are extremely careful in not bumping her against the furniture once you get inside, using your slightly impaired yet still heightened senses to orient in the dark. Luckily, you make it to the bed without incidents, and once you settle her down on the mattress, Adora all but *pulls* you on top of her. Another fit of giggles follows suit as you land on top of her, only interrupted when you pull back enough to look at her, because the moment you do, you are left breathless.

The moons are high in the sky, shining through the tall windows, casting long shadows all around and illuminating her face and her hair, fanning onto the sheets, in the most ethereal light.

You gasp.

Your heart stuttering to an halt in your chest at the sight of her, so painfully beautiful and looking up at you with such love and desire.

"You are so beautiful." The words just spill from your lips, a truth that cannot be contained. One of your hands reaching up to trace the contours of her face, mindful of your claws. There is awe in your voice, but also a tinge of the same arousal that is licking hotly at your insides.

For the entire night you have been feeling this... this coil tightening in your lower belly. A gnawing pressure building and swelling and *aching*. Not an unfamiliar sensation for sure, but the intensity with which you have been experiencing it lately has been quite... distracting.

Maybe it was the drinks.

Adora smiles at you. But it's not that timid, sheepish, flustered smile of hers.

This one is heated, paired with pearly white teeth chewing on her lower lip seductively and... and...

With a hand sneaking onto the back of your neck, she decides to forgo words altogether and simply pull you down and into another deep kiss. Effectively interrupting your train of thoughts and directing all your attention on the pressure pulsing in your core, centering between your legs when she wraps hers around your waist, urging your hips together.

Reflexively, you grind against her and she moans, long and deep and unbidden in your mouth.

You do it again, enslaved by that urge, by that pressure seeking an outlet, and in response, Adora rolls hers up to meet you.

Bracing your weight on your elbows at the sides of her head, you slot even more comfortably between her legs and, together, pick up a rhythm that has you swallow each other's moans and groans of pleasure.

Fuck...

You are so worked up already.

And she feels so. fucking. *Good*.

Your head is spinning and your skin is burning under your fur and clothes, which feel utterly unnecessary right now and far too restrictive. Adora must feel the same way about them because her hands slide from your back to the front of your shirt, unfastening the buttons with shaky fingers. You pull back just enough to discard it once she has finished, but it's your pants that are making you the most uncomfortable right now.

That tight, awful pressure that has been coiling in your lower belly and has settled between your thighs has become simply unbearable.

On top of that, it's becoming increasingly difficult to think with the haze of lust that is slowly taking over your mind, plaguing your every thought with a string of images depicting some lewd, mindless, instinctual acts, and... you don't think you have ever felt so needy and *achy* in your entire life.

Your inner walls pulse. Your clit swells and throbs, painfully so, seeking friction. *Release.*

"A-adora..." You stutter when her hands go for your belt next. *Yes!* A voice cheers in your head as you pull away from her and sit back on your haunches to give her more manouvering space, all while helping her peeling off her dress, careful not to accidentally tear it with your claws (for it looks far too lovely on her to be permanently damaged).

The belt is discarded, landing with a satisfying metallic clank on the floor just as Adora lifts her dress off the rest of the way with one hand and pops open the button at the front of your pants with the other. The moan of relief that falls from your lips upon feeling slightly less constricted is absolutely *obscene*, but the last thing you care to feel after releasing such noise, is embarrassment.

As a matter of fact you don't even dare to question the reason *why* it feels like such a blessing having a couple more inches of breathing room. Nor does Adora. At least until she tugs at the waistband of your pants.

You have been feeling so delightfully dizzy, your skin prickling, your fur fluffed, every sense you possess heightened. Your mouth watering with anticipation and the intoxicating scent of Adora's arousal filling the air, fueling your own excitement.

So really, it's remarkable that you are even capable of breathing right now considering the overload of stimulus you are receiving from all sides, so posing yourself questions like *why* some parts of your body feel exceptionally more sensitive right now, seems like a colossal waste of time.

But then again, maybe you should have spared a couple of brain cells and given the thought a bit more priority over the lust burning away in your veins.

Because as soon as your trousers are lowered past your hips you realize that something is, indeed, very, *very* wrong.

As the fabric drags down the top of your thighs, in fact, something bounces free and *slaps*, noisily, against your lower belly.

Your gaze snaps downwards, startled.

You blink.

It takes a moment or two to put into focus and fully comprehend what you are *actually* seeing though.

But when you do, you are so taken aback by the sight of the thick, heavy, *pounding shaft* standing erect between your legs that you shriek and jump an impressive six feet in the air, not so differently than you did that time when Entrapta, the *asshole*, sneaked a cucumber beside you while you weren't looking. (*"For science!"* You remember her saying. *It was pure fucking revenge, that's what,* a part of you growled).

Good thing that the celings of Bright Moon Royal Palace are way higher than that or you would have no doubt knocked yourself unconscious, both back then and right now.

Or maybe you already have, you consider as you land back into the bed, heart racing a lightyear a minute, and stare, wide eyed, in utter disbelief and gaping in absolute horror at the... the *thing* poking out of a furry sheat from your mound. A wide, flared, pink tip pointing straight up to rest against your navel. *Leaking.*

The sight sobers you up in an instant and you do a double take.

There also may be another squeal. Whether it came from you or Adora this time, however, barely seem a detail worthy of importance given the circumstances.

Because really.

What. The actual. *FUCK?!?*

"Catra, w-what... is that?" From her. The shriek came from her you realize, given the uncharacteristic shrill in her voice. But beside the initial yelp of surprise, she seems to be taking this much more calmly than you are, albeit still profoundly confused and more than a little concerned, or so that's how her slightly shaky voice sounds like to your ears. Although, you might be mistaken. What with your head spinning like it is and the incessant pounding of your own heart threatening to burst out of your chest it's difficult to focus. Not to mention the *other*, equally distracting pounding you are currently experiencing.

"I-... I-I don't..." Your mouth opens and closes a few more times but no sound comes out. Nor air comes in. Your throat closes off, contributing to your increasing dizziness.

"Catra breathe!" Adora sounds so distant as she shakes you and gives you that command, which you don't listen to. You *can't.*

And so, instead, gripped by an overwhelming sense of anxiety and fear (and just the right amount of nausea) you do another, different, far more mature and very adult-like thing.

With your pants still lowered to your mid-thigh, you bolt from the bed on all four and scamper off into the bathroom, locking yourself inside.

"Catra!"

Under the loud sound of your thundering, widly racing heart, you can hear Adora stumbling out of the bed in between curses and chasing after you.

"Catra! Wait!" She calls, alarmed, knocking urgently on the door just a few moment later and almost making you jump out of your fur. "Open up!"

"No fucking way!"

"Catra!"

"I'm not coming out!"

Your hands are shaking horribly. Your knees have turned to jelly, and your heart feels like it's about to implode on itself. So you consider it pretty close to a miracle, really, the fact that you manage not only to remember how to breathe, but also how to push the words through the panic swelling in your chest and lodging in your throat, making you tremble all over with cold sweat.

Tears well up in your eyes.

What is happening to me?

Just like when you were a scared little cub hiding away in a dark corner, you find yourself sliding down the door and drawing your knees to your chest, wrapping your arms and tail tightly around them, all while trying to ignore the hard, heavy shaft throbbing insistently between your legs and pressing against your stomach.

It's so uncomfortable that you don't know if the slight nausea that you are feeling is due to that, the general shock of what-the-fuck-is-happening, or... or the fact that you may feel a bit disgusted by your own body right now. Because, for how alien the sight of that... thing... is to you, the sensations attached to it are so very, *very* familiar. Unmistakably so.

"Catra." Adora calls once again from outside, her voice coming out softer, and sounding much closer, as if she herself might be crunching down against the door, and hearing that tone in her voice, paired with how confused and overwhelmed you are feeling right now, is enough for those tears that have pooled in your eyes to start falling once you squeeze them shut.

"Go away Adora!" You yell, wrapping your arms tighter around yourself and burying your face between your bent knees, breathing through your mouth as to not inhale the sharp, musky smell that you recognize as a more pungent, heavier brew of your own arousal.

It's a default mechanism at this point; pushing her away when you need her the most.

You thought you were over it.

You thought you had gotten better at this.

You thought you could *do* and *be* better.

Apparently, you haven't. And you *can't.*

"Catra, *please.*" Her voice is so impossibly soft, pleading, and the muffling of the closed door certainly doesn't prevent your sensitive hearing from picking up the fear in that plea. It makes your heart ache, a part of you so desperate to reach out, longing to console her, but... you can

barely keep yourself together right now. So what good could you possibly be to her when you are falling apart like this?

"Leave me alone, Adora." You repeat, but this time the order lacks its previous bite. As a matter of fact, your voice sounds defeated to your own ears, pitiful really, and that must be the reason why you are not even a bit surprised when, in response to it, you receive a firm, definitive,

"No."

"Adora..." You beg, a sob tearing out of your throat without your consent.

But that only seems to fill her with even more determination.

"I'm not going anywhere." She states, unyelding. Fiercely.

And then, after a beat, softer, so softly it *hurts*... "I'm right here."

You can picture, behind your closed eyelids, with a startling crystal clarity, the way she is pressing her hand against the doorframe as if reaching out for you.

Your resolution crumbles, but some of your hesitation is still standing strong, because for the first time in a long time you are just so-

"I'm scared." You admit, quietly. So quietly and shakily that when you are only met with silence you start to think that she might not have heard you. But then...

"I know." She answers. Just as softly. "I know you are, baby. I don't know what is going on, but... *I'm here.*"

Heavens...

She is, isn't she?

She didn't run away, scared, disgusted, repulsed upon *seeing*-- tentatively, you ease your limbs just enough for you to glance down and... instantly tearing your gaze away, shutting your eyes and swallowing hard.

"Catra?"

Once again, her voice guides you back from your spiralling thoughts, and you cling into it like a lifeline while fighting off another bout of nausea.

She is right here, you repeat to yourself.

She loves you, another voice assures you. *Reminds* you.

"Can you please let me in?"

You think about it for only another handful of moments before reaching up with a shaking hand to turn the key, unlocking the door with a quiet click.

The knob turns ever so slightly but a moment later as she opens it, slowly. You remain on your spot, still drawn tight into yourself, barely daring to breathe as she slips through the gap of the door.

"Hey baby." She greets you, and you can hear the affectionate smile in her voice, just like you can hear the softness of her steps as she quietly approaches you, as if a sudden movement could spook you. In this state, it very much could, but it hardly matters. You have run yourself into a corner by coming here in the first place.

"H-hey Adora." You greet her back, but without even an ounce of your usual cocky playfulness, and the smirk you try to flash her is reduced to a tremulous twich by the fresh tears welling in your eyes.

Almost reflexively so, Adora's own instantly fill up, too.

"Oh, kitten." She whispers, and while you usually would throw her a nasty snarl and be generally put off if not straight out furious by the use of the pet name, this time you can't help but fling yourself in her arms when she crunches down next to you.

She welcomes you with warmth and more love than you feel you'll ever deserve. More than you are worthy of.

"It's okay. I got you, baby." She assures, stroking your back as you choke down your sobs in the crook of her neck.

"I got you." She repeats, carding her fingers through your mane, lightly scratching at the scalp in that way that never fails to soothe you.

Even now.

If you weren't so distraught, you would probably purr.

You spend a minute, maybe more, with your face buried in her neck like that, simply inhaling her scent, focusing on it, on its many layers, willing it to ease your jumbled thoughts.

And who knows, maybe it's because you have always associated it with safety and home, especially lately, but it really seems to be having a soothing effect on your frazzled nerves.

"There you go. Good girl." She praises upon feeling you relax in her arms, and you whimper, sucking in a sharp breath of air through your teeth.

"That's it, deep breaths." She instructs again, and this time you listen, and slowly, but surely, with calm, measured breaths, your heartbeat starts slowing down, too. Settling within a far more acceptable range.

With it, the panic receeds, and the rest of your body stops shaking as much. Even your fur smooths back from where it was still bristled.

"Feeling a bit better?"

Taking in these signs, Adora must decide that it's safe for her to ask a few, tentative (and fortunately) unspecific questions.

"Does it hurt? Do you want me to take a look?"

It does. You think, although it's not exactly pain what you are feeling right now, rather a deep, uncomfortable pressure gnawing at your core. Like an elastic band stretched to its limit, ready to snap. But you lack the eloquence at the moment to properly explain the details to her, not to mention the willingness to do it. And so, you limit yourself to shake your head in negative at her kind, considerate, albeit still terrifying offer.

"Okay." She nods, and you are so grateful to hear the understanding in her voice that you almost burst out crying all over again. "Okay. I won't do anything you don't feel comfortable with. We'll just wait a little until it passes, okay love?"

You don't know if it's *going to pass*, but you find yourself whimpering in affermative anyway, which, luckily, seems to be enough to reassure her.

"Okay then." She repeats, and with that, you become aware of her own body relaxing against yours with her next exhale, which seems to encourage your own muscles to lose some of their tension as well.

It's... hard to explain.

But also so very, very simple.

On an instictual, primal level.

Her presence, her nearness, her *scent* above it all, seem to quiet that same *something* inside you. That wild, feral, hungry part of you that had awakened and has been growling with need this entire time, ever since that first night.

You are far too grateful to feel even just a smidgen of relief that you don't dare question it though. Just relish in the sense of safety that her closeness brings.

She hasn't bothered putting on a shirt when she ran after you, so she is still only wearing her underwear, her bare skin being in direct contact with your fur, and since humans run at a lower temperature than yours, the slight coolness feels nice. Almost a relief.

Instinctively, you find yourself snuggling closer to her and inhaling deeply.

Heavens.

Your stomach clenches on itself with a pang of longing.

Has she always smelled this *good?*

Your mouth waters some more and you find yourself having to swallow down a growl as the shaft between your legs grows even harder, giving a heavy, needy throb, pulsing and aching with pressure.

Trying to ignore it is pretty near impossible, but something about her scent, about the way she holds you, has a way to keep your worries at bay.

Up until Adora makes a tentative, yet midly alarmed observation.

"Catra, sweetie... you are burning up."

You haven't been feeling great, that's for sure. But if a fever is what she is suggesting... You frown.

Now that you think about it, the pads of your hands and feet have been feeling a tad clammy tonight, you are feeling sweaty and nauseaus, although it doesn't seem so different than how you remember feeling the few times you got caught in the clutches of a panic attack. So now that Adora mentions it with such tentativeness, it occurs to you that it could be because you might be actually, truly sick.

The thought startles you and urges you to make yourself even smaller in her arms, wrapping your limbs even tighter around yourself.

"Adora... what is happening to me?" You ask - as if she clearly wasn't as lost and confused by all of this as you are - in such a small, pathetic voice that you can hardly recognize as your own.

"I don't know baby." She admits, sounding so deeply apologetic, almost pained for not being able to provide you with a satisfying answer. "But I'm here with you, okay? You are not alone. I'm here. We are going to find out together, okay?"

You start trembling all over in a cold sweat when you answer her with the most vulnerable question of all.

"You promise?"

You try not to think about the tears that you can hear in her voice and instead focus and draw strength in the determination and commitment of the vow that she makes to you when she answers, craddling you close to her chest and pressing a kiss to your wild, untamable mane.

"I *swear it.*"

Chapter End Notes

What?

You were hoping for an easy and fluffy ride? Nope.
It's all drama with these two. Even boners.

Origins, Designations and Laws of Variation

Chapter Summary

A thorough search for answers bears fruit.

Also, Adora gets four nominations, respectively for: best, most thoughtful, most supportive, and dorkiest girlfriend of Etheria.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Of all the places you thought you had to visit in order to get some answers, (the Palace infirmary wing, the hospital situated in the main village of Bright Moon, that clinic at the edge of the Woods, hell, the Crystal Castle to speak to whatever shattered remains of glitchy hologram was left, or even Entrapta in her new lab filled with all her crazy inventions, scanners, and her AI girlfriend Darla ready to provide any kind of diagnostics - not that you would have ever gone willingly, of course, but still...) a mythical Library allegedly located in the middle of the woods was *not* the place you thought was on top of the list.

And yet, after having made sure you weren't actually sick or suffering from some sort of fever, Adora had decided that this was going to be your next destination.

You may have agreed, sure. Partially because, panicked as you were at the time, you would have agreed to almost anything.

Now that you are approaching your destination however, your hesitation about this whole idea is starting to show.

It's in the uncertainty of your steps.

In the uncharacteristical way you fidget with your hands.

In how your ears remain pinned flat against your head and how your tail twitches nervously behind you.

Signs that are already an alarm bell on their own, but that put together indicate the tumult of conflicting emotions raging within you, which Adora (who has been able to read you with a single glance for as long as you can remember) doesn't take even half a second to spot and recognize when she glances back to see why you have fallen behind.

Just the sight of your posture is enough of a giveaway to make her grind to an abrupt halt.

You are only prevented from colliding against her and sending the both of you tumbling in the dirt because of your impressive reflexes. But even the slight flicker of irritation sparked by her protective, concerned hovering is snuffed in an instant when she simply takes your hands in her own, flashing you that tentative, dorky smile of hers.

"Hey," She says. Her voice so soft and smooth, in a way that weaves in between the cracks of your sudden insecurities, gently tugging at the knots of apprehension tightened in your chest, willing them to untangle.

"I know I said it before, but... We don't have to do this if you are not ready."

You resist the temptation to roll your eyes at her phrasing ("said it before" is a *huge* understatement. She has been saying it almost nonstop ever since you left Brightmoon) but you are unable to smother the smile that tugs at the corner of your mouth in spite of everything.

"Being ready is overrated." You tell her, half joking, gathering a bit of your usual confidence back by shrugging and flashing her one of your trademark, cocky half smirks. "Sometimes you just have to roll with it and see what happens, right?" Not much of a strategy, really, but then again this isn't an attack plan, you don't have to consider the odds in your favor. And you like to think you have grown a bit in the aftermath of the war, enough to attempt to pull some mature shit like this.

Somehow, so far, your willingness to at least *try* has been enough to trick you into compliance.

You take a deep, shaky breath, only realizing that you have closed your eyes in order to center yourself a bit more when you feel a soft squeeze around your hands, prompting them to flutter back open. Once again, you are greeted by the familiar sight of Adora smiling oh so tenderly at you.

No matter how many times a day she has been looking at you like this lately, your heart still manages to stutter within the confines of your chest, skipping a couple of heartbeats only to pick up the rhythm at doubletime a moment later.

"I know you are nervous." She says, barely above a whisper, so quiet that the words get almost swept away by the breeze blowing in the clearing you are standing in. "Honestly I am, too." She adds with a nervous little laugh that reinforces exactly that fact. "But..." She pauses, chewing self-consciously at her bottom lip, running her thumb lovingly over the fur covering your knuckles. "Bow's dads are good people, who happen to know *a lot* of things and who can really help us- help *you* understand what might be going on with you. And I know you are still struggling with trusting people, especially strangers-"

You shuffle in place upon hearing that, glacing downward, trying not to blush for having been caught, for having given away *the reason* behind your reluctance. For being so trasparent about it. But then again, there was no way you could possibly hide your fears from her.

"And while I could tell you that they are trustworthy, I'm not asking you to trust them right away without you making your own opinion first." She continues, and something about the

new firmness in her voice prompts you to lift your gaze from the soft grass at your feet and look at her. "I'm asking you to trust *me*."

Your ears swivel forward. Your shoulders dropping from their previously hunched-over position, the muscles there easing some of their tension.

Oh.

"Can you do that?" She asks, stroking affectionately your hand and giving you a tremulous, yet weirdly reassuring little smile.

This time you don't bother to hide your own when it starts curling on your lips, rolling your eyes and shaking your head, exhaling loudly with pretended exasperation.

"I thought I already did. I mean look at me... traipsing through the grass in the middle of nowhere, with snakes probably lurking in the bushes and all kinds of insects chirping and buzzing all around me."

As if on cue, one of your ears promptly twitches when a nosy bee gets near it, and that's all it takes to make Adora go all *"awww!"* on you.

You grit your teeth and snatch your hands back, clenching them into tight fists at your sides. Because- ugh! *The nerve.*

You are a goddamn *predator*, for crying out loud!

When, indignantly enough, you remind her of this with a low, threatening growl, she simply smiles brighter, her eyes crinkling with authentic amusement at the corners, the blue in them shining in the sunlight so distractingly that you almost miss her answer.

"Well come on then, *Tiger*." She says, flashing you an unmistakable challenging look as she takes a couple of steps backwards. "Show me what you got."

And just like that, as soon as you realize what she has in mind, the worries that have been plaguing you for the past few days seem to melt away in an instant.

"Oh, it's on, *She-Ra*." You taunt her, planting your feet firmly onto the ground, a huge grin taking over your face as you watch Adora getting ready into a proper sprint start. "It's *so* on."

On three, you get on all four and dart off like a bullet. Your paws pounding on the ground, the wind howling past your ears, the cool autumnal air filling your lungs, your blood singing in your veins.

The clearing turns into a meadow that runs past you in an indistinguishable flash of colors.

You throw your head back and laugh and rejoice in the rush of sensations.

It's the most incredible, most freeing, exhilarating feeling in the entire world.

You run.

Carefree.

And faster than you have ever done before.

Your muscles - always supple and action-ready - feel even more springy and reactive. The perception of your own body and its movements far sharper, as if more acutely attuned with your surroundings without you having to put any conscious effort into it.

It comes naturally.

Instinctively.

Perhaps it's just an impression, you think. Attributable to the rush of adrenaline flooding your veins.

Or maybe...

Maybe something *is* changing inside you.

This time, you allow yourself to entertain the idea, unable to find a single reason to be upset by the current circumstances.

Also, you win by a mile. And while Adora - despite still being the overachiever that she has always been - has never beaten you in a race, victory still tastes far too sweet for you to not properly savor it.

You do so by relishing in the pounding of your heart, leaning casually against a tree while inspecting your claws as she approaches a solid five minutes later (two more and you would have turned back to go look for her, but you don't tell her this) simply flashing her an obnoxiously self-satisfied smirk when she finally approaches, out of breath, disheveled, and...

Grinning?

You frown.

It is only when she reaches you and wordlessly takes your wrist to guide you through a thick growth of trees ahead, smiling as if she is the one who has won that you realize... she did.

The trees part and there, standing in the middle of another lush green clearing, is the fabled Library.

Even for you it's hard not to be left at least a little bit in awe by the splendor of the building embraced by vines that stand so tall and majestic in this place as if part of the forest itself.

You look back at Adora, who is still wearing that smug little smile, shrugging nonchalantly as if this was her plan all along; a tactic that she used back when you were kids... and that you should have recognized earlier.

Tricking you with a challenge to get you there before your own insecurities and hesitancy could resurface and make you reconsider this whole thing? You would have thought such

tricks beneath the mighty, righteous She-Ra, but really... you are actually fairly impressed.

You cross your arms over your chest and assess her up and down, from her disheveled hair (which has gotten comically loose in your race, sticking out from her ponytail in all directions) to her grass-stained pants and dirt-covered boots, smirking proudly at her.

Well played, Princess. Well played.

"Perhaps we can make a strategist out of you yet." You tell her while she fixes her hair, and she beams, taking your hand once again and tugging you towards the stairs leading up the front of the Library.

Still, as you reach the top, she pauses.

"You ready?" She asks, because all games aside, your consent means just as much to her as hers does to you, no matter what. And you know that if you would say "no" she would turn around, no question asked, and lead you back home.

But you don't.

It may be scary, but you won't allow fear to dig its fangs into you and consume you like it did that night.

You need answers. And you trust her.

So, you take another deep breath, squeeze her hand back and smile when she leans in to press her forehead against yours.

You draw comfort in her nearness, breathing in the same air for a second, and when you pull back to answer her, your posture is confident and your voice is firm.

"Yeah, I'm ready."

Her answering, proud smile is almost blinding. Warming you from the inside out. And making you believe that for as long as you'll stay in that light, you'll have nothing to fear.

. . .

Lance and George are... not what you expected them to be.

They are not a couple of stuffy, pompous, know-it-all, patronizing old men who tsk at your ignorance and act all haughty.

They don't turn their nose up at you or act as if your presence (a stray, a former Horde Force Captain *scum*) within their precious sanctum is sacrilegious.

They don't make you feel inferior simply because you haven't received a proper education in the Horde. If anything, they are extremely (almost disturbingly so) nice and welcoming (in a way that has you believe they didn't get the memo about that one time you threw their son off a cliff), positively *delighted* upon seeing you (a humanoid felidae hybrid) in the flesh for the first time in their lives, and so genuinely *eager* to help when Adora mentions needing theirs.

No matter how warm their welcome is though, because having to explain *what happened* that night might end up being the most mortifying thing you ever had to do in your entire life, but their earnest kindness and patience put you enough at ease for you to do it.

Luckily, you don't have to go into full details, for they look at you knowingly, already nodding in understanding half-way through your retelling.

"So yeah, it kinda just... uh... *sprung out* from nowhere." You swear to the Heavens above and the Hell below... the temperature in the vast sitting room where you have made yourselves comfortable has increased at the very least by a couple of degrees for how hard you are blushing.

George however - the short haired one of the pair with the neat mustache - simply gives you a warm, reassuring smile. "It's all right, kid." He says. "Nothing to be ashamed of. As a matter of fact, I think congratulations are in order."

Your features scrunch up into a frown then, but before you can ask what he could *possibly* mean by that, Lance - the taller one whose long braided hair kinda reminds you of Lonnie's, and who has also been staring at you, wide eyed, ever since you stepped foot into what is basically their home - straight out *squeals*. The sound so high and squeaky that it tests the integrity of the sound barrier itself.

"I still can't *believe* we are in the presence of a living, breathing *Khajiit*, George!" He gushes, gasping in awe. "Possibly a female Alpha at that too from what they just told us! Do you know how *rare* they were, honey?!"

You are still trying to recover your hearing, but a few words made it past the ringing.

A *Kaj*what-what now? And also... *were*?

You glance at your side to exchange a brief look with Adora, who looks equally perplexed and fascinated by this puzzling new piece of information, before your attention gets once more redirected towards the pair sitting on the couch across from yours, the coffee table in between filled with platters of scones, homemade marmalade, jams, and chocolate-dipped confections that Adora - being the sweet-tooth fiend slash bottomless pit that she is - hasn't shown reservations about trying in various, horrifying combinations. (Seriously, what kind of *monster* puts a spoonful of cherry jam on a smoked salmon scone? You go with the citrus marmalade! And just a thin veil of it. Even *you* know that! Ugh.)

"Lance, darling, please don't scare our guests and settle down." George kindly requests, urging his husband to take a seat beside him.

"I'm so sorry," He apologizes, blushing and rubbing at the back of his neck in a way that reminds you strikingly of Bow when he is acting all self-conscious. Or guilty.

"I'm just very excited. I mean, there haven't been seen any Khajiit on Etheria ever since-"

He cuts himself off abruptly and his expression changes just as suddenly, shifting from bright excitement to sadness to a look of pure grim in the span of a second, diverting his gaze downwards.

"What? What is it?" Adora inquires, leaning forward to perch on the very edge of the sofa, sounding both curious and apprehensive.

But Lance doesn't offer an answer, just a shaky, tentative, apologetic twitch of a smile when he looks up again and his husband fixes him with a hard, reprimanding stare and a subtle shake of his head.

Oookay then.

You are *definitely* going to need to ask about... whatever that was, but... one thing at the time. Which, in your opinion, seems already way more than you can handle.

"I still don't understand what is happening to me." You say, hoping that the urgency and frustration in your voice will be enough to get the two scholars back on track.

Apparently, that's all it takes to spark the light back into Lance's eyes, who claps his hands excitedly. "Then let us explain!" He exclaims while George fondly rolls his eyes at his husband's antics before getting up, stating that they are going to need some tea to go along with the snacks.

As it turns out, given the amount of papers and scrolls and books that Lance goes retrieving all around the Library and lays, with the outmost care, onto a nearby desk, more than tea you could really, *really* use some of Lonnie's clandestine moonshine.

And when a worn page depicting (in the most striking, life-like details) the anatomy of an alien species resembling yourself, you almost choke on your own spit.

Forget about the drink.

You could use a whole damn distillery.

. . .

It shifts from mildly embarrassing and (albeit rarely, thankfully so) downright awkward, but somehow, you manage to make it through the whole sexual education lesson thing perfectly sober.

Lance and George are nothing if not respectful. They never even try to ask you questions, simply laying down the informations for you to pick up. (And the fact that you get the chance to witness Adora also blushing at some of the images depicted in the alien biology book that she has been distractedly leafing through, makes your own embarrassment a lot more tollerable).

For the next hour or so, not only your hosts turn out to be extremely competent in providing you with answers, just like Adora promised they would, but they nearly end up overwhelming your brain with a seemingly never-ending flood of informations.

"So, let's see if I got this right," You summarize at the end of the first hour into your... research, looking at the scrolls and books now taking over the entire coffee table, still trying to wrap your aching, pounding head around most of this. Including subjects like anatomy, biochemistry and sociology. "The bite is what... triggered it?"

George raises his hand and opens his mouth to answer but, once again, his husband beats him to it with his excitement.

"Exactly!" Lance exclaims. "Well... uh, at least partially it did." He amends, deflating a little.

At the look of confusion on your face, George chimes in.

"What he means is that it was not the main cause, but still a powerful one, indeed. You didn't grow antyhing, dear. It was - or rather - it's always been part of you, just... dormant."

You blink.

Huh.

It's... a bit unsettling to think about.

Knowing that you had another appendage inside you this whole time.

"But if the bite isn't the only responsible-" While you are busy trying to sort through the thoughts swimming about in your head, Adora asks one of the questions that are puzzling you the most. "What other cause could there have been?"

All these questions, one on top of the other, would be more than enough to annoy anyone, really.

If anything though, George and Lance look all the more pleased by your mutual curiosity and interest in the subject.

"Ah. That's a great question, isn't it? We don't know precisely, but..." They share a look and nod at each other (in a way that has you wonder, somewhere in the back of your overly crowded head, if this is the kind of bond that you and Adora will have at their age... you so dearly hope so) before turning back to you with a smile. "We might have a theory about it."

. . .

"From what you both told us, you grew up in a military domain that prioritized discipline and order above anything else. Stressful for anyone really, but particularly so for kids, and even more damaging for young adults. Definitely not an enviroment adequate for a young *Khajiit*, whose needs as a species to freely roam the wilderness was only matched by their need for social interactions. Their diet was also very rich and varied, requiring lots of protein and saturated fats, and from what you told us it's not something that ration bars could adequately provide, and that brings me to my next point about malnutrition, which alone can significantly impair hormones production and delay their designated functions. So, because of the conditions you grew up in - which weren't so different from those of captivity - it's possible that the development of some of your body functions had been put on hold during that time."

That... explains a lot.

So much.

Maybe even too much.

Years of hunger gnawing at your stomach at night instantly resurface. Old memories of Shadow Weaver denying you of your meals, of Adora finding out and sharing her rations with you and even going as far as to *steal* them from the kitchens for you when it simply weren't *enough.*

Your fists clench tightly into your lap... only to relax at the feeling of a soft, comforting hand resting upon them and gently prying them open. Your head snaps up and there she is again.

Adora.

Like always.

Providing comfort and understanding with the softest of smiles, with the simplest of gestures.

"It's okay." She whispers, and the sound of her voice is so soothing, the look in her blue eyes so warm and loving. The silent *"I got you"* lurking in them has your tense muscles instantly uncoil.

Slowly, the memories receed, the weight in your chest eases, allowing you to take a deep breath and relax back into your seat.

"I'm sorry," You apologize, both to her and your hosts, who just dismiss your worries with a shrug and understanding smile of their own.

"Like she said, it all right," George assures, "I know this might be like a lot. And we can certainly take a break if you want."

The offer is as kind as it is tempting but... your curiosity and the urgency of those questions in your head craving an explanation has the better of you.

"No, I'm okay." You assure them all, but especially Adora, flashing her a smile and squeezing her hand for good measure before turning your attention back to George and Lance. "Please, continue."

Lance wheels over a chalkboard then, where he draws a pyramid, separating it in five horizontal sections.

The three on top remain blank.

"You see, Catra..." He says, while writing something on the two sections at the bottom. "We believe that up until a few months ago you have lived your entire life in this area of primary needs right here. Or, well... at least your body certainly has been forced to."

When he has finished writing you squint and read to yourself, "...safety and physiological needs?"

"They are the so-called base needs." George explains. "Food, water, shelter, rest... Back in the horde your body may have started prioritizing your survival, allowing you to develop the skills necessary to ensure that. And for how controversial it may sound, it actually makes sense, in an evolutionary way, that your reproductive system would grind to a halt and fall behind if it meant using the energy reserved for that process to develop and enhance the primary skills that would give you a better chance."

Where he ends, Lance picks right up.

"So, if we had to come up with a fairly logical theory about the reason for your change - beside the bite, I mean, it may be directly linked to your lifestyle improvements. It could be related to the fact that you feel safe now, and I mean actually *safe*, no longer living under the terror of whatever kind of punishment would be inflicted upon you by the system that raised you."

Part of you, that same proud, stubborn part of you that wants to deny ever been afraid of anything or anyone, *aches* to do so, but... you'll have to conceed that he definitely has a point there. They know what they are talking about, and if it makes you feel vulnerable well... you are starting to learn that it may not be such a bad thing as the Horde made it up to be. It doesn't feel much like a weakness. Especially not when Adora is right there with you, providing comfort with a simple look and the solid, warm, grounding feeling of her hand into yours.

And so, you let them continue.

"You are better fed and sleep more regularly- as George implied, an adequate nutrition can definitely be enough to trigger a proper hormone production, hence kickstart your reproductive system. But beside the biological factors there are also the sociological ones at play. Meeting different people of different species and origins outside those you have only known for your whole life could be considered an important change that requires certain kinds of adjustment and adaptation from your body, too. Things like pheromones perception and production, to which most sentient species inhabiting Etheria are totally oblivious about, lacking the adequate receptors, but that you, a *Khajiit*, are definitely more sensitive to."

Again, it's... *a lot*. But all he's saying makes also perfect sense to you, instantly remembering how overwhelmed you felt upon first arriving at Brightmoon. And apparently, there were other reasons at play beside your own sins and guilt trying to chase you away and preventing you from interacting with *anyone*.

Luckily, your hosts kindly let you absorb this ephyphany you just had for a few minutes before continuing.

"In conclusion," Lance says, "I personally think - and I also believe that a doctor would confirm - that in these special circumstances the bite might have kickstarted the process on its own, and your body has responded with the hormonal cascade that followed such act; the very meaningful, very profound one of.... uh... staking your claim on your chosen mate."

Your heart stutters out of rhythm.

And your face grows suddenly very, very warm.

"Mate?"

This time it's George who answers you, smiling broadly, which makes your blush feel even warmer.

"That's right. It can be a pretty powerful factor on its own, as you yourself have found out. And it was well-known that a mating bite exchanged between mates, especially between species with enhanced senses, can induce a series of substantial changes."

Adora (bless her heart) either takes pity on your stunned speechlessness, or is simply feeling brave enough to ask the million coins question on her own.

"What does this mean exactly?" (You don't miss the slight shakiness of uncertainty that weaves in her voice though).

"It means that having achieved the primary needs of safety, shelter, proper nutrition and now even love and belonging, it's quite possible that Catra's body might have started producing all the right hormones to ensure that, were you to chose so, you'd be able to meet what is considered one of the highest priorities among any species. A biological imperative."

You swallow, hard. Your entire face now ablaze, your throat dry and scratchy, and yet, this time you manage to at least stutter a couple of words, "Y-you mean..."

George and Lance answer at the same time.

"Procreating."

"Mating!"

In the few instants that follows, in a *completely* unrelated way, your mind wanders back to that theoretical, pseudoscientific concept that Entrapta randomly shared with you that one time about spontaneous combustion.

Well, your local mad scientist Princess will definitely be *delighted* to know that it ain't a theory no more.

And, fortunately, judging by the very similar way Adora's usually pale, fair and delicate complexion flares up like a red chilli pepper dipped in tomato sauce the moment your gazes meet before instantly darting away, you aren't the only one experiencing such a phenomenon.

You sure as hell aren't scholars but you both kinda *knew* - or at the very least *suspected* - what all of this was about, and yet, having the fact laid out in front of you with nothing in between is... a bit frightening.

You reach for your previously untouched, sweaty glass of lemonade and down it as if you had spent a month crawling through the Crimson Waste. The coolness of the drink soothes your inexplicably parched throat, but it does nothing to put out the fire of awkwardness burning you from the inside out for thinking about the implications of what they said now that you are fresh out of an extensive biology class.

Good Heavens.

The sound of amused, fond chuckling mercifully tears you away from your thoughts before they can become any more... inappropriate.

"It's all right, kids. No need to panic." Lance says, far too casually. "Just because your body is going into overdrive with a cocktail of hormones it doesn't mean that you are in any rush to do anything you aren't both comfortable doing yet, all right? What you should keep in mind though, it that bite is going to affect both of you. And according to the data we have collected over the years on the subject, it's going to create a very powerful, magnetic pull between the two of you."

Stronger than the one we already have? You want to ask, but something inside of you doesn't allow you to, holding you back.

The fear of ruining it perhaps?

Given your track record, that sounds like a plausible fear.

But what Lance said resonates within you, a truth and an unspoken rule that you have already embraced without a second thought and with your entire being.

Because even if your reproductive system has suddenly decided to wake up and join the party, even if it thinks that mating is a priority for you right now, an obligation your very DNA demands you adhere to, you simply *refuse* to be bullied into submission by your own damn body.

You are ready to disregard that pull, no matter how powerful and overwhelming it is and might become. Even though you remember the compulsion you experienced that first night when you sank your fangs into Adora's neck. How glorious and *right* it felt. How dizzy the rush of possessiveness for claiming her had left you.

...fuck.

This is going to require *a lot* of self restraint and discipline.

"We can provide you with further material if you want. Including cerimonial and mating rituals, specifically how Alphas interact with their chosen mate, what are their duties, the importance and significance of the mating bite, and how it affects the people involved. As I said before, and luckily for us, the Khajiit- or more commonly "Magicats" as Etherians used to call them - were a very proud species, deeply committed in preserving their history and culture, so we do have some records that can be helpful."

Once again, your mind grinds to a halt upon hearing that word.

Khajiit.

...strange.

All your life spent without meeting any other one of your kind, knowing nothing of your origins, and now... you do. Only to learn (when you gather enough courage to swallow down your nerves and ask about it) that the Horde had exterminated their settlement during a purge, about twenty years ago or so.

It surprises you, how deeply, genuinely pained Lance and George seem as they speak of this event. But then again they have shown to be quite compassionate about many things. And firmly against violence of any kind.

A lump lodges itself in your throat at the end of their tale, even though it shouldn't... right?

You knew what the Horde did, what has done. You knew what they were capable of. You were *a part of it* for crying out loud! Learning that it has been the responsible for the extinction of an entire species shouldn't be so shocking.

...or upset you in such an unexplicable, profound, visceral way.

You glance at your side, once again drawn to Adora for guidance when in doubt regarding how you are supposed to feel about something like this, and... the shimmer of tears that you find in her eyes, the deep sadness pooled in them, the way she bites on the inside of her cheek like she often does when trying not to cry, speak on their own.

If she feels pain about it, then you are more than allowed to, also.

Knowing you are possibly the last of your kind, the sole survivor of a merciless attack ordered by the very same military force that "adopted" you afterwards and trained you to perpetuate the circle of violence and death and destruction is... well... disconcerting.

And fucking *enraging*.

You clench your hands into fists, digging your claws into your palms.

It would be so *easy* to give into it. To get swallowed by the grief and injustice of it all, to lose yourself into a fantasy entitled "how things would have been different if only..."

But... another look towards Adora, another plunge into the deep pools of endless blue that you find staring right back at you, is all it takes for you to have yet another epiphany.

She lays a hand on top of yours, as if to solidify that thought, and your fists unclench.

The beast of anger stirring inside you gets instantly subdued.

Because a very, very similar thing also happened to her, too.

You were both used as tools. You were both orphans. First from parents, and now, from species, too. Possibly the lasts of your respective kinds.

And yet, you are not alone.

You have never been, you realize as you clasp your hands together, intertwining your fingers with no words exchanged but all the understanding and need for comfort passing between the two of you with nothing but a single, meaningful look.

Taking in a deep breath, you center yourself, releasing the rest of your hurt and anger with your next exhale.

There are still so many questions buzzing in your head.

Possibly as many as the answers that George and Lance have patiently provided you with, often without you having to ask them either.

But you don't quite know how to feel about any of this right now beside overwhelmed. And so very, *very* tired.

Luckily, once again, Adora sees right through your speechlessness and takes it in stride.

"This is a lot to process. But we thank you for all your help," She says, smiling warmly. "It's been... priceless."

"Yeah," You croak, blinking back into focus and managing a small, shaky, yet sincerely grateful smile of your own. "Thanks, guys."

They beam and you are once again struck by how much Lance's smile looks like Bow's.

They escort you back to the entrance, and while Adora is busy updating Lance on Brightmoon's welfare, as well as his son's and Glimmer's, George comes closer to you and places a warm, solid hand on your shoulder. Paired with that gentle look in his eyes and that same, equally kind smile, it feels... oddly comforting. In a way that makes you think about all the ways that things could have been different if you ever had a parental figure like him in your life.

But that's a dangerous thought that is best dismissed as soon as it springs up. Better not to dwell on.

Although one truth remains, standing as strong as ever.

Bow is *so* lucky.

"You got nothing to worry about, kid." He assures, so calmly, in a way that has your lingering fears seem a bit smaller, a lot less threatening in front of that earnest smile. "I have dedicated my entire life trying to understand some of the mysteries that surround us by gathering knowledge of species who have inhabited Etheria at some point of another in hystory, trying to find a link, something that binds us all, and the only thing I have found out so far, is that the Universe simply loves diversity. It can't functions without it. And while I can understand that all of this - how are you feeling and the way your own body is changing - is new and fightening, you have to know that you don't have to be scared by change."

The tone he uses, the words he chooses... It's probably the nicest, most kind, earnest, comforting and respectful way that anyone has ever spoken to you in your entire life.

And for the first time, you don't feel ashamed or betrayed when a single tear escapes, leaking from the corner of your eye. It disappears instantly however, swallowed by the thin layer of fur covering your cheeks, but the feeling is still there, like a gaping hole in your chest. Like a wound that is no longer bleeding yet waiting to be tended.

George smiles again and tilts his chin to where Lance and Adora are still talking animatedly and laughing just a few feet away.

"You have a lot of people now who care about you." He reminds you before throwing you a wink. "And a mate that clearly loves you very, very much."

Your heart skips a beat.

Mate.

Make it two beats. Because while the act itself may have been caused by blind urge and instinct, you know the intricacies of what that means now.

And holy shit...

Adora is *your mate.*

Yours.

As if on cue, the sound of your lover's dorky, snorting laugh draws yours attention back to her.

Blue eyes find your mismatched ones and, instinctively, as it often happens when you are feeling so vulnerable, her body seems to instantly gravitate towards yours.

You shouldn't be, but you are still struck with a bit of surprise when you find her still there, by your side, smiling warmly at you with those stunning, deep blue eyes of hers, and her hand slipping into yours to give a strong, reassuring squeeze.

"It's all going to be okay." It promises. *"I'm right here."* It assures. *"I love you,"* It reminds you. And also, most shocking of all, the shimmer in her eye that you have learned to mean, *"I'm so proud of you."*

And for the first time in a while, thinking back about how you have acted and reacted today about all the informations that you have received, about all the facts you have learned, being brave and stepping out of your comfort zone by asking some very humiliating questions for the sake of understanding... you may be feeling quite a bit proud of yourself, too.

When you leave the library you feel lighter, somehow. Well, methaphorically speaking at least, because Lance and George have insisted in lending you a pile of books on your... species' culture, history and what little they have managed to scape together about biology and anatomy. Some of it is almost indeciphrable, but still... the fact that they were so genuinely willing to help, to the point of trusting you with a piece of the treasure they have been protecting for decades...

You'll have to think of a nice way to properly thank them.

Possibly something more than a dead rat at their doorstep.

...maybe a Capybara. You think you have seen some around earlier.

You make the mistake of asking Adora what she thinks about it and she almost trips over herself, gasping outrageously and looking utterly *horrified* by the suggestion.

"What?" You asks, nonplussed.

"Well you can't!" She splutters indignantly.

You are about to ask why but... you know what is coming next even before she says it, recognizing the way her eyes sparkle and light up. "They are so *cute*!"

Oh for the love of-

Ugh.

Having long decided that it is utterly *pointless* trying to make her see reason on the subject, you simply growl to yourself and stalk in front of her, effortlessly balancing the priceless books in your arms and speed walking ahead, leaving her to her own idiocity and lack of coordination as she tries to both balance her own pile of books and catch up with you.

It must be a fur thing, you think.

And that's enough for you to spend the rest of the walk home entertaining the oh-so-tempting thought of shaving yourself down to your skin just to prove a point.

. . .

Okay. So *maybe* it's not a fur thing, *exclusively*.

I mean... she doesn't have any, you reason, and yet that's the first word that springs in your mind on multiple occasions during the next few days whenever you find Adora hunched over the books you have brought back from the Library with single minded purpose, a look of intense focus in her eyes and determination setting her brow as she mercilessly attacks knowledge from every front.

You forgot how... how utterly *adorable* she looks when she is studying. When she is so focused and committed to something with her entire being.

She even goes as far as to try and determine to which clowder- which *tribe* you might have belonged to by searching into the records for descriptions of stripes similar to the ones adorning your arms, legs and back.

The pout that shapes her lips when she can't find anything about it is... the *cutest* thing you have ever seen.

Yep.

There.

You said it. But really, there is no other word for it.

And you simply can't help but smile at the sight.

The tip of her tongue pokes out the corner of her mouth, her blue eyes narrowed with intent, an errant strand of hair that keeps falling down to tickle her face and she keeps on blowing up until she has had enough and decides to gather it on top of her head in a messy bun, sticking a pencil in it to hold it in place before returning to her reading.

And the fact that she is doing it for you, to know you, your origins, and your (changing) body better, fills you to the brim with a warm tingling feeling that centers itself in your chest.

You help her organize the books by stacking them ordinately and by category, on one of the shelves hung above the desk.

Some of them are scrolls and, puzzling enough, written in First Ones' languange.

You frown as you unroll one, turning it over in your hands as if that will help you make any more sense of the jibberish of lines and dots that look a lot less like a language and a lot more like a map of sorts.

"Why do you think the First Ones were studying my people's physiology and anatomy?" You ask, handing her over the scroll. She takes it and examines it, equally puzzled.

"I don't know. But we have to keep in mind that, originally, the First Ones came here to study and find a way to harness the planet's magic, so it's possible that they may have also gathered informations about all of the species inhabiting Etheria at the time."

That's... actually a pretty smart observation.

You tell her as much and she blushes a bit, tilting her head down and tucking yet another unruly strand of golden hair behind her ear.

"Just spit balling." She shrugs as if it was nothing, rolling up the scroll and twisting it nervously in her hands. And damn it... She does look cute when she is all flustered like this. Terribly so.

You ought to think of ways to elicit this reaction more often.

But there is another thing you must do first.

"Thank you."

Her gaze snaps up, eyes wide with surprise, and a single crease furrowing her brow. "For what?"

"For... you know." *Introducing me to Bow's dads. Putting all the effort you do in trying to learn about my origins and what is happening to me...* but mostly- "For being here with me and doing all of this for me." *like you promised,* you don't say, but something in the way you look at her in the following moment must still convey that last thought, because Adora looks at you with such a softness in her eyes and an even softer smile.

"Of course." She says, setting the scroll in the "to be translated pile" side of the desk, in order to take your hands in hers.

"Catra I already told you we would be doing this together, and I meant it."

Your heart throbs at her words. Painfully so.

Heavens... you love her. *So much*.

"We could study together if you'd like." She suggests kindly, her entire face lighting up at the idea, and its so damn endearing that your inside threaten to melt.

Not yet accustomed to the feeling of such tenderness that (for how much you are starting to associate it with something pleasant and right instead than vulnerability and weakness) still leaves you squirming a bit uneasily on the spot, you take her thoughtful offer as your chance, for you are in desperate need to regain your cool and collected composure back.

"Well, I guess I could use to learn a bit more about anatomy." You tease, but the striking realization of *what* you just said hits you so hard and suddenly that it slaps the smirk right off

your face, replacing it with a look of pure mortification.

You. *Idiot!*

Up until a week ago you wouldn't have had *any* problem making an insinuation like this. But now...

Your eyes widen in horror, your mouth falls open in speechless shock, while Adora's face turns into a radioactive hue of red.

Panicked, you jump a step away from her and raise your hands in front of you, waving them frantically and spluttering incoherently, desperately trying to backpedal.

"I-I didn't mean- I was just- I didn't *think* of the- I wasn't trying to *imply*-"

Dammit! May the floor open up and swallow you whole already to put you out of your misery! Heavens know it's happened before! Like... Multiple times!

Oh boy...

This is a *disaster*.

You were just making a stupid, dumb joke without *thinking* about these rather new circumstances.

Hopefully she knows that you weren't propositioning *anything* whatsoever. Because you *weren't*.

A part of you wants to reassure her of that in case there were any doubts about what you meant, but... if the warm, tight pressure that is starting to build in your lower belly and the stirring that you feel at the front of your trousers at the *mere thought* of how Adora *might* have interpreted your words now that you possess a tiny bit more of knowledge regarding your... additional appendage and have the confirmation of its intented purpose... it appears that you are going to have another problem in your hands to deal with. Like... very, very soon. (And possibly quite literally, too.)

There is not willing it away, unfortunately.

And so, wisely choosing to take *that* as your priority (not even wanting to *think* about the possibility of Adora taking notice of *it* after making a fool of yourself in such a spectacular manner), you grab your jacket from where it's hanging on the back of a chair and drape it over your forearm, holding it in front of you (in what you do your best to make it appear a casual gesture) loudly announcing your imminent leave.

"Gotta go!"

That seems to snap her back from whatever trance she has been stuck in.

"W-wha-? Catra wait!"

But you most certainly *can't.*

"I got a prior commitment I almost forgot about. With.... uh..." Think, think fast you perverted *dumbass.* Something not sexy. Something the very opposite of sexy. Like Glimmer's stupid shrill voi-*oh!* "Glimmer! T-that's right. Counsel duty calls! B-but I'll catch up with you later, yeah? Love you! Bye!"

You don't quite know if she buys the lie. Being a well-known awful liar herself she might be oblivious to it, or maybe just too confused by your barely coherent vomit of words and abrupt announcement to linger on your poor, pathetic (yet plausible, given your current role and duties here at the Palace) excuse.

You don't care to stay a second longer to find out though, that's for sure.

So, before she can get any closer, and before she can say another word, for the second time in a week, you dart off like a coward, sprinting out of the room and down the seemingly endless hallway of your floor on all fours, searching for an unlikely place to hide. Even if the temptation to throw yourself off the nearest balcony and jump straight into the river instead is pretty damn strong.

Who knows, maybe the cold water will wash away the *filthy* thoughts that are filling your mind right now. Or you'll simply drown. Which doesn't seem like such a bad alternative at the moment.

Ugh.

So much for your vow about acting mature and in control.

Chapter End Notes

Yes... I borrowed the Khajiit from The Elder Scrolls because I personally find "Magicat" to be kind of a dull and terribly unimaginative term, and an awesome character like Catra can't be associated with any of those things (also she bloody *deserves* a proper name for her species rather than two words smashed together imho) but mostly, I may have decided to swap it because... I'm just a massive nerd.

Seriously. It can't be helped.

Anyway, be a little bit more patient with Catra here. She is still adjusting to these new changes and learning how to deal with troublesome, untimely boners.

But don't worry. She'll cum around soon enough.

Effects of Habit and the use or disuse of Parts (Part 1)

Chapter Notes

Chapter picks up right after the end of the previous one.

Major warnings for Catra acting like a panicking, hormonal dumbass.
(And for a little bit of sexy stuff, too. Just a taste though).

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There must be a limit, you believe, to the amount of embarassment and humiliation that a person can endure.

And given how often such feelings have repeatedly assaulted you in the past week, merciless in the ferocity of their attacks, you can't help but wonder - as ridiculous as it may sound - if dying of shame might be an actual thing.

Heavens know you have toed the threshold enough times as of late to last you a lifetime already.

Not wanting to tempt fate and find out for yourself the answer to that particular question by possibly colliding with someone- *anyone*- along the hallway and make your current state known throughout the Palace in a matter of minutes (seriously, gossip spreads like wildfire between these gilded walls), you end up hurrying your pace and opening a random door, which, luckily, happens to lead you into some sort of musty utility closet and not a meeting room full of self-important dignitaries.

Good enough.

You close the door tightly behind you and lean heavily against it, trying to catch your breath and willing your racing heart to slow down, all while urgently fumbling with the buttons of your pants before the pounding pressure between your legs may threaten to burst them open on its own.

Stupid hormones.

Stupid urges.

Stupid sexy thoughts swimming about in your head and addling your poor perverted brain.

But most of all... *damn* these tailored trousers!

They may hug your long, lean legs in the most tantalizing, flattering way and make your ass look like the work of art that it is, but *why* all these fucking *buttons?!*

(Ugh. You are going to have *words* with the Palace's appointed tailor).

Finally, after what feels like a short eternity, the last one pops open and you almost sob with relief.

The tiny room is dark, but not dark enough to prevent you from seeing the throbbing erection that instantly springs free.

It bobs briefly in the air before coming to rest against your lower belly. You glare at it. The broad, flared tip pointing straight towards the ceiling. Leaking expectantly.

You groan. Banging the back of your head against the door, closing your eyes and taking in a deep breath, expanding your lungs to full capacity and holding it, willing your racing heart to slow down and your hands to stop shaking as you exhale.

Easier said than done, but the bright side is that at least you are not suffering from a panic attack this time, not like that first night. You are simply feeling *slightly* overwhelmed at the moment is all, and (in your defense) for good reasons. Namely- the mortification you suffered a minute ago back in your chambers with Adora, paired with the slight annoyance towards your... *thing*... having a mind of its own.

Knot. Your brain promptly supplies, but instead of feeling further annoyed by the spontaneous suggestion, you actually find remembering the details you have absorbed in the past few days of research to be somehow helpful- like a tiny flicker of light guiding you back to reason, reminding you that you don't have to be scared. That all of this is perfectly natural, and that you are simply adjusting to find your new balance ...and self control.

Strangely enough, instead of making you feel weak and powerless, the thought gives you comfort.

Your next deep breath serves its purpose, helping your stiff muscles lose some of their tension and tricking you into making you feel a little more in control. You don't care that it's a trick though, you still take the momentum of such chance in stride.

And so, feeling a little bit braver and made a little bit bolder by the knowledge that you now possess... you gather the confidence to look down again.

Here we go.

Despite its proclivity for literally *popping up* whenever it pleases, your knot is... *not* as intimidating or threatening as that night it made its first appearance.

As a matter of fact, now that you look at it knowing what it actually is and what purpose it serves... it seems pretty harmless. (But that, you guess, may depend on the points of view).

Sorta funny-looking, too.

But also... kinda fascinating.

Like- anatomically speaking, *of course.*

The tip - broad, flared and rosy (an extension of your own clitoris) is gleaming with the slick dribbling from the little slit situated at its center.
The shaft stretching below- tinged just a few shades paler - smooth towards the base (where your outer lips stretch to accomodate it) and surrounded by some interestingly shaped ridges circling the underside of the first half - is *thick*. Thicker than your wrist. And painfully *hard.*

It feels heavy.

Full.

Straining helplessly with pressure in the cool musty air of the closet.

And when, tentatively, you wrap your fist around its even thicker base (about half an inch above the little pouch of skin surrounding it that would be the knot proper, now deflated) barely managing to close your hand around its generous girth, you can feel it pulsing with its own heartbeat.

You squeeze experimentally and instantly groan, your stomach muscles clenching as it gives a heavy, needy twitch, dribbling some more clear fluid from its slit.

You may not be used to it yet, but the way it responds and makes you feel is unmistakable. As it has been ever since that very first night. You were just too shaken and panicked to properly acknowledge it.

But now... You swallow. *Now* you only hesitate for a moment, mostly in order to brace yourself before dragging your fist up its length, slowly stroking it from base to tip and-

"O-oh, *fuck!"*

Another stab of pleasure pierces through your belly. Hot and searing. Your core clenching and spasming so viciously that the sensation knocks the air out of your lungs.

Fuck! You curse again, panting and sucking in a much needed, shaky breath.

You glance down and watch, mesmerized, as another spurt of clear fluid erupts from the sensitive tip, sliding down its ridged underside and running down your knuckles.

Fuck.

You close your eyes, breathing shakily and repeating the movement, just as slowly, but applying a little more pressure as you reach the tip and-

Oh.

O-oh.

The ache in your belly sizzles, flares, and when you swipe the pad of your thumb over the flared head to gather the wetness pooled there, you almost bite off your own tongue in order to muffle the whimper of pleasure that swells in your throat.

Heavens above.

It feels good.

So good.

You sink your pointy fangs into your bottom lip, almost hard enough to pierce the skin and draw blood, feeling awfully torn between your own doubts and hesitation and the need literally throbbing in your hand.

(There is no question about which one between the two wins in the end, though.)

You sigh in defeat.

It appears that your first anatomy lesson is going to be a solo session. As it probably should be, you think, to allow you to get more... *familiar* with your new equipment.

And yet, as you close your eyes and slowly, experimentally, start touching yourself - here, in the dark, tiny confines of a stuffy supply closet among mops and brooms and (no doubt) spiderwebs (and their eight legged inhabitants lurking *somewhere*), trying to find out how much pressure to apply and how your body responds to different strokes and changes of rhythm - you feel anything but alone.

Despite your initial effort to focus on the physical sensations alone, as it often happens whenever you find yourself taking care of such a need, it doesn't take long for your mind to get flooded with images of Adora.

Only this time you are not blessed with a memory of her naked, writhing on the sheets, with that blush warming her face and traveling all the way down to her heaving chest as you lap languidly at the raw honey pooling between her legs. Her hand in your mane, her abs flexing with each roll of her hips as she chases after the warmth of your mouth, the swirl of your tongue...

No. This time, for some blasted reason that goes *completely* against the way your body is supposed to help you along in order to get the relief it's obviously craving and seeking, your brain decides to provide the image of how you last saw her but a few minutes ago.

Specifically, the look that she gave you before you left.

The way she reached out for you.

The initial speechlessness giving away to the confusion etching on her lovely features, and-

"Catra, wait!"

The hint of *fear* in her voice.

...the look of *hurt* in her eyes.

Yours snap wide open in an instant, a gasp tearing out of your lungs as your heart leaps right in your throat, hammering away with apprehension.

The warm sizzle of pleasure that was starting to unfurl from that tight coil settled deep in your belly and that was beginning melt into liquid fire gets suddenly cooled by another, unforgiving feeling that turns out to be ten times more effective than taking a plunge into a frozen lake.

Guilt.

It assaults you out of nowhere. More vicious than ever, having caught you (literally) with your pants down.

It sinks its claws right into your chest. Digging deep, seeking its beating target and *twisting*, mercilessly, the moment it finds it.

That first blow is fatal enough to cripple you.

You simply can't battle against it, least of all hope to emerge victorious from a fight against such a formidable adversary.

And the worst thing about it?

The facts won't even allow you to try and fight in the first place. They won't even allow you to *defend yourself*.

The truth is plain and simple:

You left Adora.

Again.

You *lied* to her and then *left her*. Alone. Confused. Most likely worried.

You left her despite *knowing* how fast she tends to spiral.

The tears welling up in your eyes, completely unbidden and blurring your vision shouldn't be so unexpected considering the ache that you just felt digging in your chest at the realization.

You swipe at them angrily with the back of your... unoccupied hand.

Damn hormones, you sniffle.

Making you all emotional and shit.

But you can only blame them so far.

And no amount of panic could ever justify you for making the choice you made by running away the way you did.

Like a fucking coward.

The thoughts and guilt laced so intrinsicaly to them are more than enough to sober your lust-addled brain and make the shaft in you fist lose some of its firmness.

It's nowhere near soft, and a long way from retreating completely, but the gnawing need that was there just a minute ago, the flames that had been licking so tentalizingly at your insides, have been snuffed out, leaving room for another urge to take over. Less primal, but still quite visceral.

Suddenly, embarrassment and humiliation don't seem like anything more than just words compared to the thought that flares in your mind of Adora, back in your chambers, looking confused and worried and - worst of all - feeling possibly *rejected*, when she has been nothing but patient with you, and so, so deeply understanding and comforting and loving and-

That's enough.

That final thought is enough to sober you up for good.

It's enough to convince you to remedy this mess that you have created. To go back and fix it before the light crack that you have caused with your hasty, foolish departure can grow into a yawing chasm.

You won't allow it.

And so, finally deciding to be true to your word, you exercise some of your (seriously lacking) self control and maturity.

Just because you are no longer as hard as a steel rod though it doesn't mean that the process is any less harrowing or even made slightly more comfortable, because it *isn't*, but with a bit of manuvering you manage to tuck yourself away, adjusting your clothes the best you can in order to conceal the swell showing at the front of your pants and sucking in a deep breath of musty air before exiting the closet, setting your jaw, squaring your shoulders and straightening your back, striding down the hallway with determination, holding your chin high and ignoring the prickling of tears forming in your eyes or the way your heart aches and stutters with apprehension at the thought of what is going to happen next.

You just suck it up and keep going.

Because you might even be going through a late puberty of sorts, but it's about damn time you stop making Adora suffer for all the times you keep acting like a child, and start acting like a fucking adult instead.

You owe her that much.

And... you believe that you owe it to yourself, too.

. . .

When you enter your chambers again, it is with the nervous sort of hesitancy that would have anyone believe you were intruding into someone else's room. You try not to think about how true such assessment feels like under the current circumstances and instead slip inside, making as little noise as you can.

It really says a lot the fact that Adora (who is always alert, always vigilant, even in rest, even without a war to fight or enemies lurking about) doesn't move an inch from where she is sitting, at the edge of the bed, her shoulders hunched, her hands folded around the spine of a book resting in her lap, her gaze vacant (in a way that has the serrated blade of guilt twist in your stomach some more) only glancing up in your direction when you, with your heart stuck in your throat and that same shakiness affecting your limbs, click the door shut.

Her head snaps up. And a pair of wide blue eyes pin you in place.

"H-hey Adora." You greet her.

The look that crosses her features shifts from surprise to confusion in the span of a second, only to settle on pained the next.

"Catra..."

It's like getting sucker punched right in your solar plexus.

The way her lips part to breathe your name, almost in disbelief, is what threaten to break the dam you have managed to keep intact during your walk back. But it's also what propels you forward before she can stand, a gust of determination making you cross the room in barely three strides without you even realizing it, dropping on your knees in front of her and - even though you feel like you have no right to after the way you left - reaching up with one hand to tangle your claws in her gorgeous, loose, silky golden hair and pull her down.

It's a strange sensation the one that stirs inside you the moment before your lips are about to touch.

Like a cold disembodied voice whispering from the back of your head, *hissing* that you don't deserve to touch her, nor kiss her after what you did, but you need it, for it is the only way you can properly convey how deeply sorry you are, and for her to understand how much it has pained you what you have done. Because after all that has happened between the two of you, it's no longer simply about the fact that you *left*. The panic that had surged through you earlier simply hadn't allowed you to consider the consequences of such a seemingly harmless and impulsive act. Which only makes you feel like an even bigger, class A *idiot* right now.

Hopefully, you aren't too late to remedy your idiotic mistake.

Despite the rush and impulsiveness with which you have pulled her towards you, your lips press ever so softly against hers, and if the light gasp that she emits and the way she tenses up at the contact are of any indication, then she clearly wasn't expecting it.

The only thing that keeps you from tearing yourself away from her with the sudden spike of fear that pierces through you at the thought of the gesture being unwelcomed though, is feeling her melt a little against your lips in the second that follows. Instinctively (and also unsurprisingly) your own body reacts in a similar way.

She reaches up with one hand to rest it against your jaw, but you don't give her the chance to return the kiss (were she about to, anyway). For you still don't feel worthy of reciprocation. Not without you explaining your actions first. And so, acting against what every fiber of your being is telling you, you pull away, and look up at her.

"I'm sorry."

As soft and innocent as the kiss was, it had visibly left her a bit dazed, you take notice, unable to smother the spark of delight that flickers inside you at the realization, nor the light curl of a smile that twitches on the corner of your mouth. But all changes in the moment you apologize.

She gasps. And her eyes, still a little dialated and wide, grow even wider at your next plea.

"Please forgive me."

Her lips part, then snap close, then part again. But after a couple more attempt no sound comes out, at least not until she delicately clears her throat and straightens her shoulders, regaining a modicum of composure after your ambushing kiss and looking down at you with a displeased frown that (despite her intentions) it is clearly taking her some effort to keep in place.

(You almost smile again at the way it wobbles uncertainly).

"What was all that about?" She asks exasperatedly, gesturing towards the door with a huff of annoyance. "Why did you leave like that, Catra?" That last question sounds more like a demand, but the twich in her brow and the way she starts twisting her hands nervously atop the book in her lap gives her insecurity and vulnerability away. Yet another stab through your chest. (You are more Swiss cheese than Khajiit at this point).

"I know it wasn't because you had to see Glimmer, so don't even try that and just *tell me* why-
"

"Because I'm an idiot." You declare. Without shame. Effectively cutting her off and holding her gaze with determination even if it makes you feel so horribly, horribly exposed and vulnerable in a way you fear you'll ever feel comfortable with. But that doesn't mean you'll stop doing it.

Because being vulnerable comes with telling the truth. And Adora deserves as much.

"I was... embarrassed." You confess, wondering how hard you can blush before even your fur won't be enough to conceal it. "By what I said- by that stupid joke I made without thinking. I- I didn't *mean it*, Adora!" She *has* to know that.

Although... it looks like... she already might?

Your eyes grow huge at the sight of her nodding as if the thought of you actually implying something with your dumb comment hasn't even crossed her mind.

The first wave of relief washes over you, overwhelming you as you get enveloped in its soothing, comforting warmth that almost has you curl up on yourself and sobbing. It casts light into the shadowy doubts lingering in your mind, and tends to the aching wounds that you have sustained until now.

It's like being caressed by the first ray of sunlight after a long, incessant deluge, and you feel just as blessed as the earth for its warmth.

Emboldened by a fresh surge of confidence that follows such blissful sensation, you decide to continue and be completely honest about what happened.

"And then..." Determination aside, you still have to pause though, because it's hard not to blush or feel a twinge of embarrassment at the thought of sharing the specifics, but you can't let that stop you. "Then, to make things worse... well..." Your voice trails off and you rub at the back of your neck. Eyes cast downward. (So much for being brave).

But Adora, once again, meets you in the middle, reaching out and preventing you from getting dragged away by those very same doubts emerging from the shadows, taking your hands in hers and demanding nothing, just uttering a single request.

"What is it, Catra?"

It still amazes you, how the sound of her voice can ease the tumultous storm raging inside you. How a gesture as simple as joining your hands can infuse you with strength, enough to soldier on at the sight of your intertwined fingers.

"I got... *excited*... and I panicked."

There.

It wasn't *so* hard now, was it?

...ugh.

You almost groan out loud and facepalm yourself at the *terrible* choice of words.

"Catra," You look up just in time to see Adora's features twisting into a frown at your explanation. "You know you didn't have to leave though, so why did you run away, really?"

You swallow. Roughly. But the stubborn lump forming in your throat doesn't budge. Nor does the prickling sensation in your eyes.

"Because..."

Because that's the only way I know how to deal with my problems.

Because that's what I do best. *Disappoint.*

But also...

"Because I didn't want you to *see* how excited I got and think that I wanted *to*... -it just happened! It happens a lot actually, but when I'm around you, because of the way it tends to... draw attention to itself... I'm terrified that you'll think something that I have no intention of doing without the both of us being on the same page about it first."

It rushes all out of you in a flood. But it appears that once you start, you aren't able to stop.

The words just keep coming, voicing your fears and insecurities, and you can't quite help the way it makes you feel; like you have just slit open an artery.

The flood doesn't give sign of stopping. And so you bleed.

You spill everything.

Or... well... *almost* everything.

But there are things you simply can't find the strength to share. Things that will have you bleed to death.

I'm worried you won't like me anymore if you see it.

I'm worried that things will change between us if you do.

It may sound foolish, an unfounded fear that has no reason to exist, not with the way you know Adora loves you, with everything she has, with everything she *is*, but... it's there.

When the the emotional emorragy finally stops and you have gathered enough courage to open your eyes and lift your gaze, you are immediately struck by the way her entire expression has softened, by the way her eyes are *glistening*.

"Oh, Catra..." She breathes. Both with relief and pain, with pride and disappointment, with understanding and lingering confusion regarding that same *why*.

"So I ran." You conclude, finally managing to swallow down that spiked knot in your throat. The crushing weight of guilt that was pressing down against your chest also seems to lift a little, allowing you to breathe a bit more easily.

The moments of silence that follow are tense, growing almost palpable as Adora studies you as if searching for Heavens-know-what.

The last thing that you expect to see as she takes in all your vulnerable ugliness however, is the smile that curls oh-so-softly on her lips. The warm touch of her hand returning to your cheek. The softness of her voice when she finally speaks and says,

"But you came back."

You bite your lip and nod. Willing your heart to start beating again. Anytime now would be wonderful, in fact.

"I have." You confirm. And then a little softer, a little more tentatively, and with your voice still aching with guilt, "I'm so sorry, Adora. I shouldn't have left in the first place but-"

She doesn't let you finish though.

And this time you are the one struck by shock as Adora's other hand comes to rest on your jaw and - with reflexes almost comparable to your own - tilts your head up to press her lips against yours.

You may tense up at first. Hackles raised and ears lifting on high alert. But you fall right into it just as instinctively, merely a skipped heartbeat later.

The kiss is firm. The pressure grounding. The warmth... absolutely *everything* you were left yearning after such an ordeal.

It doesn't deepen, not does it last for half as long as you had hoped, but it still manages to leave you a bit dazed.

You blink stupidly as Adora pulls away. Your entire being still reeling as after a blow to the head. (None have ever managed to leave you so delightfully dizzy afterwards though).

And yet, even when you still have to recover from your dumbfounded haze, you succeed in asking the one question that is still weigthing heavily on your chest.

"Does this mean you forgive me?"

A fond chuckle tumbles past her lips, and the sound of her laugh, the sight of her *smiling* so *brilliantly*, has your heart blossom open, fluttering at the affection that you see reflected in her eyes.

"Yes, you silly cat," She confirms, and your tail (which also happens to have a mind of its own) may or may *not* give away how blissfully relieved and happy you are by this news. You barely manage to restrain it when she suddenly fixes you with a serious, reprimanding look though.

"But Catra, you can't do that again, all right? The way you left..."

Her voice trails off, her gaze growing distant. The smile that was there a moment ago completely swallowed by another, gloomier look.

A sense of dread sneaks up on you upon seeing it, making your hackles raise again.

"What it is?" You ask her, doing your very best to try and keep your wild, frantic thoughts and emotions at bay.

She bites her lower lip, averting her gaze, looking anywhere but at you.

Panic starts swelling inside of your chest again, closing off your airways, getting a hold of you and threatening to drag you back down that bottomless pit that she has just helped you crawl your way out of.

You won't allow her to get down that hole. Especially not *because of you*.

Once again, you find all the motivation you need in one single thought.

Now is *your* turn.

"Hey..." You tilt your head down, searching for her gaze, and smiling softly at her when she finally, tentatively meets it. "Please tell me?"

Perhaps it's the note of softness in your voice, the way you stroke the back of her hands with your thumbs in a feather-light touch, the calm that you force your body to emit in the vain hope that she will perceive it and that it will affect her. Whatever it is, you are beyond grateful when, after just another moment of hesitation, she nods in consent and deflates, blowing out a shaky breath.

Just in case, you brace yourself for whatever is to come next.

"I know it wasn't the same," She starts. "But... whenever you leave the way you do, it always reminds me of that night, you know? Before the Heart. When you snuck out in the middle of the night a-and I j-just..."

She stops herself right there. Her voice choked off by a lump. Most likely the same one that is also responsible for the tears that you can see pooling in her blue eyes. (And yours.)

Your grind your jaw in a hopeless attempt to hold them at bay.

Well. Congratulations, you fucking *moron*.

By choosing to run as a way to deal with your pathetic fears and insecurities you were able to trigger one of the most painful memories that she possesses.

Well done.

What a day to be proud of yourself, uh?

Heavens. Is there *anything* that you can't fuck up?

For how tempting and *easy* it would be to start blaming yourself all over again though, you know you can't spiral down that road.

You can't.

You *won't* make the same mistake twice.

If not for your sake, then for Adora's. Who clearly needs you more than you need to chastise your worthless, sorry, pathetic, whiny, bratty ass.

"I would never leave you." You swear, your voice firm, fierce, your gaze as hard as steel despite the tears that you can still feel pooling there in response to hers. If nothing else, you need to be sure that she at least knows *that*.

"*Ever*."

And when that isn't enough to convince her either, you shoulder your way past the guilt and uncertainties and rising panic to remind her something that will hopefully make her understand how much you mean what you said.

"I know that, both in the past and recently, I have picked up the habit of running away from you, but... I always came back eventually, didn't I?"

At this, a tremulous smile curls on her lips. Her eyes clearing a bit from the gray gloom that had taken over their usual proud, magical brightness.

"...you did." She conceeds, almost timidly.

You can only smile in return. "Then trust me that I won't leave you again."

You seal that promise by pressing a soft, lingering kiss to the back of her left hand.

"You better mean it." Adora says gravelly, and while it is not exactly distrust the note that you catch in her voice, you get her scepticism.

It hurts, but you only have yourself to blame for that.

You see how she battles against her own hesitancy on whether to believe you or not. Squirming. Clearly wanting to despite the fact that your track record (as already established) isn't great, but she is still ready to give you her whole trust again (along with the power to potentially break her heart), just like that.

It's a show too raw to witness. Too visceral. Displaying a level of intimacy you don't feel worthy of. But you are ready to do whatever it takes in order to be so.

The last thing you want however is to risk making a promise that you'll end up breaking if something really upsetting will once again ignite that flight instinct. Hopefully, it'll never happen again, and if it does then... you believe you may have an acceptable alternative to offer.

"I'm not say that it's going to be *easy* or that I may not feel tempted to do it again," You tell her, truthfully. "But... I'll do better."

This is a promise you feel comfortable making. Something that you can work on and improve. With her help. A little at the time.

And apparently, it's also good enough for Adora, who smiles at the sincerity that you have poured in your words- at *you*.

And you know, from the moment she places her book aside before throwing her arms around you, that she has forgiven you once more.

You won't forget it. Nor dismiss what happened. Hugging her tightly to your chest until Adora looses her (severely lacking) balance, sending you toppling backwards onto the floor with an *ooof!*, and her landing on top of you with a squeal.

"Ow!" You cringe when your elbow slams against the marble floor, sending sparks of electricity shooting up your arm, but you are laughing and Adora is actually *giggling*, presses kisses to your cheek, unable to hold back her affection, even reaching up with one hand to scratch you behind your ear and under your chin (in that unique way that only *she* can do), like a reward for your show of vulnerability and open honesty.

If that's what you'll earn each time, you might grow inclined to do it more often, after all. But that's kind of the point with positive reinforcements, you reason.

You roll around for a minute, wrestling half-heartedly and laughing, taking full advantage of the lightness of the moment to simply enjoy being silly for a second, like you used to do when you were kids.

Eventually though, (inevitably really) the struggle becomes more competitive, but neither of you seem willing to turn it into a proper match or display of strength. Far more content to simply bask in the closeness that has you laying on top of each other, with Adora petting you and nuzzling your neck.

And maybe it's the scritches, or the sense of safety and calm settling in, maybe it's your hormones or the fact that you just went through the ordeal of opening up and allow yourself to be more vulnerable than you have ever been in a long time, but suddenly you feel *exausted.*

Nothing looks more appealing to you than a lazy afternoon nap in the arms of the woman you love.

Or maybe it's the bite, a voice in the back of your head suggests, your heart giving a hard throb when Adora, who is still nuzzling your neck and inhaling your scent asks you, "Would you like to lay down with me for a little while?"

Her voice is so soft, a bit slurred already, and weighed down by sleep.

This time, you see no point in trying to conceal your delighted grin.

"Stop reading my mind, you weirdo."

You can feel her grinning where her face is still tucked into the crook of your neck.

"Not my fault, you think loudly." She defends and you scoff, blushing for some unexplicable reason.

"Come on, let's get up."

You manage to make it to your feet, supporting each other because of your wobbly legs, and onto the bed, where you lay on top of the covers, not even bothering to strip down from your stiff formal clothes (which you'll no doubt regret when the'll be wrinkled beyond recognition, but that's a problem for later) mostly concerned with getting your heavy limbs to cooperate in order to get properly settled.

Even though it's true that your sleeping arrangements have changed in the past few months, you don't have a favorite position (you are both content as long as some parts of your bodies are touching). Usually though, you spoon her at night and the next morning you wake up with her body curled protectively over yours.

Right now however, with Adora seemingly keen on keeping her nose buried against your neck (for reasons that make your imagination run wild and your heart race even wilder), you let her curl against your side. It works as perfectly as it always does. Your bodies slotting together effortlessly, without any conscious thought at all.

You hold her close to you, stroking your hand down her back, unable not to think about how you risked to lose this today because of your own foolishness.

It isn't long before Adora's soft hums of appreciation for your petting turn into steady, measured, slow breaths, and that- the hypnotic rhythm of her breathing, of her heart - is all your body needs to relax the rest of the way, for your mind to dismiss the rest of your troubled thoughts, and follow her into oblivion.

. . .

When you wake up, it is (embarrassingly enough) because of your own loud purring. You startle but don't jolt upright, struck by that initial feeling of desorientation that only comes after a particularly deep, restful sleep. The question about where you are instantly answered by the familiar, sweet smell of Adora's hair filling your nostrils. A sleepy smile curls on your lips as you inhale it deeply, settling back onto the covers and instinctively snuggling closer to the source of that scent.

You don't know how long it has passed either, but when you finally manage to open your eyes, you see that the room is bathed in the unmistakable and particularly stunning, fiery orange glow of sunset casting tall, long shadows of the furniture all around.

It takes a while for you to properly regain your awareness though. Every thought feeling as if it's dragging through the quicksand of your sleep addled brain, but despite the grogginess and lingering sense of disorientation, you also feel incredibly, surprisingly well rested.

You stretch a bit, bringing relief to your stiff limbs and joints but without uncurling your tail, which is - unsurprisingly - wrapped around Adora's calf.

That's the first detail that your eyes manage to put into proper focus when you rub the rest of sleep away from them with you knuckles, and the sight of it instantly triggers a smile on your

lips and a delightful throb in your chest.

Your gaze trails upwards, lazily, *appreciatively*, eager to take in both the delightfully soft curves of your lover and the firm leanness of her athletic body, until you reach her face and-

"Hi."

The softest, rosiest smile and even softer pair of blue eyes greet you, and you can't help but grin right back at her.

"Hey yourself, Princess." Your voice comes out deeper and so much raspier than usual with disuse, but it's no secret that Adora kinda enjoys the slightly husky note in it. "Did you have a good nap?"

She nods through a self explanatory yawn. "I have been awake for a little now but yes, I slept like a rock." She admits with a timid sort of smile and... a *suspiciously* fleeting gaze.

You fix her curiously with a quirked eyebrow and one corner of your mouth lifted in a teasing little smirk. "Were you watching me sleep, you creep?" And even though there is only affection in your voice, the playful accusation still earns you a lovely blush and the sight of teeth sinking into a plush, rosy lip as Adora averts her gaze once again. Guiltily.

"Ha! Knew it." You chuckle, stretching your arms above your head and arching your back off the bed just to show off your flexibility, actively ignoring the discomfort that comes with the realization that you slept with your formal clothes on. Ugh. You *knew* you were going to regret it. (But you can definitely endure it, especially considering the way Adora's eyes rake down your body, the way her lips part and she has to force herself to close them. Swallowing. *Hard*. Leaving you to bite down on the inside of your cheek to keep from laughing).

"Can't blame you really. I mean, I'm quite irresistible." You smirk obnoxiously, flashing her a wink.

The much-expected shove, or huff of annoyance, or half-hearted, sputtered, flustered denial never comes though, and when you glance down at her after you have settled back from your long stretch to see what got her so silent all of a sudden, you find her with her eyes fixed, unblinking, on a spot between your bodies.

"What?" Frowning with confusion you follow her gaze and-

Oh no.

Your heart trips over itself and stumbles into a stop.

Your eyes go wide.

Not *again*! You beg uselessly, staring in disbelief at the visible swell tenting in your pants.

Panic surges through you in an instant, burning hot in your belly as does the embarrassment at its heels, scalding you from the inside out.

Instinctively, your knees draw up and your hands shoot down in a desperate attempt to cover yourself, but before you can do just that, a hand intercepts one of yours, catching it mid air.

"Don't." Adora all but pleads in the softest command.

"A-Adora."

Wide eyed and with your mouth agape, you meet her gaze, half terrified and half frozen bewilderment.

She holds it with unweavering steadiness as she begs you again.

"Please, Catra." And her voice is so impossibly *soft*. Almost liquid. Making her request all the more devastating to hear.

"Please, don't hide from me."

Not again.

Your heart, which has resumed beating at some point, now feels like it might be about to leap straight out of your chest, every inch of your body (with one significant exception) and every thought in your head narrowing down to one need; screaming at you to bolt.

But you don't.

No matter how tempting the urge to run and go hide somewhere dark and quiet is.

You remember your promise, smother that urge and, after a particularly shaky breath and a harsh gulp... you nod.

Here goes nothing...

With your next exhale you lower your hand back onto the matress and stretch your legs out as they were before. Willing the rest of your muscles to relax as you gaze down at the outline of your knot straining under the fabric of your still half-buttoned pants, wondering *how* you didn't realize it until she pointed it out, and... if you'll ever be able to *control it.*

"Does it happen often?" Adora asks, curiously.

Hesitantly, you nod again. "Y-yeah." You rasp out. "More and more frequently, yes."

A moment of silence then, followed by a concerned furrow in her brow that anticipates her next question.

"Does it hurt?"

Her concern warms you, truly. It almost comforts you even. But you are still conflicted about how to answer.

Eventually, you decide to shake your head in negative, but this time, no matter the effort you put in it to make it look convincing, she seems to catch the lie in the way you didn't realize you have been biting down on your lower lip.

"Catra..." She reprimands, seeing right through your pitiful attempt.

"Ugh. *Fine.*" You roll your eyes. Since when has she become so fucking *observant*? Just as that question crosses your mind though, your eyes happen to fall onto the healing scar on her neck, and understanding hits you from all sides. (Particularly so in your groin and the appendage stirring in your pants, growing stiffer by the minute - which, conveniently, brings you back to her question).

"It's not pain, exactly." You explain, features contorted into a light grimace that this time you know better than try to hide as you squirm. Suddenly *extremely* conscious of *it.*

"But keeping it... contained... when wearing particularly stiffling clothes isn't... well... *comfortable.*" You also do your best in choosing the most appropriate words while hoping, with your entire being, that she won't interpret them in the wrong way, or as an allusion to *anything*.

"O-oh." She simply says. Blushing in a way you shouldn't find pretty but it just *is*. Undeniably so.

For a long moment there she is silent, absorbing this new piece of information.

It stretches into a full minute.

Just when it is starting to become unbearable though, and before another spike of anxiety can pierce through your paper-thin layer of frayed calm, she looks up at you again.

You aren't quite prepared for the intensity in her eyes though, the dark unwavering look in them, and the surprise of it tears a noisless gasp from between your lips.

"Then maybe you should take them off."

You almost choke on your tongue right then.

"Adora-"

"Please." She asks, as something soft and vulnerable weaves in her sleep-thick voice, in her intense, darkened eyes. "Will you let me see you?"

Ordinarily, there isn't a single thing in the universe you would ever be able to deny her, but *this...*

Heavens.

You struggle with the idea for a long moment, weighing the pros and cons of her request that simply lead you to the most obvious, most inevitable conclusion.

She is going to see it eventually.

It's not like you can spend the rest of your life hiding from her or worse, start wearing *underwear.* May the Heavens preserve you from such a fate.

You swallow hard, willing your hands to stop shaking and your heart to slowing down its wild galloping, unable to wonder if it is simply nerves... or perhaps excitement what you are feeling coursing through your veins.

Whatever it is, you can't deal with it right now. There is enough on your plate already as it is.

"Are you sure?" Is what you settle for asking her at long last, and this time, there is no hesitation before she gives you her answer.

"Please." She nods. Twice. Firmly, and with nothing but certainty staring back at you from two puddles of endless blue. And yet... you don't miss the oddly endearing blush spreading over her cheekbones.

"O-okay." You say, and normally you would be embarrassed by the way you stutter, your voice sounding far deeper, and huskier than usual. You pin it on the fact that you have basically just woken up. As you do with the shakiness of your hands when you reach for the buttons at the front of your trousers.

And even if your insecurities would still have you keep your eyes tightly closed for the entirety of it, you force them not no.

You barely breathe through the process however, until the last button is undone and the immediate relief that follows as your shaft gets released from the tight confines has you expel a long sigh.

Once again, you feel it slap mutedly against your lower belly, hard and aching.

You feel *so* exposed you might as well have stripped off your own skin.

"Y-you know," You gulp dryly feeling as if your entire body is going up in flames. "Just because it's like this it doesn't mean we have to do *anyth*-"

"I know." She interrupts, making your gaze snaps up to meet her eyes - still so dark, gleaming, and so very *very* intense that you find yourself stuck in them as if the were two pools of shiny tar.

And that's probably the reason why you remain completely oblivious to the hand that moves out of your peripheral vision, only becoming aware of it when you feel it coming to rest on your hip, fingers slowly trailing down. Not because of hesitation though, but rather with a patient sense of purpose that has you shudder with anticipation.

And that's it.

You gasp and she eagerly takes the chance to bend down and kiss you.

Hard.

Deep.

Yet slowly.

With intent.

To prove a point- An *answer* to your previous reassurance.

But I want to her ardent kiss says. *I want* you.

She *wants* you.

She wants *you.*

The thrill of those words echoing inside your head resonates through your entire system, fluttering wildly within the cavity of your chest, burrowing deep into your bone marrow, and throbbing exquisitely in your core, melting with the desire stirring there.

She wants you.

It's an exhilarating feeling.

Thoroughly intoxicating.

The way your heart swells at the realization, and the way such realization fills you to the brim with relief leaves you breathless, and the comfort in it, in the way Adora touches you and kisses you as she slowly reaches her destination, her hand steady and certain purposeful, leaving no space for doubts, completely demolishes your fears, crushing them into dust.

Accepting the fact that she truly, genuinely wants you, you finally allow yourself to surrender to the need gnawing deep in your belly ever since this whole ordeal started.

You reach up to blindly slip your hand into her gorgeous, silky golden hair, urging her closer to deepen the kiss just as Adora wraps her fist around the aching, straining shaft of your knot, giving it a slow, torturous, exquisite, experimental first stroke that has the pressure inside you swell even further and your entire body shudder from head to toe, making you groan helplessly in her mouth as your knot gives a heavy, eager and quite encouraging throb in her palm, shamelessly spurting a jet of clear slickness from the tip that you can feel dripping down to land on your navel.

Pleasure coils tighter on itself deep in your belly, a sensation that is both familiar and alien at the same time.

The warm, firm pressure of her soft, slightly calloused hand holding you is like a hot brand reminding you of what you weren't able to finish earlier in the supply closet.

This time though, you don't think that anything is going to be able to stop you from seeking the relief that you so desperately need. And you can already tell - from the enthusiastic way

your body is responding to Adora's lovely, first, exploratory ministrations - that you aren't going to last long either.

Chapter End Notes

There. This seems like the perfect spot to end the chapter. *Smiles innocently*.

Effects of Habit and the use or disuse of Parts (Part 2)

Chapter Summary

Two massive idiots madly in love with each other and acting like two blushing virgins do some hands-on exploring.

Chapter Notes

Warning! Things start getting quite serious here in terms of adult stuff, folks.
So from this point on I'm rating the story with an E, triple X, NSFW, whatever you fancy.

To make it simple: it's smut time, peeps. With a huge side of feelings.

Anyhow... chapter picks up right where the previous one ended.

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Adora..."

It feels like the first time all over again.

When your entire world revolved around her.

When her touch was all you needed, all you craved, even more than air itself.

When her name on your lips was the only word that held importance, the only one you could remember and manage uttering, over and over again, like a mantra, a prayer in response to the pleasure that you felt igniting deep within you with every kiss, burning hotter with every brush of her fingers. From the most innocent and loving to the most direct and electrifying.

And right now your body surely feels like a live wire. A sizzling current traveling through your entire system, tickling every nerve ending in the most tantalizing way.

It feels so familiar.

Yet... undeniably different at the same time.

Like the desire burning inside you, directly linked to the pressure building in your lower belly. Pounding at the very base of your shaft. Demanding something from you. Something that your body seems to know intrinsically even if you are unable to put it into words.

It's equally frustrating and intriguing, and the mystery of it only serves to fuel your resolve to discover what it might be.

"Is this okay?" Adora's sweet voice tugs you back from your thoughts and into the present, her tentative inquiry barely a hushed whisper in the quietness of your room, sounding slightly breathless with nerves and... looking just as flustered as you are feeling, you realize as soon as you are able to blink your eyes open and put her properly into focus.

Her cheeks are tinged into the loveliest shade of pink that makes your heart flutter within the confines of your chest, feeling it swelling with affection when, with a note of concern etched on her lovely features and weaving in her even lovelier voice, she adds, "I'm not hurting you, am I?"

"N-no." You instantly assure her through a stuttered, croaky groan, tossing your head onto the pillows for good measure. "It feels... So good."

Good enough to deprive you from your usual eloquence apparently, only allowing you to utter a few words before the air gets knocked out of your lungs with a shuddering gasp by the stabs of pleasure that pierce your stomach with the next exquisitedly, torturously slow pump of her fist along the hard shaft of your knot. And yet, in spite of your temporary albeit still slightly embarassing lack of eloquence, Adora blushes even harder, visibly flattered by the simple praise (a sight so endearing and precious that only serves to remind you more acutely of your first time together).

"I... I don't really know how... a-am I doing it right?" She asks, blue eyes wide and hopeful as you cant your hips into her touch.

If anyone were to see her like this, in this moment- a flushed, stuttering pile of nerves - they would hardly believe they were in the presence of the Vessel of the mighty She-Ra herself.

But here's something that almost everyone seems very keen to forget on a daily basis.

Adora ain't She-Ra.

She never was.

Despite what everyone seems inclined to believe, she isn't all power and strength and confidence oozing out of her perfectly sculpted butt along with rainbows and sunshine.

She is just a girl.

Your girl.

Your beautiful, stubborn, dorky, snort-laughing, perpetually-tripping-over-her-own-feet girl.

And this Adora, the *real Adora*, the one you have come to know and love so very fiercely, is riddled with holes about insecurities like anyone else. But she is brave and strong enough on her own to push past them. And *that*, you believe, is more heroic and courageous than recklessly throwing herself head first into battle against an unknown enemy as a magical being wielding an equally magical sword.

"You are doing... amazing." You reassure her, thankful that your voice has decided to cooperate for once. "Your h-hand... it feels *so good*, Adora."

And just like that, her lovely blush deepens some more, spreading further down her neck.

She looks so, so pretty.

"You feel good, too." She confesses, biting onto her lower lip in such a timid manner that for a moment you wonder where the young woman who's kissed you so fiercely and grasped you in her fist so boldly and confidently just a minute ago has gone. Until you catch sight of her- lurking into the dark, seemingly bottomless pools of desire that her crystal clear blue eyes have turned into, making you realize that she is still very much *in there*.

"So hard," She continues, "But... your skin... is so soft and *smooth*." Yeah... You kinda know what she means by that, given that -with the sole exception of your genitals- no other part of your body has ever been that smooth or furless.

Strangely enough, the comment and the note of fascination that you hear coloring her voice leaves you feeling slightly, inexplicably flattered.

To emphasize her words, and before your poor lust-addled brain can conjure an adequate response to her observation, she glances down again and swipes her thumb over the tip of your knot, where the skin is exceptionally soft, with a sponge-like texture and, most importantly, *amazingly sensitive*- a detail that she has already picked up in her brief exploration apparently, for your enthusiastic responses to her touches there definitely haven't gone unnoticed. But that's no wonder at all; she has always been a quick study. (And an incredibly attentive lover, as well).

She repeats the gesture, gathering the clear drops of slickness pooled at the divot there with a feather-light touch, and your hips jerk of their own will into her hand once more. The added sensation tearing a low, guttural groan from your chest and making your eyes roll into the back of your head.

Fuck.

And apparently that's all the encouragement Adora needs to resume stroking you, this time though, instead of diving in to kiss you deeply again, she simply gives your parted lips the gentlest peck before shifting her attention downward.

You open your eyes just in time to see her settling comfortably on her side and propping herself up on one elbow, properly taking in the sight of your body stretched out onto the bed, completely at her mercy, eyes fixed intently and focused in studying your knot, the way it responds to her touch, admiring the way the thin layer of skin enveloping it pulls back with

each down stroke, leaving the sensitive head all the more exposed, twitching and dribbling against the cool air.

"Oh, Catra..." She whispers, sounding so completely enraptured by the sight of you. And you can't even begin to express the relief, the *joy* that brightens inside you upon hearing that tone in her voice, which it's enough to banish every single doubt and insecurity you had in the past week about how she would have reacted upon seeing you like this. Upon seeing *it.*

In response, however, you can only choke down a sob that turns into a whimper, trying to keep your hips still in order to allow her to continue exploring your body at the pace she is more comfortable with.

It's pure torture.

But one you are more than willing to endure. (Even though all you want is to break of these self imposed restraints and just... *rut* mindlessly into her hand to relieve your shaft from the pounding pressure that you can feel trapped within, which grows ten times worse when she curiously examines the ridges lining the first half of the underside by stroking them, one by one, with the pad of her thumb).

"A-adora..." You moan, unable to stop yourself, fisting the sheets at your sides and breathing hard through your nose in an attempt to keep you grounded. Both literally *and* figuratively.

Seriously, you feel like you might be about to just... float away.

Which is humbling.

You should be better than this.

You should have a much firmer grip on your self-control. (On *your own damn body!*) But *fuck...*

It feels just so. *amazing.*

And you are not thinking exclusively about the physical sensations. But about *the way* Adora is touching you, the way she is *looking* at you. With fascination, almost in awe, so genuinely *eager* to learn you and please you, curious to know how to best touch you to elicit the most pleasurable reactions from your body.

After the panic you have suffered earlier, when you were worried, beyond reason, and above anything else that she wouldn't want anything to do with this new part of your body... experiencing all of this, feeling and seeing her genuine affection and care reflected in every single touch... it almost feels like too much. Something that your wildly fluttering heart is barely capable of handling on its own. You feel it swelling to make further space inside it to accomodate the surge of love that blossoms within its chambers.

(Just when you though that you couldn't *possibly* love her more...)

You can't help but feel a little ashamed of yourself for thinking so little of her, for doubting her affections for you being linked only to your physical appearance and the sprouting of a

new appendage between your legs.

Mercifully, before you can fall further down that deep, dark pit of self-deprecation and meet your end at its bottom of self-pity, Adora- more specifically the wonderful, amazing thing that she does with her hand by *squeezing* the thick base of your shaft, yanks you back to the present.

You groan, long and deep, shuddering from head to toe as your knot answers Adora's loving gesture by rewarding her with a fresh spurt of clear wetness.

It's too much and yet not quite *enough*.

"P-please..." You implore her, looking up at her pleadingly, even though you have no idea what you are begging her for, exactly.

And yet, as always, with just a single glance at you she seems to sense that, above all, you just need *more*.

"It's okay," She says, so quietly, her voice merely a whisper that seeps right into you, quieting the battle of need raging within you and soothing your frayed nerves with just three simple words.

"I got you." She promises, smiling knowingly and oh so lovingly at you.

"Let me take care of you, baby." And with that, she leans in.

You tilt your head up and meet her halfway into the kiss, choking down a whimper and melting against her lips, wrapping one of your arms around her shoulders to draw her closer just as her hand resumes moving.

It's no longer exploratory half strokes and tentativeness though. In a matter of minutes she seems to have learned enough about where you are most sensitive and what makes your hips fly off the mattress. Because now she pumps you fully, from base to tip and back again, tightening her fist and applying just the perfect amount of pressure to drive you that tiny bit more insane, feeding the sparks ignited in your belly.

You feel the exact moment when those sparks properly catch and flare into actual flames, flickering and dancing at the rhythm she establishes, completing every down stroke by squeezing you, and every up stroke by swiping the fresh fluids dribbling from the tip with her thumb.

Never before you have ever felt more grateful for the kind of bond that you share, where just a look, a touch, a kiss is enough to convey what words only partially can. It's a language that your bodies have learned well. A way of communication that comes effortlessly and is particularly useful, especially so in these circumstances where words seem to fail you more and more often.

And it's by attuning that particular, unique sense that you start moving together.

Finally realizing that you don't have to hold back, you allow your hips to roll with each movement of her hand, seeking the tightness of her fingers wrapped around you, hissing and growling when she squeezes the thick base of your length to elicit another heavy throb and consequent spurt of wetness.

And because of that, each stroke grows easier, slicker, faster, aided by the amount of arousal that keeps leaking out of you at a steady pace.

She may even have just started touching you (like... *properly touching you*, not exploratory, teasing touches) but the promise of your release feels just around the corner.

After all you have been through today though, you don't think you'll be able to survive the mortification that you would no doubt suffer if you were to climax so soon.

She is so *good* at it though.

(The part of you that isn't completely lost to the bliss sizzling through your nerve endings can't help but scoff- albeit affectionately. *Some things never change.* You think, more amused than annoyed, because even after all these years she still remains the same overachiver show off).

And so, in order to center yourself, you close your eyes and draw in a much-needed, shaky breath.

But even that turns out to be a mistake.

Considering your exceptional senses you *definitely* should have taken it into consideration before, but you barely have two brain cells left at this point, and there is no turning back now that you have just inhaled a noseful of Adora's scent.

So clean and balmy and fresh.

Like soap.

Yet underlined with that something sharper, a bit muskier and a lot headier that is uniquely *her*, making it simply irresistible.

It fills you from within and wraps around you like a blanket of safeness.

It's incredible how every single muscle in your body goes lax as soon as you inhale it, while the pounding along your shaft grows ten times worse. But maybe even that is a reaction elicited by the way her scent blends in the air with what you have started to recognize being the sharp, pungent smell of your own arousal (now literally dripping out of you in rivulets as Adora keeps stroking you, faster and harder) creating a new, absolutely mouthwatering, irresistible fragrance.

It's enough to make your resolution about enduring this exquisite torture waver. And when, in the midst of all the scents tickling your nose you catch another, far stronger, unmistakable note, you think you might be about to completely lose control.

Once again, you close your eyes in an attempt to regain your balance, taking another deep breath and... making the same mistake yet again as you inevitably sniff the air, catching another, stronger wave of that particular, familiar scent.

So light and sweet-smelling that all it does is make it, absurdly enough, that much easier for your sensitive nose to pick up, and once you do and you recognize it for what it actually is, your knot gives a particularly sharp throb.

"A-Adora..." You moan. The smell of her filling your nostrils and sticking to your palate, clogging your airways. Only this time you aren't talking about the simple smell of her skin layered by a bit of perspiration.

This scent represents something else *entirely*.

Something that your own crippling insecurities have prevented you from considering it a possibility altogether.

Yet here it is.

Floating in the air.

Threatening to choke you with the syrupy sweetness of the unique, unmistakable, musky notes of arousal.

Yes.

That's right.

Adora is *aroused.*

It's the sweetest realization you have ever tasted in your entire life.

Touching you is *arousing* her.

Your entire body shudders with a warm wave of pleasure.

She is *wet.* Wet enough for you to *smell her* despite the fact that she is still wearing all of her clothes.

The thought leaves you feeling incredibly dizzy, and your knot twitches heavily one more time. Your hips bucking instinctively, chasing after the firm pressure and warmth of her hand in spite of your desire to make this last, but you truly can't help it. And from the way your body keeps disobeying your orders, you know that it won't allow you to hold back much longer.

It hardly seems fair though...

The thought crosses your mind attached to the unmistakable need- no, *urge* for reciprocation. It flares suddenly and violently inside you, just as hotly as the need centered between your legs, pounding along your aching knot.

Because Adora is always taking such good care of you, and lately she has been the most loving and patient and comforting...

The urge to touch her strikes you even harder at the reminder of how supportive and caring she has been in the past week. How she has soothed your insecurities and tended to the wounds the have left.

You want to feel her, too.

You want to make her *feel good*, too. (Possibly as good as she is making you feel). You really, *really* want that.

But despite your desire to do so, you are no fool in believing you could, not in your current state at least, where even breathing regularly is starting to feel like a challenge. Not when your mind seems to have been stripped blank from all reasoning, from the ability to form any coherent word, drowning as you are under the flood of pleasure coursing through your veins and swirling hotly in your belly.

And yet, when you feel her subtly rolling her hips against your side, in a way that even in your current conditions you recognize being a completely unintentional, purely instinctual movement, a zap of electricity shocks your system just enough for you to regain some measure of control over your own body.

Coordination isn't usually an issue for you, but right now, with the pleasure no longer lapping gently at you but *crashing* like hungry, merciless waves in a savage storm ready to swallow you whole at any moment, the best you can do is shift a little and *slip* one of your long, lean, toned thighs between hers.

Much to your utter delight she immediately welcomes the intrusion, moaning appreciatively into your mouth and not wasting a second before properly mounting your leg and starting to grind against it, just enough to provide a bit of relief to the pressure that otherwise would be (as you yourself have experienced on multiple occasions) quite unbearable.
But even that doesn't distract her from her main purpose. Her focus still entirely on pleasing you.

The steadiness of her touch doesn't relent, not for a second. If anything, she starts stroking you faster.

There is nothing that you would love more than return the favor with the proper kind of attention that she deserves, watching mesmerized as you work her up to bring her higher and higher towards that peak and then push her over the edge to watch her plummet into the depths below.

The thought pains you, because right now you can only spare the mental and physical effort required of you to *flex* the muscles on your leg, providing her with a firmer surface for her to grind against as your own hips surge and buck into her touch, searching for more contact, urging her to stroke you even faster, to squeeze you a bit harder.

And she *does*.

She does. She does. *She does*.

She reads into the fast, desperate, choppy way your hips move, moaning knowingly into your messy, wet kiss, readily tightening her grip around your knot in a way that leaves you gasping for air, forcing you to tear your lips from hers as you throb *viciously* in her fist, feeling the thick spurt of fluid that such gesture earns her. And judging from the way she groans and the way her thumb readily swipes at the head, gathering the new layer glazing the very tip, then she definitely felt it as well.

"Adora..." You moan against her lips. Yet another prayer to your mortal goddess. The last word you manage to utter before you turn into a completely incoherent, whimpering, babbling mess. But you are beyond the point of caring about how you must look or sound like. You are beyond feeling embrassassed or mortified for giving in so easily, for reacting so strongly, especially since Adora looks down at you as if she were under a spell, as if you were something otherwordly, something astonishing, awe-inspiring, something-

"You are so beautiful, Catra."

The way the words fall from her lips, the way her eyes shine and widen almost comically so a mere heartbeat later, as if it was just a though that was meant to remain private, something that she wasn't planning to actually say outloud... *Good Heavens.*

There is no holding back the tears that well up in your eyes.

How did you get so lucky?

How can she possibly love you so much that it actually, physically hurts?

(Some questions you don't think you'll ever get the answers to. Because some things simply *are.*)

And the fact that that comment just slipped out, unbidden, is what makes it all the most unbearably, painfully sweet to hear. What might even tighten your throat with emotions you still don't fully know how to deal with.

You part your lips to reciprocate, to tell her that you are nothing compared to the beauty that she exudes in every waking moment, nothing to the way she shines and brightens the world all around her, that you love her and worship her like the celestial being (not She-Ra, not a weapon, but a *being*) you have grown convinced that she actually *is*, that you are going to love her till all the stars in the sky will perish (even though a part of you still feels like you ain't worthy of such privilege)... but before you can do anything, before you can remember how to talk and pronounce *words*, Adora (maybe out of embarrassment for blurting out that heartfelt comment without realizing it, or maybe because she simply wants to reinforce what she just said) bends down to kiss you again.

Deeply.

With more ardor and committment than before. Caressing your tongue with her own and stroking your knot with just the same fervor while grinding onto your thigh at a matching

rhythm.

And you can only kiss her back in return, slipping your claws through her hair to bring her closer, deepening the kiss and letting yourself get lost in the warmth surrounding you, even though, soon enough, your world inevitably starts to narrow down to Adora's hand pumping you so *perfectly*, and to the pressure gnawing and pulsing and straining in your belly for release in a very, very familiar way that makes your knot grow impossibly hard, making it throb even harder and more frequently within Adora's fist.

Fuck.

You are *so* close.

A mix of apprehension and excitement flutters in your stomach at the realization of what that means. The feeling reminding you so strikingly of the way you are used to feel Adora's inner walls pulsing and quivering around your fingers right before you are about to make her climax. A feeling that provides a warning of its own.

And yet, you still feel compelled to provide a proper, vocal one, blushing bright red under the flush of arousal scalding you from the inside as you pull away from the kiss (with extreme reluctance) to inform her.

"I-I'm going to come."

You are delighted to see that Adora appears to be just as flushed as you are, but in spite of it, she doesn't show those endearing signs of nervousness or shyness that you had caught when she first started touching you earlier.

Now, she is all fiery purpose.

And the fact that she is so visibly flushed only serves to confirm how aroused she has gotten by all of this.

"I know," It's what she says at last, looking down at you with a knowing little smile curling on her lips. "I can feel you."

For good measure, to emphasize that point, she gives you another squeeze, and your knot responds by rewarding her with yet another, particularly enthusiastic spurt of wetness.

You don't have to look down in order to see that Adora's hand is already coated in your arousal.

The wet, slippery noises that her fist stroking your knot is making are quite loud, nearly obscene, and... so unbelievably arousing.

It only serves to remind you that what is about to happen- "It's... going to be... m-messy." You stutter in between a gasp and a groan. And if your blush wasn't already visible through your fur, you are pretty sure that now it can be seen from *space*.

"Do it." Adora whispers in response. "I want to see it."

Well... she definitely doesn't give you much of a choice when she picks up the pace, emboldened by the confimation that you are indeed about to come.

"Please, Catra." She asks, looking down at you with such affection and desire that makes her eyes glint and shine so beautifully. "Come for me?" Not a demand. But the most tender, the most kind and genuine request she has ever uttered.

She really wants you to.

She is as *eager* for it, to see you writhe and lose yourself in pleasure as she always is when you are making love to each other.

Nothing has changed.

She wants you.

She *wants* you.

Simply enough - the realization finally sinking for good and filling the chasms of doubts and worries left inside you, paired with another firm stroke of her hand... is really all it takes.

You barely manage to scrape together enough brain power to reach down with a shaky hand and bunch up the lower half of your shirt (because while you could have torn your trousers to shreds earlier, you look far too fabulous in wine red to risk staining this button up) before the first wave of pleasure crashes onto you.

A mighty throb races up the length of your knot and you gasp as your body goes entirely rigid. Back arching. Eyes screwed shut and mouth falling open in a breathless, soundless scream before the dam breaks and you throw your head back, shouting your pleasure to the high ceiling with a croaked, half choked cry, shuddering all over, convulsing with each pulse of pleasure that assaults your senses in a merciless attack that doesn't allow you to catch your breath.

The overwhelming fullness and pressure that has been pounding along your shaft for all this time finally burst free.

You come *explosively.*

Like... literally.

Colors burst behind your closed eyelids. Fire engulfs you from the inside, erupting out of you in a series of fast, long, *thick* streams.

The first jet of your release catches you by surprise as it lands on the thin layer of fur of your rippling stomach.

It feels lukewarm when it seeps through and finally makes contact with the skin underneath, as do the rest that follow.

Adora, on her part, after her own initial gasp of surprise, simply keeps on stroking you. Faster. At a pace that would undoubtedly make anyone else's wrist cramp. But even that would hardly be enough to stop her, sensing the determination that has possessed her and guides each one of her strokes, squeezing and pumping you as if she might be trying to coax every single drop of your pleasure *out*. And even if it's not entirely up to you, the least you can do in return for her efforts is to try and give her *everything* you have. As always.

If feels so good. (And messy. And *sticky*. You doubt your shirt will survive and come out of this stainless, but at the moment you really couldn't care less. If your clothes are going to be collateral damage of your own orgasm... then so be it. It wouldn't be the first time. And... it's *so* totally worth it).

It feels so wonderful that you almost sob at the immeasurable relief that it brings to the ache you have been feeling gnawing deep in your belly. And there is something simply so... inexplicably *satisfying* in feeling your release burst out of you in such a spectacular manner.

And yet... despite the sweet bliss of relief, you can't quite dislodge the feeling that something about it strikes you *wrong*.

It's almost like a whisper that is far too feeble for you to hear, too far out of reach no matter how hard you strain to try hearing it.

It's more like the splinter of a feeling that pierces through your consciousness at the sight that welcomes you as soon as you manage to open your eyes and blink back into focus, seeing your come- your *seed*, adorning your abdomen in long, thick streaks and fat droplets of white.

"Oh, Catra..." Adora whispers, looking and sounding so completely enthralled by the sight.

A sound between a whimper and a groan falls from your lips as a few more spurts erupt from the tip with Adora's aid. She keeps on stroking you devotedly, slowing down only to guide you through the aftershock, until the twitching of your knot become weaker, and so does the flood of come, which subsides, tapering off with one last squirt that leaks from the divot at the tip and rolls down the upperside, brushing against Adora's wet fingers.

She gives you another long, slow pump from base to tip, but the gesture, for how delightful, only earns her a weak twitch and a low groan that tears itself from your chest without your consent.

Your abs ripple as a shudder of what resembles overstimulation runs through your body. And yet, in spite of it, you are beyond relieved to feel Adora still holding you in her warm grasp.

The touch is less firm now, more mindful of your sensitivity, her fingers wrapped a bit more loosely around you, but the comfort that the simple pressure brings, is... truly indescribable.

You can't help but release a long, shuddering sigh at the relief that fills you then.

The ache that you felt piercing your belly during the past few days, that hunger that you felt gnawing at your insides has finally been sated. It's not yet gone though, and to testify to that

there is the fact that you are still hard, but the pounding, restless pressure that has been haunting you is now gone.

You take in another breath, and slowly, the world stops from spinning, righting itself back into its axis.

The intensity of your orgasm has left you dizzy, disoriented, breathless, gasping for air, your ears ringing, your vision struggling to adjust, only making out bright spots here and there, as if a flash grenade just went off, or like it happens when you glance accidentally at the sun. But within a few more moments you are able to properly get your sight to cooperate.

You can't help the sheepish grin that tentatively stretches on your lips the same way you can't help the flutter of emotions stirring in your chest when the first thing you see, as soon as you finally manage to put the surrounding into focus, is Adora smiling down at you.

"Hey, there."

Words.

Right.

You try summoning them by opening and closing your mouth, doing an impressive imitation of a suffocating fish before deciding to do yourself a favor instead by stopping before you can do something even more embarrassing.

Yeah. Your ability to speak is yet to return.

But you hope that carding one of your hands into her silky soft hair and tugging her down to draw her into a slow, deep kiss, conveys what you lack the ability to properly express at the moment.

And from the way Adora kisses you back, you have reason to believe that a good part of the message got delivered just right.

When you are forced to part for air though, a twinge of doubt needles at you when you see the look of uncertainty that descends on her features, furrowing her brow.

"What is it?" You ask her, propping yourself up a bit, trying not to give into the worry that is already starting to churn in your stomach upon seeing that expression on her face.

"It's nothing." She assures. "I was just wandering if..." She pauses for far too long, but just when your worry is starting to reach a whole new level, the unthinkable happens.

"Didn't you enjoy it?" She blurts out, bottom lip sticking out in an actual *pout*.

And you truly can't help it.

You splutter and gawk, heaving a breathy, incredulous laugh before wildly gesturing to the mess you have made by emptying yourself all over your own stomach.

"Do you *really* need to ask?"

Silence.

"Adora?"

Finally, she looks at you, meeting your gaze with an incandescent blush blooming on her cheeks.

"It's just that... You are still *so* hard. And I thought..." She doesn't finish her sentence, squeezing you instead, just hard enough to make her point and forcing you to swallow down a groan (and almost your entire tongue along with it) at the feeling of her warm fist tightening around you before you resolutedly slip into a mask carved out of control itself.

"Y-yeah well, what did you expect?" You ask her rethorically (and a bit shakily) shrugging dismissively with fake nonchalance and flashing her a teasing smirk in an attempt to regain some of your actual confidence and control back. "It's basically a dick."

Luckily, your lame attempt at humor and reassurance works splendidly.

She laugh.

That adorable, honest, dorky snort-laugh of hers that fills you to the brim with joy in knowing you were the one to elicit it.

"That one was terrible." She accuses, but she is still chuckling and her eyes are sparkling. Positively *alight* with joy.

...but you definitely don't miss how they are also still very, very dark. Shimmering with something that you can easily recognize. Something that (along with the feeling of legs still clamped around your thigh) reminds you *why* she is still in such state.

"Don't try to distract me," You tell her, flipping her onto her back and resting your weigth top of her before she can do so much as blink.

She gasps, but doesn't try to fight you off. If anything, she gets more comfortable in her new position. Parting her legs to accomodate you better.

"I'm a woman on a mission." You state.

"O-oh?" The humor falls off her face then and her next breath catches a bit in her throat. "Really?" She tries to recover her previous bravado by flashing you a smirk of her own and quirking a teasing eyebrow, but the look wobbles as she is forced to gulp in the moment you reach down with one of your hands, sneaking it between your bodies.

Another, breathless gasp tears from her throat when you cup her sex in your palm, feeling the warmth of her seeping through the layer of fabric of her pants.

"*Really*." You confirm with a low purr.

"Catra..." Even just adding a little bit more of pressure against the seam has her eyes roll into the back of her head, her mouth falling open as she moans out your name, her hips jerking instinctively onto your touch as if in search for more while the rest of her body is struck by a powerful shiver that promptly reminds her of the need that is indeed still there, waiting for you to tend to it.

"You thought I forgot about this?" You ask, deliberately stroking her through the seam, clicking your tongue and slowly shaking your head from side to side. "No way in hell."

When she opens them again, her eyes have, if even possible, grown a shade darker.

"W-what are you going to do?"

You haven't even started yet and she is already stuttering.

Normally, hearing her voice shake like this would be an immense ego boost. Right now though you are far too preoccupied and impatient to settle between her legs (your mouth already watering just at the thought of it) to pay any mind to such a thing as meaningless as your inflated ego.

"Simple," You tell her, leaning in to whisper your wicked plan to her, preening when she shudders and whimpers at the feeling of your hot breath brushing her ear. "I'm going to show you exactly *how much* I enjoyed what you just did to me."

The way you growl almost makes it sound like a threat. But it's actually not so far off, because it's important that she gets the seriousness of this. "So there won't be any more misunderstandings about it."

. . .

You could spend hours with your face buried between the cradle of Adora's thighs, lapping at the seemingly infinite supply of sweetness that she provides you with every lick of your tongue and every suck of your lips.

(You actually have. More than once).

Actually, scratch that. Because you could make the whole act of pleasuring her with your mouth your new purpose in life.

The fact that you get as hard as a steel rod again within a minute of eating her out speaks for itself on how deeply it affects you, and the fact that you just ignore it says it all on how committed you are about her pleasure.

Your shaft may even start pounding anew with fullness, but you are far too drunk with the scent of her, with the taste of her on your tongue to properly acknowledge the need that has settled once more deep in your belly (something that you are grateful for). But nothing

prevents you from grinding, although completely unconsciously, against the silky sheets as you keep her thighs spread wide open and dine on the salty sweetness of her essence, listening to her moans and groans, reveling in each shudder of pleasure that runs through her body, marveling at the sight of her writhing, all lean muscles rippling and soft feminine curves that fit so perfectly in your hands.

She looks so pretty like this.

So open and eager.

So swollen and needy and *dripping*.

Simply put, the view from between her legs is one to die for. A true sight to behold.

One that you would like to prolong for an indefinite amount of time, like someone would with a particularly pretty sunset.

Thing is... she is more worked up than either of you realized. And while you would usually delight at the prospect of teasing her some more, of drawing this out to make her orgasm all the more intense, right now you simply want to show her how devoted you are to her and her pleasure. And it's not just because of something as empty and meaningless as reciprocation for what she has done earlier.

Sure, you may have phrased it that way, but it's something that goes far, *far* deeper than that.

"The Khajiit are a Matriarchal society ruled by Omegas who work tirelessly to keep the peace between the various tribes, settling disputes to avoid conflict in order to ensure the prosperity of their species as a whole." You remember reading in several of the history books you have been studying.

"In this society, and in every single pride, Alphas are given a chance to prove themselves worthy of an Omega's favor (and affections) through a series of trials, selected by the most esteemed and wise Matriarchs, which purpose would be to demonstrate the physical prowess as well as the cleverness and judgment of the candidates (for they mustn't compete in terms of brawn alone, but of wits also, to truly show their worth). Ultimately though, Omegas are given the final choice regarding the Alpha with whom they want to mate (for pleasure as well as for reproductive purposes) and spend the rest of their lives with."

(Honestly, you don't know why you feel the need to abide by the rules of your long dead species, but... that same, deeply rooted part of you that has only recently surfaced and which you are just beginning to discover, as you have found out, is pretty persuasive in its motivations about why you should care about something that has been denied to you your whole life; your origins. And perhaps, the fact that you may very well be the last one of your kind -on Etheria, at least- is the reason why it feels so important that you at least *consider* your people's customs. For all these things that you have been reading about the culture and history of your people so far make a lot of sense to you, especially considering your recent changes).

So yeah, there are a lot of similarities that match perfectly with your current relationship.

True- Adora may not be an Omega.

Hell... she doesn't even belong to your own *species.*

But you *have* gone through your own set of trials and tribulation in order to be together.

And one thing remains indisputable above all else:

She has chosen *you* as her mate.

More than that, you have chosen *each other*.

And according to your studies about how Khajiit's society worked, that's pretty much the equivalent of an actual, modern-day marriage in Etheria.

Something inside you, that same something ancient and primal embedded in your DNA that has growled at you to bite her that first night, to claim her - a bite that you now know should have been first inflicted upon you by your Omega before you could return it (which... *ooops*. Although, in your defense, it's not like you had anyone growing up with whom you could have had a proper conversation about the mating rituals revolving around the extinct species you have learned just a week ago you belong to) - is now also urging you to please her and devote yourself completely to her needs. To her pleasure.

Because: "*It's an Alpha's* duty *to tend to their Omega's needs."*

To hunt and provide shelter.

To challenge and drive away any other Alpha who threatens your union or doesn't respect it.

To make her safety and well-being your number one priority.

To cherish her like *Azurah*- the Goddess of Creation Herself.

To give her emotional comfort and support.

...to pass your best genes to her through your seed and give her many, many cubs.

You try not to think about that last bit too much, but the implications of the act required to reach that particular outcome inevitably has your body go up in flames with the intensity of your blush, making your knot grow impossibly hard.

You feel it throbbing with renewed need where it is pinned between your stomach and the mattress. So viciously and suddenly that you barely manage to muffle a growl against Adora's sex.

"Catra..."

Mercifully, your lover's moans and restless squirming redirects your attention back to her and her own needs, which you might have involuntarily neglected for a minute, caught up in your thoughts as you were.

"I'm right here, love." You reassure her. And to make it up to her you stop thinking too much and start mouthing wetly at her cunt instead, doubling your efforts with each, long, slow lick, making sure to cover every single inch of her slit, dipping low and into her tight opening with the tip of your tongue before drawing back, sealing your lips around the hard, swollen bud of her clit and *sucking* it into your mouth.

Her responses are, much to your utter delight, most enthusiastic and unabashedly loud.

She gets quite vocal in her pleasure. (Although that has not always been the case).

Her moans increase in frequency, as does her chanting of your name, all while her hips become possessed by a restless force that has them rocking repeatedly against your face. Searching for more of the warmth of your mouth.

And you give her everything. Even depriving yourself of oxygen by refusing to pull back in order to properly breathe. But apparently, it still isn't enough.

"C-Catra..." Adora calls for you again, the note of urgency in her voice, making it shake, and the feeling of a hand slipping into your mane to give a gentle, yet firm tug, has you look up at her.

You gaze past the firm valley of her quivering stomach and the twin, glorious mounds of her soft breasts further up to meet her gaze.

"Please..." She pants, breathlessly.

Her pupils are blown wide, her eyes so dark and glossy, like pure obsidian, that you can barely make out a trace of blue inside them anymore.

The sight of the raw want reflected in them is enough to steal what little breath you had in your lungs. Your entire body stiffening, and it's only then that you have stopped that you realize that you have been grinding, this whole time, against the sheets, unconsciously trying to bring a smidgen of relief to your aching shaft.

You swallow in an attempt to bring some moisture to your throat, made absurdly, inexplicably dry (in a logic defying way, given the activity you have been devoting yourself to for the past five minutes).

"Tell me what you need." You ask her.

Usually, you don't need her to make her needs known, for you have grown particularly capable of reading through her and what she wants. But now... The way she is looking at you. The pure hunger that you find reflected into the obsidian that her eyes have turned into... is so *raw*. So *visceral*. So primal... It makes you core clench on itself and your shaft swell even further, pounding with its own heartbeat.

She couldn't *possibly* mean what crosses your mind for the split second you drown into the liquid desire pooled in her eyes.

Except... she is.

"Grind against me."

Your jaw drops open and eyes almost pop out of your skull at her request, which makes her flush into an incandescent shade of red, but between her flustered state and the need that is making her shake all over, the former simply doesn't stand a chance against the latter.

"Please... I'm... *so close.*" She says. "A-and I know you are, too. I... just... I want to *feel you*."

Underneath the shock, you can't help but be impressed by how eloquently she phrases her request considering how far gone she currently is.

Although you have to admit that she has always been brave in voicing what she needs, what she wants (once she has realized *what* it is that she actually wanted, of course). It's something you might have envied of her once- the way she made up her mind so quickly. Now however... it's a trait that you can't help but admire.

And that's why you feel so torn upon hearing her request.

Because it's not like you could ever deny her *anything*. But you can't simply dismiss the harsh truth either.

And while you trust in the fact that you would never hurt her, ever again, (either emotionally or physically) you can't trust the wild, savage, slavering beast that trashes inside you and which urges have *commanded* you to bite her that night. Same way you can't trust the burning, greedy lust that you see flickering in her dark eyes.

It's just as reliable as your own; once you sate its thirst, it receeds, but you can never take back what you did in order to sate it in the first place.

And at the moment, you can confidently say that neither of you are anywhere near being lucid enough to make a choice that could potentially lead you to something you aren't prepared for.

Because what if, with how wet and slick she is, you were to just accidentally slip? What if you nudge her or poke her in a way that is the opposite of pleasurable? And *what if* you get so caught up that you delude yourselves of the fact that she can take you without any kind of preparation and end ruining what was supposed to be a mutually enjoyable, magical experience?

No. You won't allow that.

There is no amount of lust or raging hormones that could convince you otherwise. Ever.

And maybe, the fact that you are clear-headed enough to reason in such way says more about your self control than you had given yourself credit for.

But even *that* doesn't change the decision you have already reached.

"I'm sorry." You tell her at last, your features contorted in actual heartbreak, your voice coming out barely above a whisper, sincerely pained for denying her of this.

But you can't.

You just *can't*.

Not yet at least.

You are still adjusting to your new changes, and you know that you would never be able to forgive yourself if you were to hurt her again in any way.

First, before you can feel comfortable enough to even entertain the thought you'll have to master your self control and learn how to tame that beast that is constantly scratching savagely under your skin and *demanding* to come out and *claim her*.

Until then, there are *other* things you can do to bring pleasure to you lover.

A sound in between a choked sob and a whimper of disapproval falls from Adora's lips the moment you deny her lust-addled request, but you quickly turn that noise into a sharp, loud moan by diving back face-first into her cunt and sealing your lips around her clit, lapping at it with the tip of your tongue while sneaking a hand just under your chin, pressing two fingers against her slick, tight opening.

You meet no resistance whatsoever when you slip inside of her.

Your fingers sliding in deep. Right to your third knuckle in one single thrust.

You groan in unison at the feeling. Adora's hips jerking up to take you that tiny bit deeper, relishing in the fullness of the sudden intrusion while you try not to be driven completely insane by the welcoming, silky heat clutching so *tightly* at you that for a moment you can't even move, can't even breathe by how overwhelming it feels.

And let's be honest- it's impossible not to feel such velvety-soft tighteness wrapped around your fingers and think about how her walls would feel like stretched tight and stuggling to accomodate the generous girth of your-

"Uugh!"

Your knot gives a simpathetic, mighty throb at the exquisite image your brain has just conjured up, in such vivid details that you actually *felt it* in your groin.

It makes it that much harder for you to concentrate, but you *are*, as you said, a woman on a mission. And so, gathering what little mental focus you can spare, you search purposefully for that sweet little spot located on her spongy, swollen front wall and-

"Aahhh!"

There.

Adora cries out when you find it and start stroking it by curling your fingers against it over and over again while switching between lapping and sucking at her clit.

She starts shaking all over. Thrashing.

Chanting your name and babbling an incessant, approving string of "yes, yesyesyes!" interspersed by another one of "don't stop, don'tstop *dontstop!"*, until even words become too much and she can only manage to make sounds. (The most exquisite kinds).

And that's how you know that you have her.

You glance up just in time to see her go stiff after a particularly hard thrust of your fingers followed by that curling gesture deep inside her.

Her mouth falls open in a soundless scream and her head tilts back against the pillows, exposing the exquisite, vulnerable, delicate column of her throat... and the mark etched proudly at its side.

Hurriedly, you slip another finger inside her, suck her clit into your mouth one last time and *watch* as she falls apart. Feasting your eyes on the most beautiful sight you have ever witnessed.

She comes quietly, but that's probably because of the harsh series of shudders that rock through her entire body, leaving her breathless and making her ripple viciously around your fingers. Squeezing you over and over again, trying to draw you *deeper* almost as if *milking them* and-

And fuck...

Oh fuck.

Fuck!

That image of a minute ago flares once more in your mind and, embarrassingly enough, combined with the feeling of her velvety warmth rippling around your digits, it's enough to push you over the edge you have been straddling for what feels like an eternity.

"Uugh!" Your cry gets muffled against her flesh as your knot gives a heavy twich and you are powerless to do anything but come. Spilling your release in the tiny, cramped space between your stomach and the mattress, rutting shamelessly against the sheets, *desperate* for any kind of contact you can get. Even if it is just the scratch of cool fabric against your sensitive, heated flesh.

It's nothing, almost an insult compared to the warmth and pressure that you have experienced earlier with Adora's hand wrapped around you. But it's enough to soothe that deep, visceral ache that had once again resided deep in your groin.

You try to guide Adora through her aftershock while also riding the waves of your own orgasm. Lapping eagerly at the juices she has rewarded your efforts and devotion with, while gently massagging her inner walls, drawing out every last shudder of pleasure just like you try to do by humping the mattress, feeling the sticky mess of your warm come pooling between your stomach and the now completely *ruined* sheets.

It takes a while, but by the time you have finished spilling every last drop, Adora is also slumping back onto the pillows, bonelessly. Twitching all over with overstimulation and panting heavily.

She looks throughly ravaged.

In the most exquisite way imaginable.

And the feeling of satisfaction that fills you at the realization, at the sight of her like this is even better than the orgasm you have just experienced.

Gently, with extreme carefulness, you start to ease your fingers out of her, soothing her whimpers of discomfort (as well as the feeling of loss) by pressing kisses to the inside of her thighs, licking at whatever patch of wetness you happen to come across.

You never seem to be able to get your fill of her.

And that's why you are more than happy to keep lapping at her, inhaling her scent, unable to deny how the sweet, salty taste of her arousal seems to calm the wild beast that keeps growling inside you.

You keep licking her until she is perfectly clean.

Until the hand hooked onto the back of your neck gives a gentle tug and urges you up.

You don't waste a second to crawl up her body at the invitation, but before you can even make it past her navel, Adora bends forward and dips down to capture your lips in a kiss.

Unexpectedly, it is impossibly soft and slow. Filled with tenderness and affection. And you relish in it even more than if it were hungry and fervent.

The easy rhythm and infinite gentleness in it puts you in a post-orgasmic trance of sorts. Your muscles going lax, and your mind growing quiet at last. Barely noticing it when you get laid down onto the bed.

And it's only then, only when you lie sated and safely in each other arms, breathing in each other scent, that it finally feels like completion.

. . .

It took two massive, life altering orgasms, but your knot has finally, at long last, gone soft. Resting innocently against your thigh. Looking much smaller and a lot more innocuous. But just to be safe you have decided it best to reverse your usual cuddling position, with Adora draped over your side instead of you spooning her from behind. This way your hands are kept from roaming too far and freely over her exquisite curves - an act that no matter how

innocent your intentions might be, could still very easily end up stirring your knot back into fullness once again.

"I'm sorry." She whispers apologetically to you for the forth or fifth time against your ear before pressing the softest kiss to its furry tip. It tickles. And your ear flicks in response.

For the forth or fifth time you sigh. "Adora-"

"I just don't know what came over me back there."

A raspy bark of a laugh tumbles past your lips, sounding equally exhasperated and genuinely amused because- "Okay, first of all, that's *my line*. And second-" You turn just enough to be able to look her in the eyes. "Would you please *stop already?* I told you, it's okay. I perfectly understand the urge you felt."

You do. Probably even more than she could ever comprehend. And that's why she needs to stop apologizing for almost giving into them by uttering that... admitedly delicious request.

Your firm statement and the gentle reassurance that she finds in your eyes seem to finally placate her.

She sighs, clearly not completely satisfied yet but willing to acquiesce.

It lasts for about two seconds before her brow furrows with a sudden thought. (One that has been poking at the back of your mind for this whole time).

"Do you think it's because of-"

"The bite?" You finish for her, gnawing at the inside of your cheek, considering the possibility. "Yeah, probably. I mean... George and Lance told us it was going to affect both of us." Something about your hormones now also being into Adora's bloodstream and affecting her body's chemistry, altering it (as well as some of her body functions) to be in sync with yours, you recall, but the details aren't so relevant. They surely didn't keep you from almost giving in when she *begged* you to grind your knot against her-

Nope.

Not going there.

Nuh uh.

Can't risk waking up the beast again after you finally managed to put it to sleep.

"Catra?"

Luckily, you can always count on Adora to drag you back to the present and away from dangerously sexy thoughts that she herself has triggered. (Oh... the irony of it!)

"Mh?" You turn to look at her, still trailing your fingers lazily up and down her back, finding her biting her bottom lip. Her blue eyes so big and open and *bright*.

"About what you said earlier when you came back and we talked... I just want you to know that I, too, would *never* want you to do *anything* you aren't comfortable with or aren't ready for."

Your heart nearly melts within your chest at her words of reassurance. An impossibly soft smile curling on your lips, your eyes going all soft at her earnest consideration of your own comfort. Truthfully, it's a totally unnecesary remark, but it doesn't make it any less sweet to hear it out loud.

"And I'm glad you were strong enough to resist it," She continues before you can say a word, "Because... I honestly don't think I would have if our positions were reversed."

"Okay. You gotta *stop* saying stuff like that, 'Dora." You reprimand her with a groan, trying not to think about her straddling you- *riding you*.

In response, Adora offers you a sheepish, flustered, guilty and apologetic little smile that is far too endearing.

Endearing enough to persuade you to let her off the hook.

Well... for this time at least.

And only because you feel like there is something important that you need to set straight about boundries.

"I'm glad we are on the same page about wanting to wait before doing anything that neither of us is ready for." You tell her. "But you have to know that it doesn't mean I don't want you, Adora. I always want you." Sometimes so much you can barely think straight. "Just like you always have my consent."

You don't have to explain and specify the circumstances or the intricacies of that statement.

Since the very first time you got naked and... *intimate*... she has been nothing but considerate and respectful.

You both have.

Among all the things that have changed recently, *that* definitely hasn't.

And after all that went on between the two of you in this room in the past several hours she knows *exactly* what you mean by that. What you are comfortable and uncomfortable doing now that you are no longer frightened and are starting to get more familiar with this new part of your body (and the idea of her touching you in many different ways).

To prove that she understand, she smiles knowingly at you, if a bit dorkily.

"Really?" She asks, her eyes shinning so beautifully.

You snort and roll your eyes, but there is an undeniable smile curled at the corner of your mouth.

"Of course, you big doofus."

Her smile stretches further and her eyes glint, although... in a way that makes your feline senses tingle in warning.

And with good reason, you realize, given what she says next.

"Sooo... if I were to say that we both probably need a shower after all we just did, would you-
"

Nope!

"Consent denied!" You exclaim, jumping from the bed in one leap and at a safe, out-of-reach distance, throwing the sheets at Adora's face for good measure.

She shrieks and splutters, wading through the yards of fabric, fixing you with an incredulous look when she finally emerges from the wrinkled, messy tangle, blowing her bangs out of her face.

"*Seriously* Catra?!"

You narrow your eyes at her, watching out for any sudden movement. (She may move around like Miss Clumsy McKlutz ninety percent of the time, but she can also be surprisingly fast and shockingly graceful if she is motivated enough. And for reasons that go beyond your comprehension, this whole showering business seems like a top priority for her at the moment. So better stay alert).

"Consent. *Denied.*" You repeat taking a step back when she tosses the (stained beyond salvation) sheets aside and stands from the bed.

She crosses her arms over her chest and stares you down. "Do you *seriously* want to attend dinner with the entire Princess Alliance covered in... u-uh..." She trails off, making a vague gesture with her hand. The flush of annoyance that was there scalding her face two seconds ago shifting into an actually flustered blush tinged a particularly bright shade of crimson.

"Yep!" You exclaim before she can resume. "I can and I will." You swear, one hundred percent serious.

You thought that you were simply going to groom yourself, like usual. But then you think about attending dinner all disheveled and smelling of sweat and sex.

You think about the look of approval that Mermista would most definitely try to conceal behind one of her signature eye rolls... in contrast to the look of absolute *horror* and righteous indignation that would twist Glimmer's face.

Ha! It might be the time she finally explodes in a puff of smoke rather than glitter.

Ooooh, it's so tempting that now you simply *have* to do it!

"Whatever it is that you are thinking," Adora warns, taking a menacing step forward, having read right into the malicious grin that has taken over your face without you realizing it (dammit!). "Keep in mind that I can always just transform and *dunk you* into the Ocean."

Now *that* has you torn.

Because while the prospect of seeing Adora transforming is kind of appealing, skinny-dipping in the middle of the Ocean ain't really your thing since water is still a huge no-no for you.

(You really have to come up with a safe word about the whole "bathing" subject. It's too stressful approaching it out of nowhere).

Ultimately, you decide that it may not be worthy. Especially considering what *salt water* does to your fur.

Yikes.

And so, you listen to your conscience and, more specifically, to your reason, which (same as your instincts) is also telling you to be a grown-ass Alpha, stop your whining, and just do as your Omega slash not-Omega girlfriend slash Mistress commands.

(After all, it's "*your duty"*.)

"Ugh! Fine!" You bark, throwing your arms up in surrender and grunting, turning on your heel and storming off towards the bathroom with your fists clenched at your sides before you can see the look of smug satisfaction settling over Adora's features.

Just to be safe though, once you get in the shower you make sure to adjust the settings of the water to glacial freezing *cold* since there are some particularly *filthy* images still swimming about it your head that just need to get washed away. Just like your body needs to be cooled down or you might not make it through dinner tonight.

...that is to say if Adora plans for you to actually *attend* such dinner.

Because when she finally joins you in the bathroom and enters your walk in shower a couple of minutes later, completely naked except for a look of absolute determination sitting over the flush of light pink coloring her cheeks, stepping so close to you that you are forced with your back against the cold marble wall tiles... you get a whole other vibe off of her.

"There is another thing I've been curious about trying." She confesses, her blush spreading further down her neck, warming her fair complexion into something exquisite. "That is if you are okay with it, too, of course." She quickly adds.

"W-what is it?" You ask her, swallowing thickly as a swirl of excitement, apprehension and anticipation twists in your stomach.

As if sensing your fluttering nerves though, Adora simply smiles tenderly at you and leans closer.

She kisses you so very softly.

Merely a feather-light touch of her lips lingering against yours for no more than a handful of seconds.

But it's enough to melt your worries and turn them into a puddle of soft, warm, gooey emotions.

"If it's the same for you," She whisper against your lips as she draws back. "I'd rather show you."

Still a bit stunned by the unexpected tenderness of that kiss, you don't quite manage to recover readily enough to ask her what she means by that.

But you don't have to.

Because your eyes flutter open just in time to see her sinking to her knees.

Chapter End Notes

Me, posting: Man, I really oughta start writing shorter chapters.

Me, one week later: *writes an entire chapter of smut that is 4k longer than the previous one*.
Eh. I'll start updating less often then. Besides, let's be real, I'm two years too late into this fandom, no many left lurking around anyway, and definitely no one's interested in the pile of sin this fic is about to turn into. So what's the rush? You should relax and take your time, Jay! Enjoy the ride, dude! Be a real knot-tease!

Me: Alright! *methodically applies sunscreen, slips on shades, lies on a deckchair, takes a sip of virgin margarita ('cause alcohol dehydrates)..... and gets back to writing.*

Effects of changed conditions

Chapter Summary

Catra acts all professional and smooth af.

Glimmer nearly pops a blood vessel.

Adora tries on something green.

Chapter Notes

Warnings: abuse of fantasy lore from several sources, because, as I have already warned y'all (and in case you forgot) I'm a hopeless nerd who can't be trusted to resist the temptation to get Universes from overlapping. Catch them all and you get Easter eggs bonuses. Add some veggies and you got dinner ready. The pepper is towards the end.

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She is stunning.

A true sight to behold.

Absolutely resplendent and perfectly composed. Every single inch of her.

There is not a strand of hair out of place. Not a single crease in her dress. Not a blemish on her alabaster, flawless skin.

She stands tall and gorgeous and radiant.

Even the slowly setting sun seems to linger several minutes longer than usual just to brighten the Great Hall and shine its rays on her some more. As if envious of the Moons taking over such honor once it will retreat to slumber underneath the horizon.

But you know better.

You know that such glow comes from within her, and from the dress she has decided to wear: a simple, pure white, old-fashioned, ankle-length frock adorned with golden shoulder straps. A pair of flat golden slippers at her feet to match, and a simple tiara with a single gem sitting at its center, serving both as a humble ornament meant to state her Royal Title of Princess,

but mostly as an accessory to hold back her loose, flowing hair (because she couldn't care less about proclaiming her status).

It doesn't change the fact that she looks so very regal wearing it.

A real Princess, as depicted in a Fairytale book.

And you can't believe that you had the *privilege* to walk into the dining room with her at your arm.

You still can't believe that she is *yours.*

Even with an illustrious guest among you - which... ooops, you kinda forgot about who tonight's dinner guest was going to be (apparently, you *did* have something planned to do that afternoon rather than have an existential crisis) all the eyes in the room are drawn to Adora with that same sense of wonder that you are still experiencing on a daily basis. Taking in her appearance. Praising it with earnest compliments tempered by a measure of surprise.

(Or maybe they were all staring at you because you might have arrived more than "fashionably late". Oh, well...)

When Scorpia first saw her earlier in the hallway leading to the dining room, her dark eyes had lit up like two shooting stars, barely managing to hold back a shriek (for decorum's sake, as well as to not alert the guards) at the sight of her in that dress. In response, Adora, not yet used to people looking at her in such manner, had (quite predictably) blushed so very prettily right to the tip of her ears, shuffling a bit in place but grinning from ear to ear. Her blue eyes positively *sparkling* as she looked down at her attire for the evening, overly pleased with her choice.

Because here's another thing about your lover that only the few people really close to her know.

Adora loves dresses.

Like... *loves them.*

Only recently she has started being less self conscious about wearing them. Almost as if she was supposed to feel embarrassed simply for liking them.

Not that she ever had a reason to feel such way. (You still dream about that first Princess Prom. About how *good* she looked wearing that sleevless, red halter gown).

But yeah... Ever since the end of the war, without doom looming over your heads, Adora has been delighting in the simplest things. Be it pleasure reading, tasting new food (something she is always up to do) or trying on new clothes. As banal as it may sound, she is fascinated by the different styles she has encountered so far during your travels around the planet. And how can anyone *possibly* blame her for taking joy in something seemingly so basic when all her life she has only ever worn the same, faded, scratchy, purely tactical, military-issued uniforms?

A crime, really, considering not simply how lovely she looks wearing gowns, but the look of utter *joy* that lights up her entire face, that digs *dimples* in her cheeks for how big she smiles whenever she wears one and steps up in front of a mirror, laughter spilling from her lips when she gives it a spin, looking as joyous and innocent and carefree as a child.

Every time you are blessed enough to witness such sight, you fear that it might be the last for the way your heart swells, far beyond its capacity, with a warm surge of affection that fills all of its chambers at once.

Because this is what Adora has always deserved. What has been denied to her; the chance to delight in the most pedestrian activities. To grow up cared for and with no concerns, like any other little girl you saw around Etheria, to be happy and play dress up. Because let's admit it, anyone else can think whatever they like and have their own stereotypical opinions about it, but it doesn't change the fact that Adora- strong, tough-as-nail, brave, self-sacrificing Adora- is, plainly and simply, quite a girly girl.

Correction: she is young *woman* who obsesses over her hair (maybe a bit too much), secretely gathers the ingredients and *prepares* her own organic conditioner (which you may also poach from time to time, given the way it leaves your own fur impossibly soft and all sweet-smelling whenever you use it) and who likes to dress up and just... look *pretty*. And not exclusively for formal events.

It doesn't diminish how fierce she is in battle.

It doesn't make her less of a force of nature to be reckoned with.

And yet, some people *stare* and some other people *talk*, and you would just *love* to *smack* (possibly with a grain flail) some sense into some of those grossly antiquated heads that think that her being feminine doesn't seem in character with her alter ego. That it makes her look... *soft.* (As if She-Ra didn't go around dispersing justice and helping the oppressed wearing a freaking *mini skirt*).

Yeah well, fuck 'em all and their nonsensical double standards, because the people who know her and care about her are thrilled by this new change, by how mature and *grown up* she looks.

She even rarely wears her old, beloved red jacket and uniform anymore.

(And that may be more symbolic than you might actually realize; those days are over. They are behind you. And now... Now you are both committed to look forward and to a - hopefully - brighter future).

But all of that is beside the point.

Because her change in attire, the way she carries herself, the radiance that she seems to emit with a simple smile, with her very presence in the room, is not the only reason why it's getting harder and harder for you to take your eyes off her nowadays.

Not the reason you have been sneaking glances at her from across the table for the entire dinner.

Unfortunately, despite how furtive your exchange of fleeting glances and flustered smiles has been, they *definitely* haven't gone unnoticed.

"So, not only does my Court Advisor show up to my dinner party half an hour late, but she had *also* decided to eye-sex her girlfriend in the middle of it!" Glimmer hisses at you later when all the guests have moved from the dining room to stand and chat and eat dessert in the Grand Hall.

You glance at her, standing at your side by the life-size statue of some half naked nymph, and at a discrete, out-of-earshot distance from anyone else, and while she may still be smiling to keep up appearances, she is also somehow managing to look at you as if she might be this close from actually having steam coming out of her ears.

Now *that* would be quite the spectacle, never mind the fireworks and pyrotechnics that Sea Hawk is always trying to get approval for as entertainment.

The fact that she is *such a prude* makes it all the harder for you to actually stop eyeing Adora across the room the same way Entrapta is currently eyeing all the tiny pastries at the dessert table, looking both delighted and quite tormented by the many choices available- seriously *too many.*

"Chill out, Sparkles." You huff, reaching for one of the flutes of champagne neatly arranged on a nearby table. "I'm here, aren't I?"

"*Yes.*" She grits out through a tight smile before hissing under her breath, "But you forgot about the Duchess of Val Montaigne *also being here*." That last part is practically a growl (and yeah, alright, your bad for forgetting) but what is most impressive is that she *still* manages to keep her polite smile in place while her face is starting to glow into an indignant, enraged shade of red.

It does not affect you in the way she thinks it should though. But you wisely decide to keep your amusement for yourself and simply answer her with a nonchalant, bored tone.

"Again. I remembered, didn't I?"

And here goes the first puff of steam.

"When you saw her!" She splutters.

Seriously. The glitter bomb gotta *relax*, or the poor cleaning staff will have to scrape their own Queen's innards off the walls.

You sigh and turn to properly look her in the eye.

"Haven't I performed my duties as an Advisor and-" You readily interrupt her with a raised hand when, predictably, she opens her mouth to complain. "*And* made it up for my tardiness by engaging the Duchess in a charming conversation about her homeland?"

Glimmer glowers at you. But can't dispute.

She can't dare to even *try*.

Because yeah, sure, you were late, but one look at the Dutchess and you remembered *everything* that was worth remembering. Not only about her, personally, but also about the current welfare of the Duchy.

Initial mortification aside you have always been pretty quick to recover. Always landing on your feet, as they say. And despite being somehow new to your roles as a Diplomat slash Court Advisor slash War Strategist for the Kingdom of Brightmoon, you have learned quickly the best, most successful way to deal with nobility: looking humble, show mild curiosity about their customs, and get *them* to *talk* while you smile and nod along.

Usually, your natural charm aids you in making the whole scam look flawless. But tonight you didn't even have to fake interest; The Duchess is, truly, a remarkable woman. Not that chatty though (for nobility standards anyway), but some of the things she shared at the table have surely piqued the entire Alliance's interest, as well as yours.

When, after a minute, Glimmer is still silently glowering at you and grinding her jaw as if doing her very best to search for a way to chastise you but coming up empty, you dare flashing her a smirk.

"That's what I thought." You chirp trumphantly, bringing your glass to your lips and taking a delicate sip.

"Ugh. Whatever." She grunts, crossing her arms and looking ahead to her guest pleasantly interacting with each other. "What took you and Adora so long to get here anyway?"

And just like that, in an attempt to *not* spit out your drink and risk a diplomatic incident by spraying the bratty, prude Queen of Brightmoon in vertiginously expensive, imported sparkling wine, you almost end up choking to death on it.

Warm, soft velvet wrapped all around you. A silky tongue swirling around, lapping at the wetness spilling out of you in thick spurts. The firm pressure of rosy lips gliding down your throbbing shaft, of her cheeks hollowing, of her throat closing around your broad tip as she sucks *and* swallows*, of a soft hand wrapped around your knot's base, stroking you. Squeezing you. Pumping you to make up for the fact that she can't take you all. Urging you to empty yourself of every single drop you have- per her request.*

"Come," She had said, her voice deep and breathless, her eyes so impossibly dark and gleaming. *"I want to know what you taste like."*

A plea to which you have responded as if it were a command.

Mild, slightly sweet, and with a subtle note of bitterness, was the answer that you have tasted from her own mouth when you had hoisted her up and kissed her deeply and with voracity. Your bodies burning even under the cold spray of the shower...

"Helloooo? Etheria to Catra, are you there?"

You snap out of the memory with a start, blinking and looking around, for a moment surprised to find yourself back in the Grand Hall, until you regain proper focus and are met with Glimmer's disappointed (slightly worried) scowl.

"U-uh?" You ask, eloquently, blinking stupidly some more.

"Sheesh." She makes a face and looks closely at you. "The fuck is up with you lately?"

Luckily, it seems you have recovered from your near-death experience with the sparkling wine quickly enough. But an excuse to justify your tardiness doesn't come so readily, far too preoccupied about whether your wildly beating heart may be audible. (Or if *something* in your pants might have stirred with the intensity of that memory and made itself more *visible*).

"I... u-uh... had to choose the proper attire." It's what you settle for at last. And it's not quite a lie since one of your favorite shirts *has* ended up torn to piece and stained beyond salvation, under mysterious circumstances.

"And I didn't have many choices left since your dumb tailor has messed up my measurements." He hasn't, the poor dwarf mushroom fellow. But you *have* to blame *someone* if you don't want to declare the *reason* why all your pants feel waaaay too tight all of a sudden. Which is kind of a strange thing having to get used to since you have always had a slim waist and clingy stuff has been your signature style for as far as you can remember.

But... even you have to admit that your knot can't be blamed for the way your *jackets* and *vests* have started to feel a bit too tight recently, you think while loosening yet another button at the collar of your ruffled shirt.

The gesture, for how insignificant, happens to gain Glimmer's attention.

She eyes you curiously.

You eye her back.

"What?"

"I knew I noticed something different about you lately. Couldn't quite put my finger on it though until now..."

Oh no.

Does she...?

Has *she...?*

"W-what you mean? There is nothing different about me!" You conclude with a nervous laugh, trying to keep an aloof appearance by taking another sip of champagne, making sure that this one goes straight down the right pipe even though, internally, you are freaking. the fuck. *Out.*

Shit. *Shit.* Shit!

Does she know?

Did Adora tell her?

No. No she wouldn't have.

But fuck. What if she *saw* it?!

Hurriedly, you glance down at your crotch and... let out a sigh of relief when you see that your new... equipment is well concealed and *not* trying to get anyone's attention. For once.

"That's it!" Glimmer announces, snapping her fingers and snatching your attention back to her and the grin splitting her face. "You have been training more haven't you? Yes, that's it! You look... a bit broader here, around the shoulders." She even wiggles her eyebrows suggestively. "Want to keep up with She-Ra, uh?"

You blink.

The *fuck?*

She might as well have just slapped you across the face with an octopus for how bewildered you are left by that statement.

Then your brain hurriedly catches up. A long string of information and a bout of realization following suit.

Things about hormones and high spikes of GH and tastysterone or tastotrine (or whatever it is they are called, 'cause you may be committed to learn about your changing body, but it's hard to remember every single term that you read about in your chemistry-centered studies) start fluttering about in your head, reminding you of that little race you had in the woods with Adora, of how reactive your muscles have felt, making you realize that you might, as a matter of fact, have gotten a bit sturdier.

...or maybe your breasts perhaps got somehow *bigger.*

(You make a mental note to flex in the mirror later and check out for yourself it that's the case).

For the moment though you are so relieved to be left off the hook that you stumble over your words to agree with her.

"T-that's right!" You announce. "I gotta keep up with my girl. Also- you have been feeding me better than I have been my entire life, so that helps. Thanks by the way." You say, tilting your glass at her.

"You're welcome. But what would you say to perhaps show your gratitude by giving a tour of the gardens to the Duchess, *Lord Strategist*?" She suggests, no doubt hinting to what the Dutchess said earlier at dinner regarding not ever having seen Nightshades, for they don't bloom in her regions.

You sigh, trying to wriggle your way out of this even though you know that you won't be able to. *Still...* "Perfuma knows lots more about flowers that I do." You point out.

"Perfuma isn't the Queen of Brightmoon, nor your boss though, is she? And the Duchess is here to make an Alliance with *us*."

"Then why don't you-" But you stop right there. A spark of realization flickering in your mind at the sudden thought, bright enough to cast light into this perplexing matter.

"Oooh, i see it now." You grin, wide and obnoxiously. "You need *my* silver tongue, uh? You two got beef? Need *my charm* to smooth things over?"

Glimmer's eyes narrow down to two murderous slits.

"How about I smooth you over with a hand wringer instead if you don't stop right now and go get the Duchess. You *know* what is at stake here, Catra."

You do. But the *Queen* should be way more concerned about her blood pressure at the moment rather than your pending deal. And that's why you merely acknowledge her empty threat with a smirk, setting down your barely touched glass of champagne on a tray and going for an utterly unnecessary, deep, mocking bow that would cost anyone else's their head.

"As Her Majesty commands."

With that, you leave the Queen's grunting, fuming-with-rage side, and approach the Duchess, who is currently engaged in a seemingly pleasant conversation with none other than Adora, who beams upon seeing your approach, a sight that has your heart trip over itself. Luckily, your feet are far more obedient, preventing you from stumbling over them and causing a scene.

"Good evening again, Your Grace," This bow is far more modest and appropriate. "And to you, Your Highness." And the wink that you throw at Adora is only for her to catch (and to promptly blush in response to).

Duchess Yvonne "Evie" Blanchard, ruler of the Dutchy of Val Montaigne and three times winner of the Chevalier Tournament, turns to greet you with an equally pleasant and particularly bright smile. And it's somehow refreshing. (No one in the Alliance has ever

greeted you with such warmth the first time. Well... all except for Scorpia, but she is utterly incapable of being anything else other than kind).

"Ser Catra." She even tilts her head in the slightest bow. "I was hoping you'd come to find me. There is so much I still want to discuss with you."

Summoning your patience and charm doesn't take that much effort either. Who knows, you might actually enjoy the more diplomatic side of your job for once.

"Certainly. And perhaps we can continue our conversation in the gardens? As I recall, Her Grace mentioned earlier to never having seen the Nightshades in bloom. May I interest you in a stroll?"

It's easy to play nice and act pleasantly when the person you are meant to discuss business with is not one of those self-important, haughty nobles. And Duchess Yvonne is a woman who has earned her title, like you. Who has fought in the front lines, *like you*. And who isn't afraid to do whatever it takes to win. You certainly share many similarities.

"You may." She takes your proffered arm and then turns to bid a sincerely warm farewell to Adora. "Thank you for regaling me with your fascinating tales, She-Ra. It's been a pleasure and an honor."

Adora, on her part, doesn't correct her about the name, blushes, and returns the sentiment in earnest. "The honor was all mine, Your Grace."

They exchange a polite smile before those two stunning blue eyes fix on you.

"Come find me later?" She asks, the question reduced into a whisper so low that only your acute hearing is able to pick up among the many sounds mingling in the lively Grand Hall, and when you do, you smile softly at her, mouthing an affirmative, *"Of course."*

You know then that you should probably move and get going, but your feet feel rooted to the very ground.

Every single molecule of your body aching for being denied the closeness that it craves to hers, and your lips tingle for how badly you want to kiss her.

But all you can do now, for decorum sake's, is simply smile at her, hoping that she can see the promise you hold in it about your intentions of making it up to her (later. Possibly multiple times in a row) before turning your attention back to the Duchess.

"Shall we, Your Grace?"

With a nod, you are off.

Needles to say, you can feel many, many eyes on you as you make your way outside. And it makes you quite uneasy, even if you have no reason to feel such way. Even if what you are doing - looking for some privacy elsewhere to discuss boring, yet necessary details to cement a new alliance - is literally part of *your job*.

For how hard you try however, you can't quite shake off how... *wrong*... it feels leaving the room with anyone other than Adora at your arm. But...

You heave a silent, inward sigh.

For how appealing the idea of locking yourselves in your chambers and carve the words "do not disturb" with your claws on the door, you can't just ignore your duties forever. Half the planet still needs your help with dealing with the post war *mess*.

Still, the regret and sense of melancholy lingers, striking you even harder when you make it to the gardens; at night, in this time of the year, they truly are a sight to behold.

The flowers in bloom, their lovely arrangements, the vines crawling suggestively up the outdoor furniture, the luminescent green insects buzzing about, as well as the blue mushrooms glowing intermittently, create such a peaceful, romantic ambience that your thought drift inevitably back to Adora.

(How you wish she were here with you...)

Although, you have to admit that the Duchess isn't terrible company.

As a matter of fact, she may be more down to earth than any other pompous noble you have ever met and had the displeasure of dealing with outside of the Alliance.

"I have heard a lot about you, Ser Catra." The Duchess confesses casually while closely inspecting the stunning streaks of color of the Nightshade bloom delicately cupped in her palm. "Beautiful." She murmurs to herself.

"Just Catra, Your Grace." You politely correct her. "I'm afraid my knighthood is still pending."

To that, she stands from her crunched position near the ground and turns her attention back to you with a look of mild surprise. Still, she doesn't question the reason why, simply accepting it.

"Very well then, Soon-to-be Ser *Just Catra*." She jests, flashing you a smirk, and you are once again grateful for your fur covering the warmth that you can feel blooming on your cheeks.

"Tell me though, is what they say about you all true?"

Well... there is *a lot* of talk revolving around you. And, unfortunately (but also realistically) not all of it is flattery and praises.

"That depends. Is there something in particular that Her Grace wishes to know?"

She taps her chin with one finger and makes a pensive, humming noise, but it's entirely fabricated. You can see it in the mischievous glint sparkling in her rich, amber-colored eyes.

"A recounting of your most recent exploits, to start with. And please, don't hold back on the gory details. I don't know why everyone thinks that by sparing me from those they are doing me a favor."

Upon hearing that you can't help but laugh out loud.

Fucking *finally* there is someone who can properly, objectively face the fact that post-war affairs aren't all about treaties and negotiations. Sometimes violence is still required. Threats of imprisonment and torture come up more often than the rest of the Princesses care to acknowledge. Well... except Mermista.

And so, you wander the gardens for a while, admiring the arrangements of flowers and plants and talking mostly about the war, about how His self-proclaimed Lordship Prime, despite having been sent into the Void by She-Ra, has still managed to leave the world in shambles, ruled by chaos, and how the Alliance's Appointed Advisor and Strategist (*you*) is handling driving away the remaining forces while also dealing with outlaws trying to run the nearly destroyed towns, causing all sort of troubles and mayhem, trying to profit off the limited resources and taking advantage of the general crisis.

Of course, the Duchess needs your help for a similar situation in the lands surrounding the Duchy of Val Montaigne before things can get further out of hand, and by the time she openly admits that, you have made it to the backyard, and more specifically to the section reserved for the training of the Palace guards.

"May I interest you in a duel, Ser Catra?" She asks, already approaching the armory closet and curiously inspecting the blades within.

Apparently, persuading her to call you anything else has proved futile. Not... that you actually *mind* the title. As the Dutchess said earlier it does have *"a nice ring to it- be it official or not yet,"* and considering all your achievements, *"it is well deserved."*

"I'm afraid that I won't be a worthy opponent given Her Grace's known affinity with the rapier." You warn her. After all, her Chevalier title isn't just for show. She has *earned it*. With sweat, pain and blood.

The deep scar left by a blade and slicing a line from her chin to jaw is a glaring proof of that.

And she wears it, truly, like a badge of honor, with all the pride that it rightfully deserves.

Predictably, she just dismisses the voicing of your concerns about your inadequacy with a wave of her hand and a very unlady-like scoff of amusement.

"Nonsense. You seem nimble enough and pretty light on your feet. And besides," She adds, selecting one of the blunt blades used for practice and testing its grip and weigth in her calloused yet deceptively delicate-looking hand, "My weapon of choice will always be the longbow. So this is going to be a fair fight."

Her easy, friendly approach to this is refreshing, and her disposition - the way she brushes aside most of the formalities while still being respectful and corteous - is... oddly charming.

(Seriously, the rest of the Alliance could step down their pedestal and learn a thing or two from this woman).

At last, since you have never been able to turn down a challenge, you end up accepting the sword that she holds up to you with an equally challenging smirk.

"Very well." You mimic her by pressing the handle of the sword to your chest in a salute before getting into proper stance. "En garde."

Unsurprisingly, as it turns out, you are still nowhere near being a decent match for her. But your fast reflexes and night vision aid you remarkably in a duel that you weren't prepared for it to be quite so exhilarating.

Your muscles rejoice in the activity, as does your heart, pumping adrenaline that further enhances your already phenomenal senses.

Still, you don't delude yourself of ever standing a chance against a three times rewarded Chevalier whose sword moves as flawlessly as an extension of her own arm, striking true and without hesitation.

Her steps eat quickly at the space reserved for the sparring area, and you can only deflect and par her attacks, until you find yourself with your sword knocked out of your hand, your back pressed against the tree delineating the end of the available space, and the blunt point of a sword resting an inch below your chin. You follow the long, slightly curled line of the blade with your eyes only to find the Duchess grinning at you at the other end of it.

Humbly, you yield.

"Not bad on your defenses, Ser Catra." She says, looking genuinely impressed as she steps back. "Nice footwork, too. You are truly a natural. A few pointers here and there, some training, and in a year's time I might find you participating at the Tournament."

You wonder how many flattering comments it will take for your fur to go up in flames. (Hopefully, you won't have to find out).

"Her Grace is too kind. I don't believe I own the right aptitude for this particular sport, but..." You pause, picking up your sword from the ground. "I have to admit that it was quite fun."

She looks positively delighted by your concession.

"Glad to hear it. And thank you for indulging me."

As if on cue, the lamp post in the garden flickers to life, officially signaling nightfall and encouraging any wandering soul to get back within the Palace walls.

"I should probably get back to my chambers." The Duchess declares with a sigh. "It's getting late, although... I have to say that I'm loath to part from such pleasant and invigorating company such as yours, Catra."

Yeah...

All things considered, the night has turned out to be a more pleasant affair than you dreaded.

"Likewise, Your Grace."

Another smile. This one more tentative though. Almost shy. Which strikes you as odd and completely out of character. Considering her bold disposition you wonder what could *possibly*-

Wait.

And that's when the first spark of realization flickers inside of you. Even before she can phrase her next question.

"If we feel the same way, then perhaps I can interest you in a nightcap?"

It's not quite like a pang in your stomach, but... it's still pretty close.

You weren't mistaken then.

You catch the look before you hear the note of hopefulness carefully weaved in her voice in a way to make it sound casual.

But you know better.

Someone as oblivious as Adora might not have caught the meaning behind that invitation, but you are far sharper in these matters.

This situation, however, requires delicacy. You certainly don't want to end up insulting her and risk jeopardizing this new alliance.

"I'm very flattered, Your Grace." It's what you settle for at last- and for once, you truly are. "But as delightful as that sounds, I'm afraid I have to turn your invitation down."

Strangely enough, she doesn't look either surprised nor offended. Merely a bit disappointed.

"So I wasn't mistaken then." She says with a puzzling little smile curled on her lips.

"Pardon me?"

"You and She-Ra." She explains, "You are an item, aren't you?"

"Adora." You instantly correct. Nonetheless, you nod, your shoulders drawn back as your chest puffs out with pride.

The Duchess makes a contemplative noise, eyeing you up and down, from your black riding boots to the opened collar of your ruffled shirt, with a look of unconceiled appreciation, sighing at length and shaking her head.

"Lucky young woman she is."

Your heart stumbles over a beat and your entire face flares with warmth. Still, miraculously, you manage to maintain your composure and reply.

"I'm the lucky one, Your Grace."

The luckiest.

And that, the sincerity with which the words spill from your lips, earns you another, fuller smile.

"That's lovely to hear." She says, but you still catch that note of disappointment that gets immediately explained when she confirms your first suspicion.

"But I have to say, at the risk of making a fool of myself, that I might have been hoping you were still simply courting. Not *officially* mated."

Suspicion, however, is still a world apart from having the *actual* confirmation that you were *right*, and the effort required out of you not to choke (or keep your jaw from dislocating and hitting the ground) is immense.

"Y-your Grace?"

She runs a nervous hand through the long waves of her glossy black hair before answering.

"Your tactics to take back the lands once occupied by Prime have been remarkable. The attack plans extremely effective. You have managed to gain back territory without losing one single soldier. Your job of containment for the outlaws by turning their gangs against each other rather than the poor townspeople has been very astute. And... I personally find your general aptitude for strategy, quite frankly, a massive turn on."

And there, before you can do anything about it, goes the jaw.

She notices and chuckles amusedly.

"But if tonight's display wasn't enough to provide even just a hint of the bond that you and the mighty Princess of Power share, then the confirmation you gave me just now has erased any doubt I might have had on the matter. It's clear to me now that I don't stand a chance."

You can't be sure, at this point, that you aren't just having a pretty vivid hallucination.

Fuck. Did Sea Hawk spike the champagne again without anyone noticing?

Or perhaps you have stepped onto one of the bioluminiscent mushrooms earlier- their spores are known to play tricks on the mind if inhaled (in large quantities though, and the patch of trampled grass where you are standing doesn't have any).

But if you *aren't* experiencing an hallucination, then you are simply standing here with your mouth open. Trying to catch the merrily flitting-about fireflies.

The realization is humiliating enough that, thankfully, you manage to *snap* out of your trance (and your mouth shut).

"I..." You delicately clear your throat and try again when all it comes out is an embarrassingly raspy croak. "I'm afraid that I don't quite know what to say, Your Grace."

But the Duchess, as you have already witnessed for yourself, is a good sport, simply dismissing your worries with another casual wave of her hand.

"You don't have to say anything. It is I who needs to apologize for having been so forward, Ser Catra."

Huh.

A humble noble.

What an oxymoron.

Glimmer could *really* use spending some time in the company of this woman.

"But when I see something or someone I like, I just... go for them." She confesses, and maybe it's the warm orange light of the nearby lamppost, but you *swear* that the Duchess pale cheeks seem to have turned a shade rosier in the past minute.

Visual illusions aside, you can't argue that hers remains a pretty straight forward approach.

(One you might even envy, in part).

Whatever it is that you believe, you better recover soon and come up with something to say, you gaping moron.

Right.

"Like I said, I'm truly flattered." You repeat, at a loss of what else to say.

Luckily, you don't have to add more.

"And I truly hope that this won't negatively influence your decision about my other offer, Ser Catra."

You shake your head.

"Not in the least, Your Grace."

Because while most would have had their doubts up to six months ago, now you *are* a professional who takes her duties very seriously. And you like how the new challenges of your work as a Strategist keep you on your toes. Also- as Glimmer said, you know what you have to gain in all of this beside yet another ally...

"Does this mean that you will consider it then?" The Duchess asks, hopefully. "Joining my forces and help me and my people re-establish order on the lands surrounding the Duchy previously occupied by Prime... in exchange for ownership of the recently uncovered ruins and whatever technology they contain?"

To that question you can readily reply, with full honesty. *After all, it's all for Adora.* The Duchess only seems to care about her people's welfare. You can ensure that. And there isn't a person in the universe you wouldn't make deals with if it meant possibly gaining a new piece of information about Adora and her origins (she has done *so* much lately to learn about yours).

Perhaps those ruins will turn up holding some answers. Perhaps they will only contain mold and murderous spider robots. But it's a risk you are willing to take... with Glimmer's blessing and support.

"I will, Your Grace." You nod solemnly at last.

And just like that, the Duchess beams.

"Splendid!" She exclaims excitedly. "Then I consider myself *very* satisfied."

She throws you a wink, and to distract yourself from overthinking what that might *mean* you gesture for the guard standing nearby the side entrance of the barracks, not because a worldly woman such as the Duchess needs an escort to find her way back to her chambers, but simply because it's etiquette and custom and nobility formality bullshit reserved to all guests.

And that's probably the same reason why (thankfully) she doesn't complain when Juliet approaches.

"I look forward to working with you, Soon-to-be Ser Just Catra. Goodnight."

With that final, gentle tease, the Duchess flashes you a grateful smile and leaves, following Juliet before you can offer anything else other than a simple, parting bow.

Well, you think to yourself as you straighten, still a bit doubfounded by whatever it is that just went on. *That was... definitely something.*

Or probably nothing, you reconsider shaking your head in an attempt to clear it from the nonsensical thoughts accumulating there as you put away the rapiers in their proper place and make for the stairs.

By the time you are ascending them, those thoughts have all but vanished, replaced by the new purpose of searching for Adora, which fills you to the brim with elation, the feeling of anticipation shaping a huge smile on your face and putting an extra spring in your step.

. . .

Strangely enough, you have to roam the Castle halls for a while before you find her, for she hasn't been waiting at your usual spot- the cozy alcove near the large painting depicting the eternal spring of Plumeria displayed in the Main Hall - but rather tucked away in one of the most secluded studies on the eastern wing of the Palace.

Perhaps she got tired of all the discussions about politics and simply had to tear herself away from the rest of the Alliance. (They can be quite a handful, and Adora never cared much about politics anyway. She is happy to be, and remain, a weapon).

Still, you can't help but smile from ear to ear, your tail lashing excitedly when you finally find her, sitting sideways on a leather chaise lounge by one of the windows and idly leafing through what looks like a book about spells.

"There you are." You say in lieu of a proper greeting. "I have been looking all over for you."

"Well, you found me." Her answer is clipped and devoid of even an ounce of the excitement coursing through your veins. She doesn't even lift her gaze from her reading to acknowledge your presence.

Your tail swings to a slow halt, your ears lower, and your features scrunch up into a frown.

"Is... everything okay?" You ask, gingerly closing the massive oak door behind you. It shuts with a creak. "Did you and Glimmer get into another argument about-"

"Nope." She interrupts before you can even finish, turning a page over as if bored. "I just thought I would wait somewhere quiet until you were finished with our illustrious guest *Her Grace the Duchess of Val Montaigne*."

Your frown deepens at her tone.

So oddly bitter. Sour. Her accent so mocking.

Childish even. Almost j-

Wait a minute.

Your ears swivel forward. And just like that, the frown on your face instantly smooths over as your eyes grow wide at the thought that crosses your mind.

Is she...?

No.

It *can't* be.

But what if...

"Adora," you start, overly cautious as you approach her. "Are you... jealous?"

It's preposterous to even suggest such thing.

The most powerful magical being this side of the Universe acting *jealous?*

Yeah, riiiight.

(And yet... you have to try and dismiss that part of you that secretely finds the possibility so very *thrilling*).

At any rate, you get your confirmation with a sinking feeling in your gut when Adora tries to dismiss the accusation with a nervous, scoffed laugh and one of her overly exaggerated, "*Pfff*! What?! No, of course not!"

You barely manage to hold back a cringe.

Heavens. She has always been such an *awful* liar.

And if that answer wasn't enough, the fact that she is still refusing to look you in the eye, choosing instead to avert her gaze and look outside the nearby window, only cements further your suspicion into reality.

Instinctively, you follow her gaze, watching the bright, intermittent glow of blue and green buzzing around in the backyard belo-

Wait.

A second bout of realization strikes you then, your eyes growing huge with incredulity and your mouth falling open with matching shock.

"Have you been *spying* on me?!" Your voice, too, reaches a level of shrill that you weren't aware it was capable of reaching.

But seriously?! You can't believe this!

To her credit, Adora doesn't even dare to try and lie this time.

"Not on you." She admits, somewhat timidly, her voice so quiet, her gaze still cast downwards, her cheeks flushed pink with embarrassment and her hands twisting nervously atop the book in her lap. "On *her*." She clarifies. "I'm... not sure I trust her, is all."

And now it's your turn to scoff.

"That's some bull, Adora. Just admit it." You challenge her, crossing your arms over your chest and fixing her hard, daring her to look at you.

Finally, she does.

She bristles pretty quickly though, shutting the book in her lap closed, tossing it on the chaise and standing from it with a loud groan.

"Fine! I may have gotten a little jealous, happy now?! But it's not like I didn't *have* a reason to. I mean- have you *seen* the way she was *looking* at you during dinner tonight?"

"No." Your admission is instantaneous and all honesty, your gaze still fixed on her. Firm and unwavering. "Because I spent all evening looking at *you*."

Upon hearing that, Adora recoils as if struck. Her blue eyes blinking, the flush on her cheeks growing warmer.

But her passive reaction doesn't last for long.

And nothing in the few seconds of silence that follow your answer could have prepared you for what happens next.

Suddenly, those deep blue eyes regain focus and they *flash* with something dark and dangerous and wanting that lights them up in a shade of blue much, much darker than their usual hue, and before you know it, before you can do anything about it, before your extremely fast reflexes can aid you in any sort of way (or perhaps simply because such look literally *pins you* in place) Adora is striding towards you, coming to stand right in front of you, one of her hands slipping into your mane, *pulling* you towards her and into a deep, hungry, *voracious* kiss.

You may be left puzzled, perhaps even shocked but, instinctively, you really can't do anything else other than draw her closer and kiss her back with the same ferocity. Regaining enough of your own presence to step forward until you feel her back hitting the wall.

She gasps in your mouth at the impact, but doesn't detach herself. If anything, she wraps her arms tighter around your shoulders, urging your bodies even closer as your tongues battle for dominance, and for the first time you actually fully understand that way of phrasing. Because it is a real battle. An actual duel.

Whatever has possessed her has infected you also in the span of a second, making your entire body thrum with electricity.

Heavens above...

Experiencing her so wild, feeling how much she *craves* you, almost *desperately* so...

Your head spins. Whether it is for the savage way she is kissing you or for the lack of air you don't know, don't *care*.

Although it is quite possible that such sense of vertigo might be caused by the fact that all the blood in your body seems to be traveling south. Leaving your extremities tingling as heat pools low in your belly, fueling the sparks of desire flickering to life in your core... and stirring your knot into fullness.

Almost as if sensing this (and considering how close your bodies are pressed together it's quite possible that she actually feels *it*) Adora moans in your mouth, her wandering hands traveling downwards with a destination that is made perfectly clear even before she can reach the front of your pants.

Only this time, you don't fight her.

You don't stop her.

Panic doesn't seize like it did earlier.

Now that you know that she *wants* you, there is no longer reason to be afraid.

If anything, you lean into her touch encouragingly when she reaches between your legs and palms your hardening length through the soft fabric of your trousers.

Even indirect, the contact still forces you to tear yourself away from her lips with a gasp and a shudder of pleasure that kicks you in the stomach. Not unlike free falling into the Void.

"Fuck." You curse, coherently, blinking your eyes open only to be greeted by bright spots. "What... what was that about, 'Dora?"

"Just a reminder." She says almost too casually. "That you, are mine. And this-" Another choked sound is torn from your chest, this one a low and guttural, almost beastly growl as she palms and squeezes your knot in her hand through your pants.

"This is mine, too."

Good merciful Heavens above!

The feeling knocks the air from your lungs.

Since *when* is she feeling so possessive?

Did it happen during dinner?

After dinner?

Maybe something happened before?

Was it one of those shellfish appetizers that Mermista brought and declared had aphrodisiac properties?

...was it seeing you in the gardens talking and laughing and sparring with the Duchess?

"-ave I made myself clear?" Her question brings you back to the present. You blink, and shapes and colors gradually return, allowing you to make out the contours of her face and catch on a few striking details.

Like the dark flush coloring her cheeks.

The snarl twisting on her lips.

The fire *blazing* in her eyes.

Overall, that look should shock you even more, and yet... it only makes you more conscious of the fireball of *need* growing hotter in the depths of your belly.

The feeling so exhilarating that it infuses you with the irresistible temptation to tease her back.

"I didn't know that you had grown so attached to it in just a few hours." There should be an applause, really, for the way you manage to speak through the onslaught of feelings assaulting all your senses at once.

"I'm attached to every single part of you," She corrects in earnest. "But this-" Another squeeze, another stuttered groan torn from your throat. You barely manage to right yourself and regain your other senses just enough to fully hear the threat laced into the words that she hisses next. "You even just *think* about sticking it into someone else and-"

And that's what it takes for that primal part of your brain to be switched on.

That's enough.

Whatever it is that is happening right now, by uttering those words she has definitely poked at that something wild and feral that constantly snarls enraged and scratches beneath your skin, searching for a way *out*.

And it has finally found it.

Alright.

Two can play this game.

In the blink of an eye you spin her around, and before she can right herself or even realize that you have moved her at all, you press her face-first against the wall.

Another gasp falls from her lips at the forcefulness of the impact.

"You'll do *what?*" The beast that lives inside you growls dangerously in her ear as you pin her in place with the whole weight of your body.

"C-catra..." If it weren't for the shiver that you feel racing up her spine and the note of desperation in the way she moans your name, you would think that you might have read the situation wrongly and taken it a step too far.

But you haven't.

Oooh, *you haven't.*

The proof is all in the way she squirms against the hold that you have on her wrists. Not to try to break free of it (because if that were the case, she would already *have*) but to put it to the test, *moaning* and *shivering* all over with unmistakable desire when she realizes that you pinned her good. That she has no way out. That you got her cornered.

Like a tasty prey, you think licking your lips.

And now that you know what *this*- inflicting a little bit of dominance, does to her...

Fuck.

Has she been needling you on purpose to get you like this?

Is this something else that she has found in her "studies"? Teasing a horny Alpha to see what will happen? To see if it will snap your precarious self restraint and turn you into a lust-blinded *beast*?

If so, you need to make a mental note about congratulating her later, because she just won.

Although... she is *not* the only one currently benefitting from such win.

The result of having her like this, at your mercy, is almost too much of a power trip for you to handle at once. But you can try summon some of your self control back if the purpose is to play this new, admittedly intriguing game she has started.

"Last time I checked you haven't bit me yet," You remind her, tauntingly. "Or have you?"

A whimpering moan is your only response, your *permission* to continue. Your reassurance that you are on the right path to something greater than the mere promise of pleasure and physical release.

This... this feels like the promise of transcendence.

"That's right." You take the liberty to properly answer in her stead. "You haven't. And you know what that means? It means that I don't belong to you. Or anyone else for that matter."

A sound of protest and denial falls from her lips with her next breath, but you don't even acknowledge it, far too emboldened by the surge of confidence that is coursing through your veins, sizzling along every inch of your skin and bristling your fur.

"It means that you don't have any hold on me, oh mighty Princess of *Power*."

You may even taunt her with one of your old cruel laughs, but you both know that it's a lie.

Those two statements are both lies.

Because not only you *do* belong to her (body and soul, bite or no bite) but she still has, after all these years, the firmiest hold of all on your heart. It's chambers are so full of your affections for her that the organ wouldn't know how to function if only blood coursed through your veins without such feelings filling every single cell.

For the sake of keeping up this alluring charade though, you have to pretend that she doesn't own you like you own her.

"You however..." you reach up with one hand, curling one single claw to move her hair aside, exposing the side of her neck and...

There it is.

Your mark.

Your *brand*.

Your heart stutters and a powerful shiver races up your spine, the fire of desire in your belly flaring hotter at the sight of it.

So beautiful.

"*You* belong to *me*."

"*Yes!*" Adora half-hisses and half-shouts breathlessly, nearly collapsing for how hard she starts trembling when you growl those words in her ear. Her knees buckle, threatening to give in under her own weight, but you are there to hold her up, effortlessly so as the beast inside you roars to life in front of the reaction of your rightful claim.

And it *does* feel so. *Right*.

She is *yours*. You grin savagely at the exhilarating thought. Yours alone. No one else is going to kiss her, touch her, make love to her... be inside of her.

She is *all yours*.

Even while you are busy having that joyful, invigorating epiphany you are once again reminded of why all of this feels so right, by your most recent study. Because *this* is how the dynamics used to work back at the dawn of time. Back before the Khajiit even had a society to call as such.

Back when Alphas held all the power and an Omega's purpose was to simply bear and raise cubs. Before Alphas' pride and lust for conquering opposing tribes got them warring upon themselves. Before a group of rebel Omegas (later known as the First Matriarchs) rose to take the reign of ruling, rewriting history itself with a shift of power that got the dynamics reversed. Permanently. (And for the better).

But if the old, brutal, instincts-driven ways of the Alpha-ruled, ancient Khajiit world is what is making Adora all hot and bothered right now, if the mere suggestion is what is even threatening her ability to *stand*, to *breathe*... then you can *definitely* play along into such fantasy and channel the wild animal that trashes inside you.

It's about time you stop being afraid of it and learn how to hold its leash instead.

Before you decide to unhook its chain and let it take over though, you think it wise and of vital importance to make one last check in with Adora first.

And so, gentling your touch and softening your voice you lean forward, whispering the next words in her ear,

"You want to stop this, any time, for *any* reason, and I will." You promise, your hand infinitely tender as you stroke her side to provide comfort and remind her that it's still you, that you are still here, that you would never hurt her, no matter how hard that rabid, lust-

driven *fiend* may try to gain full control over you or how strongly that primeval desire may affect your judgment.

But your concerns barely have a reason to even exist, you realize, when you hear her swallowing and feel her frantically nodding her head in affermative.

For how relieving and elating it is to know that you have read her right and that you have her consent however, this isn't enough.

You need to push for something more substantial. You need her to actually *say it*.

Luckily, this isn't the first time you have tried to play naugthy. (Although, you have a feeling that you might be about to surpass any precedent with this game...)

"Say *'yes, My Lord',* if you want me to keep going." You request, and the fact that you don't even have to wait a second before she is practically blurting the reply out in an exquisitely breathless whisper, is also a confirmation in itself about *how much* she, too, wants this.

"Y-yes, my Lord."

A grin stretches across your lips, your heart doing all kinds of sumersaults and crazy acrobatics within your chest.

Nuzzling the side of her neck, right where your mark resides, you purr.

"Good Omega."

It's mostly for your own benefit. For your *instinct's* benefit. To revel in the exhilarating feeling of the beast stirring and growling within you some more, as well as the one of your knot throbbing heavily where it is pressed against the firm swell of Adora's ass, but it seems like she too appreciates the way you address her with that term. Or at least that's how you interpret the shaky whimper that slips past her lips with her next exhale and the new shiver that runs through her entire body as you bunch her dress up around her waist.

"Please..." She begs, grinding her panties-clothed behind against your groin, forcing you to stiffle a groan by biting down on her exposed shoulder, hard enough for your fangs to sting her.

In response, she cries out, the sound echoing within the library's stone walls, an exquisite mixture of pain and undeniable pleasure that has your knot throb viciously and that primitive part of yourself preen at the achievement.

You weren't quite prepared for a bout of jealousy to lead you to this, but as you sneak your hand into Adora's panties and find her positively, utterly *drenched* in her own slickness, you start thinking that there might be nothing wrong with a bit of jealousy, is there?

You are going to show her that she has nothing to fear. That you are *hers* as much as she is *yours*.

Yes, you think as Adora starts canting her hips forward to follow the precise, circling motion of your fingers stroking the hardened, slippery bud of her clit.

Things are about to get very interesting.

Chapter End Notes

Yeah, I know. I thought I made it clear with the previous chapters but... being a tease is kinda my default mode folks. Don't fret too much though. I'm officially done teasing.

Instincts graduated, Acclimatisation and Correlated variation

Chapter Notes

So...

gets comfortable on couch, opens book and leafs through it

Where were we?

Ah, yes. I remember...

finds page and fixes glasses

Our lovely ladies were about to enjoy some intimate time together..

WARNINGS: The present chapter contains some mild D/s, rough play (all consensual) and dirty talk, followed by a fuck load of feelings. Read at your discretion.

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Catra..."

Fuck.

She is so warm.

So wet.

So *slippery.*

Your fingers simply *slide* inside of her, meeting no sign of resistance whatsoever, her opening stretching so very easily to accomodate you before you find yourself wrapped tightly into that same, welcoming, velvety warmth that has all your organs jolt at once with a devastating pang of need, and makes your knot throb in sympathy for being denied the silky heat that is yours to claim.

The image that inevitably flashes in your mind is so exquisite, the feelings attached to it so intense that it sucks the air from your lungs.

Or maybe it's feeling the way Adora *clenches* around you, so tightly that at first you can barely move.

But you don't even need to.

For a few, torturously blissful seconds you simply savor that feeling, relish in it, fantasize about it, and then, at the second ripple of a pleasurable contraction, you curl your fingers by just a few inches, and that is more than enough.

As a matter of fact, it's all you need to reach *that spot*.

"C-catra..." The sounds that keep falling from her lips in between her calling your name with each one of your thrusts are simply delicious. Yet another delicacy to be savored. One at the time.

And you do so even when they start increasing in frequency and grow more and more breathless as you keep touching her.

She is already close, you realize with a rush of pride and desire swirling together to create a dangerous cocktail that goes straight to your head and makes it spin vertiginously.

Combined with the pressure and fullness pounding along your aching shaft it's a miracle that you still find the willpower to keep standing, to summon enough coordination in order to help her lift her dress over her head and discard it, to hurriedly unbutton your pants and let your knot break free of its restraints all without stopping from moving your fingers inside of her. Although... you don't think you'll be able to stop now.

And once your knot springs free, bobbing in the cool air before resting against the swell of Adora's clothed ass, your instincts take over.

Your hips cant forward of their own volition, establishing a mindless rhythm to allow you to get some friction.

"Shamelessly *rutting* against her" would be a more adapt description of what you end up doing in a matter of seconds, but you can't find it in yourself to feel embarassed about it. Not with how Adora starts responding to the way you are practically *using* her for your own pleasure, emitting a litany of the most enthusiastic and encouraging sounds, her movements growing sloppy and tormented, torn between rocking back to *feel* the hardness of your hot knot sliding through the thin layer of fabric of her underwear, and forward to chase after the touch of your hand, trying to get your fingers to speed up, to go *deeper.*

And since you no longer need to decide which one to prioritize anymore, you do both, pressing her further against the wall to maximize contact, bringing your bodies impossibly close, one arm coming up to brace yourself further and keep the both of you steady by wrapping it around her shoulders while your other arm remains trapped between the cold stone and the scorching heated slickness of her sex as you flex your wrist and plunge *deeper* inside her.

She chokes on a sob of approval, spreading her legs wider, shivering all over, pressing her forehead against the wall and panting.

You inhale and suddenly she is everywhere.

All around you.

Inside you.

Her very essence filling your lungs. Each molecule binding to your blood cells and coursing through your veins.

It's... a most intoxicating feeling.

And it's probably enhanced beyond reason by your own hormones with the purpose to drive your instincts *wild*.

But you resist.

"Adora." You murmur as if in prayer in between a groan and another breathless gasp.

"Please..." She sobs in response.

She is so far gone already. And your ego soars at the thought that you reduced her to this simply by taking a few hints in the right direction and basically stumbling into a fantasy.

But maybe... *maybe* you can push her even a little further, you think.

Keep her balanced over the edge for a few more moments. Make her really *desperate* for it.

Yes...

The idea of how much more explosive her orgasm will end up being if you delay it is what persuades you to do it. And so, you slow down the movement of your hand (not without a bit of reluctance), focusing in precise, slower strokes of your fingers.

"Is this what you wanted?" You ask her, honest curiosity desguised as a taunt. "Why you have acted like such a jealous *brat* earlier?"

"I-I..." She stutters, swallows noisily, searching for words that won't come, for an excuse she doesn't have.

But that's all right.

You are even starting to get the hang on keeping your own need and desires at bay if it means seeing hers skyrocket before your very eyes, feeling it *leak* out of her and pool in the palm of your hand. You cradle it preciously and use it to your advantage. To make each thrust smoother.

"You know," You continue before she can find an excuse or say anything else at all to justify her behavior. "If you are going to act and feel threatened every single time a powerful ally approaches me, then you should do something about it, don't you think?"

A choked gasp is the only response you receive; a sound caught in between wave of pleasure as your fingers keep stroking her meticulously, and the realization that hits her at the implication behind your words.

"You have thought about it, haven't you?" Another taunt, and this one earns you a whimper that you don't even have to use your imagination to interpret as a reluctantly affermative response.

"You have thought about claiming me as yours, too. Biting me. Leaving a sign on me that *everyone* will know *you* left?"

Her breath hitches tellingly and you smile.

A wide, savage, predatorial grin.

"Yeah, I bet you have." You purr, nuzzling the side of her neck and inhaling deeply the intoxicating scent of her sweaty skin. She shivers exquisitely in your arms, a sign for you to keep going, even if what you are about to say next happens to affect you at a particularly deep, dangerous level.

"...just like I bet you have thought about how it will feel like when I'll finally claim you *here*."

For good measure, to emphasize your accusation, you plunge your fingers *deeper* into the clinging warmth of her cunt and she chokes on a cry of pleasure, her inner walls flutter wildly around you, whether for the gesture itself or the words you just uttered you can't tell, but... you suspect it might be a result of both. And she is not the only one who is affected by them either. You too have to make an effort in order not to give in that instinct that would have you tug her panties aside and just... turn that statement into reality. Right here. Right *now.*

But you don't.

You *won't.*

Not like this.

Instead, you briefly close your eyes and take a deep, calming breath, willing the storm raging inside you to ease, all while pressing your pulsing, heavily-leaking knot harder against her as a way to contain the pressure pounding along its length. A gesture that Adora clearly appreciates, given the way she instantly rocks back against it as if trying to provide more contact in the only way she can offer it in her current position.

"I have thought about it too, you know." You admit then in a much softer much more vulnerable voice.

Because you have, not just now, and probably more than you should. More than is wise if you aim to keep your mental sanity without giving into what that *beast* demands of you every time you get even a sniff of her scent.

To make you feel less guilty about it, the mere suggestion is enough to stir those very same ideas and expectations in Adora that you don't think you are yet ready to properly, adequately meet. And under the lust slowly eating away at her reason, she knows that, too.

"Please..." Still, that doesn't keep her from begging you.

"Not yet." There is no pleasure in denying her (or yourself) of this. *But...*

A compromise.

"You are more than welcome to use your imagination however."

An advice that you are going to take you yourself.

"Can you do that for me?" You ask her, kissing the side of her neck, so very softly, as if you were making the most innocent of requests.

"Can you picture how it would feel like when I'll finally stretch you with my knot?"

"C-catra!" The way she nearly shouts your name, the way her blunt fingersnails *scratch* without purchase on the flat, cold, stone wall, the way her inner muscles *squeeze* you, so impossibly tight, with such *greed...*

A growling groan is ripped from your throat at the feeling, at the spasm of pleasure that follows such a magnificent sensation.

"Y-yeah... I can, too." You answer, your voice low and raspy, sounding alien to your own ears, but... oh, if you can!

Every single nerve in your body is left tingling at the image you have just conjured up. Your knot gives another heavy throb in response, leaking like a faucet where it remains pressed against Adora's firm ass, imagining how it would feel like to be buried within the same velvety walls that are wrapped so tightly around your fingers right now.

You feel them rippling, the spot at her front wall so swollen and full and-

"Uhghn!"

Fuck!

Another heavy spurt of wetness erupts from the tip of your knot, staining the fabric of Adora's underwear and leaving you panting, every muscle drawn taunt, like an elastic band ready to *snap*.

She might be close, but are about to burst at the seams, too.

You just need just a further little push.

"I can imagine it, Adora." You tell her, the amount of energy required for your voice not to shake is immense, but you have a purpose, something that is even grater than reaching your own peak, and in that thought, in every single reaction that you manage to *fuck* out of her, you find the strength to keep going.

"And I already know that you'll feel-" You pull out of her only to add a third finger.

"just-" She gasps and shivers at the new intrusion, her cunt spasming at the extra fullness, squeezing you greedily, unwilling to let you go.

"-*Perfect*."

As soon as you breathe that last word in her ear, as soon as you curl the tips of your three fingers against that extremely sensitive, magically responsive *spot* on her front wall, she throws her head back and cries out loud a sob of pure, unadulterated ecstasy that distantly resembles your name.

You watch and feel and *delight* in the spectacle unfolding before your eyes, coming apart in your own arms as Adora finally reaches that peak and tumbles over the edge.

But for how blissful, for how awestruck it leaves you, you don't get the chance to savor it for longer than a couple of seconds. Because Adora doesn't give you the chance to.

Even with every single muscle in her body going rigid and then spasming repeatedly as wave after wave of pleasure assaults her, even when literally *drowning* under that onslaught of feelings, she hasn't forgotten about you and your own imminent fall.

She is still conscious of it.

And in one last attempt to drag you down with her, she reaches back with one hand, grasping at your side, the curve of your hip, the swell of your your ass...

At first, you think that she might simply be trying to keep her violently twitching body from falling over by holding more tightly onto you, then you think she might be encouraging you to thrust harder against her- to assure you that it's okay for you to go faster, to do what you need to in order of following her down that precipice. But her hand doesn't search for a place to grasp onto. Instead, it keeps traveling at an awkward angle that must make her shoulder feel a certain strain, and yet she doesn't stop.

You don't understand what she is searching for until her hand reaches the small of your back and feel her fingers press against the hollow point located at the base of your tail, just an inch at its side.

Realization strikes you just as her fingertips dig in that *spot*, certain and purposeful, ripping a wild, animalistic howl from your chest, so unexpectedly and with such ferocity that the sound startles even you.

In the aftermath of that first exploratory touch you are left panting. Shaking. Your head spinning. Your knot growing impossibly hard, the added pressure within forcing another spurt of wetness from its tip that you can feel dripping down its underside and add to the *mess* you already made of Adora's underwear.

"Fuck!" You curse breathlessly.

Even when you are the one at an advantage you still tend to forget (in your cockiness) that she knows *all* your weaknesses.

The feeling is so powerful that it catches you completely off guard.

You have been toeing that fine line for a while now, yes, but prioritizing Adora's pleasure meant that you had to put yours momentarily behind.

Now however... now you are reminded of how aroused and how painfully *hard* you have been this whole time. Feeling her tumbling over the edge only emphasizes how long you have been straddling it yourself.

And with her finally coming apart in your arms so gloriously, you no longer have a reason to hold back, you realize.

When her fingers dig into that spot one more time, firmly, you have no choice but to let go.

You come with a yowl.

An ungodly, sinful sound that speaks for itself about the intensity of the orgasm that hits you all at once. Like a speeding train.

Your knot swells, pulses and with one last mighty throb, the pressure that has been trapped within finally bursts free.

Needless to say, it's wonderfully messy.

The rush of ecstasy deprives you from any thought, leaving your mind blissfully blank, only allowing you a few, basic motor functions. Namely, the mindless, instincts-driven rutting of your hips, and the curling motion of your fingers inside Adora.

You are only partially aware of the second wave of pleasure that hits her an heartbeat after you reach your own peak and that makes her spasm with fresh contractions around your fingers, a rush of wetness following suit. If she cries out her second release though, you barely hear a muffled version of her previous one.

But you don't wonder the reason why.

Just like you don't wonder what causes the sudden, sharp flash of *pain* that shoots up your arm.

It's gone in an instant, before you can even properly acknowledge it. Too caught up drowning in bliss to realize *what* just happened.

You just know that the feeling may have contributed in making your pleasure that much more intense, causing you to empty yourself that much faster as a result.

And you don't know whether it might be related, but Adora's spasming inner walls seem to ripple and *squeeze* you just that tiny bit tighter with every heavy twitch of your length, with every warm jet of come that splashes against the skin of her lower back.

You remain pressed close to her to make *sure* that she feels every single one of them. But also... also to keep that skin-to-skin connection to try to abate that feeling of emptiness that

surrounds your knot, which still aches, enviously, of the warmth and slickness surrounding your digits.

Rutting against her like this is definitely not like having the firm softness of her hand pumping you, or the even more perfect and exquisite silky feeling of her tongue swirling around your tip. But with her fingers digging and *scratching*, over and over, into that spot at side of the base of your tail, it's definitely all you need; the skin of her lower back is stained in the sticky proof of that fact.

You are half tempted to lean back and admire the way she looks wearing your release, but that would mean severing the connection you have, and you honestly don't think that you'd be able to support your own weight by yourself right now.

Not with how *drained* of strength your orgasm is leaving you. And definitely *not* considering the way your knees start buckling, forcing you to slump a bit forward and lean against Adora's much stronger frame, panting against the back of her neck as the last spurts of come are drawn out of you by the feeling of Adora deliberately grinding back against your crotch.

You groan, tightening the hold you have on her with your other arm wrapped around her upper chest while jogging your hips, willing to give her every last drop while also drawing out every single shudder of her own pleasure by repeatedly curling and uncurling the fingers until you are both reduced to a twitching, shivering mess, overstimulation forcing each other into a halt. And yet, despite how uncomfortably sweaty and sticky and hot your bodies feels pressed so close to one another, you both still seem unwilling to sever the contact.

You guide each other through the descent, supporting one another, until the waves of crashing pleasure spit you out and onto the shore, where the water laps more gently, in direct contrast to the tumultous, stormy ocean you have just ridden.

The rocking motion of it still carries within you though. Resonating. Leaving your nerves tingling all over with the reminder of such savagery.

...with one sole exception.

Because when the second stab of pain pierces in your arm, this time you *do* feel *it*. But even now, by the time your sizzling, overburdened nervous system finally, properly registers it, it isn't pain any longer.

It's something else.

Something greater.

It's realization.

Like two pieces of a whole slotting together at last. Fitting in all the right places. Molding around the edges to create something new and complex, yet so intrinsically *simple*, and flawlessly beautiful.

It's peace blooming in your heart.

A real sense of belonging that has been denied to you for all your whole life taking form, gaining consistency.

Adora bit me.

It's the blood in your veins singing.

It's your entire body and soul rejoicing at being claimed by the one you love- the one you have *always* loved.

Adora *bit* me. Every single cell of your body echoes along. A jolt of electricity that travels through you and shocks you to your core.

It's everything you have always been afraid of and everything you ever wanted.

When Adora spins around and kisses you without preamble, as if to seal this new, profound bond with a lingering taste of your own blood on her lips, it feels like an achievement that was long overdue.

And when she hooks one knee around your waist and reaches between your bodies with a steady, purposeful hand to grasp your still hard knot and presses it against the drenched fabric of her panties, sliding it in between her soft outer lips... it feels like being a step away from fulfilling destiny.

Your breath hitches and you pull away from the kiss, still panting, still shocked, your head hazy and spinning with so many thoughts so many questions...

But you only have one.

And the answer of it you can see it swimming within the blue pools of your lover's eyes when your gazes meet.

"A-are you sure?"

Briefly, you glance down at your knot, gulping dryly at how intimidatingly *large* it looks even after experiencing such a powerful, lengthy release.

It hasn't softened in the least. If anything, it feels even harder. (Almost as if the orgasm you just had hasn't really... *satisfied* you).

Your tip is broad and your shaft is *thick*.

The possibility of inadvertently hurting her strikes you again, but... after your previous ministration your fingers have contributed in leaving her impossibly wet and open.

Stretched.

Ready.

With your heart hammering in your throat, equal part anticipation and warm affection filling all its chambers and making you shake all over, you step closer and grasp your knot in your fist.

You meet her gaze again.

Watching.

Waiting.

Her expression is so open, so naked, so strong in the vulnerability of her carnal desire.

There is no trace of doubt to be found.

And so, at her firm, definitive nod to your previous question, you fit more comfortably between her legs and pull her panties aside with gentle, albeit trembling fingers.

She gasps as she gets exposed. But her hands tighten on your shoulders and the leg she has wrapped around your waist urges you closer, encouraging you to take that final step.

And so, faced with the unequivocal fact that she truly, really *wants you*, you move to press in...

...just as the big, massive oak door of the study slams open.

. . .

Just when you thought you were all out of humiliation, Casta fucking *Spella* shows up to prove you wrong.

Tsk.

"More like Brekaspella." You grumble to yourself. A lame excuse of a joke that has Adora stiffling a snorting giggle.

"Well, technically, we *were* trespassing in her private library." She points out. And yeah, sure, the spells books all over the place should have been enough to provide some kind of clue about whose sanctum you were intruding into (and desecrating) but...

Who *the fuck* actually *knew that*?

And how is Adora apparently not as bothered by the fact of almost getting *caught* like you currently are?

You'll need to ask for clarifications because you can't *trust* the wild ideas that start swimming in your head regarding all those possibilities.

It doesn't matter.

What matters is that you almosy got caught just when you were about to do a lot more than simply *"trespassing"*, as Adora just put it.

The exquisite memory of the instants that preceeded the brutal interruption flash in your mind, attached to the string of primitive thoughts that kept replaying over and over in your head under the sound of your wildly beating heart.

Thrust, fill, stretch, come, claim. *Claim. Claim.*

Once again, it gets broken (mercifully so) before you can run into the risk of losing yourself in them and act of consequence, by a sharp sting as Adora medicates the wound on your forearm.

That squirt of peroxide, for how innocuous and small, is more than enough to drag you back into the present with a start and a *hiss* that is more instinctual rather than a response to the pain itself. And something that you instantly regret when Adora stumbles clumsily over a stuttered apology.

"S-sorry!" She cringes, dabbing at the excess of liquid with a bunch of cotton pads that you have scavenged from the infirmary along with some other first aid supplies in your half-dressed, fully-panicked, ass-in-the-air run out of the Queen's aunt study before making it back into your own room. Behind a safely *locked* door.

"Sorry," Adora repeats, unnecessarily so, for what feels like the hundredth time ever since you have both regained some measure of control over your lust-addled minds. Although, you have a feeling that she may be apologizing for something *else* other than lacking a gentler touch while medicating you.

Still... the consideration is there in every gesture.

She may lack experience, but she is impossibly tender as she tends to the small laceration that her incisors have inflicted on you, dabbing at the smidgen of blood on the place where the skin actually broke.

"Does it still hurt?" She asks worriedly, her face scrunched up with concern and unmistakable guilt that doesn't even have a reason to *exist*.

"Are you *sure* you don't want She-Ra to heal you instead?"

Of course it isn't the first time she proposed that alternative either, but you still give her the same answer, shaking your head while your gaze remains fixed on that spot on your arm, feeling that same unexplicable wave of sadness and disappointment washing over you like it did when you first realized that she didn't bit you hard *enough.*

Not in a way that will scar and stay permanent.

Your eyes flit briefly on the side of her neck.

...not like yours did.

"I'm good." You assure her, masking your disappointment behind a smile and a nonchalant shrug. "The skin barely broke anyway." And then, in an attempt to regain your usual self (and simply because you can't resist the temptation to tease her a little...) "I don't think I'll need a shot either. The *creature* that bit me seemed shockingly clean. Although... She did seem a *bit* hungry, now that I think about it."

Your comment (and terrible, *awful* pun) earns you a rightful, reprimanding smack on the shoulder (which, *ow*!), paired with the discordant sight of her face going up in flames with a ferocious blush. And it's so damn endearing that you can't help the soft smile that curls on your lips. You can feel it reaching all the way up to your eyes when she ducks her head and fixes a golden strand of hair behind her ear, clearing her throat before getting back to business.

Considering that you got splinters on your fingers that bled way more than her bite did, her thorough medication is completely unnecessary.
But you aren't going to protest to these special attentions.

How could you, when she looks so *cute* all focused? When your heart is set fluttering madly within your chest at the sight of her taking such good, meticulous care of you?

And so you watch, silently, as she completes her first aid procedures by applying some antibiotic ointment on the "wound" with a cotton bud before reaching for the roll of gauze sitting among the rest of supplies on the bed.

And that's when you break the silence with a groan.

"Is that really necessary, 'Dora?"

She pauses midway from unhooking one of the clasps holding it together and fixes you with an arched eyebrow and a pointed sort of suspicion.

"Can you promise me you won't lick it repeatedly if I don't put in on?" She asks in that reprimanding tone that has your ears flatten against your head and your gaze shift downwards, guiltily.

"...no." You grumble reluctantly after a beat of silence.

When you look up again, Adora is smiling amusedly at you.

"Thought so." She chirps, sounding a bit too pleased with herself. "Now stop whining and gimme your paw."

You scowl at her. *Hard.*

...but obediently meet her request.

She smiles big and bright, cradling your arm while rolling the gauze around the wounded area.

"Good kitty." She praises, and while your scowl only hardens and you might even growl a little at the pet name, your tail betrays your apparent annoyance by going straight up with contentment at the praise. (You are probably going to need to unpack that, but... one thing at the time).

For the moment, you focus on the present.

More specifically, on the way Adora starts gnawing pensively at her lower lip after she finishes wrapping your arm.

"Should we... talk about it?" She asks, lifting her gaze to meet yours.

It's tentative.

A sheepish, fleeting look.

But even so, the flash of uncertainty lingering in her eyes doesn't get past you.

Nor does the way she starts twisting nervously the rest of the roll of gauze in her hands.

...nor the lovely blush that starts warming her cheeks in the dim candlelight.

"You mean... the bite?" You ask, glancing briefly at the gauze now covering (unnecessarily) a third of your forearm.

When you glance back up at her she is still reluctant to meet your gaze.

Maybe thats not it then...

Maybe she is referring to the fact that you almost gave into your most primal urges after you had *sworn* that you weren't going to bend your knees to a rush of hormones.

...or maybe is she talking about how Castaspella caught you.

With how flustered she looks, you choose to go with that one.

"I don't think she saw anything, Catra." She answers while balling up trash of used cotton pads in her hands and moving supplies from the bed to the nightstand.

You scoff. *I beg to differ*.

"She saw *enough*." You counter.

Sure, maybe she didn't see *your knot* (thank the Heavens for small mercies), but she saw you and Adora in a most compromising position that couldn't possibly have been misinterpreted in any other way.

And that, you believe, is *more* than enough.

"Ugh!" You groan, the reminder of the mortification you suffered merely twenty minutes ago sending a scalding surge of embarrassment through your body, making you hide your face behind your hands. "I'll never be able to look her in the eye again at the meetings." You state, flopping dramatically back into the mattress.

"Y-*you*?!" Adora splutters.

You peak between your fingers to see her blue eyes growing huge, blazing with an indignant sort of incredulity.

"What about *me*?" She actually *shrieks*. "*I* am the one who was half naked in there!"

You try, you really do, but you simply can't *help* the little smirk that curls at the corner of your mouth then. All worries about deeply awkward, mortifying future meetings with the Archmage pushed momentarily aside.

She looks just... so *adorable* when she is embarrassed about something.

"Yeah, well..." you roll one shoulder in a half shrug. "If she didn't 'see anything', as you just said, then you've got nothing to worry about, do you *Princess*?" Your smirk widens, and now its her turn to scowl at you.

"You are terrible." She states.

Then her bottom lip sticks out. "...and *mean*."

Okay, the whine and the pout may leave you feeling more guilty than pleased however.

But... still not enough to *actually* apologize. After all, let's not forget that-

"You love my particular brand of meanness, though." You say confidently when she lifts her gaze to meet yours.

You reach for one of her hands. Holding it in yours and stroking her knuckles with your thumb.

"Just like you love me even more because of the way I *really* have to put in extra effort in order to make it up to you whenever I am."

Her blush returns with a vengeance then, but her expression inevitably softens, even if the corner of her mouth twists into a naughty little smile of her own.

"...maybe." She reluctantly conceeds (competitive as always- you didn't expect anything less of her) while reaching up with her free hand to stroke that spot right under the curve of your jaw.

Your instincts would have you return the affections by rubbing your face all over hers, but you settle for leaning in and kissing her instead. A more acceptable compromise.

Keeping it innocent after what you were about to do just a few minutes ago in that study however is damn near impossible.

And with the warm swirl of Adora's silky tongue embracing your slightly raspy one in each other's mouth, your bodies too are quick to be reminded of what almost transpired.

Whether that could be a result (and first symptom) of the bite (no matter how small it might have been) however, you simply know that the closeness is something that you are left craving at a deep visceral level, especially after the measured roughness of your recent encounter.

A need that demands to be tended to.

And... not necessarily in an explicitly sexual way, you realize in surprise as you lay back onto the bed on your sides, facing each other, your hands joining and fitting in between your bodies.

Your fingers intertwining of their own volition in a familiar knit.

This... this feels like enough.

But to be sure, you also ask Adora.

"Are you okay?" Your voice is quiet, a bit of anxiety swelling in your throat and preventing you from speaking any louder as if afraid that the answer would be anything other than a-

"Yes."

A smile.

The kindest.

The most loving. Paired with that immediate answer.

Your chest deflates with your next exhale at the sincerity held in that single word.

Although not completely, once again reminded of what she asked you earlier.

"You said you wanted to talk about... what happened?"

This time she doesn't answer immediately. Chewing pensively on the inside of her cheek first.

"About the things you said..." She clarifies eventually.

And just like that, panic resurfaces.

Your stomach twists up into knots and you break off into a sudden cold sweat.

The fear that you may have done something, *anything* she wasn't okay with makes you *sick*.

A wave of nausea rolls over you.

You thought you had read every single one of the signs that she gave off *right*. The enthusiasm with which her body responded to you and your touch, the burning *passion* in the kiss she pulled you into...

But what if... What if you- What if *she*-

You open your mouth because you need to ask, need *to know*. But before you can even utter a vowel, Adora scoots closer and presses a firm kiss to your parted lips.

And just like that, the panic recedes, the coldness of dread that had followed at its heel replaced with the warmth of comfort.

"It's okay." Adora says when breaks the kiss and pulls away. Her soft smile so full of understanding that even the most stubborn ones of your lingering worries are chased away.

"I enjoyed it more than I can express, Catra. *Everything* you did."

That's... beyond relieving. Truly.

But what was she referring to then?

Before you can express your confusion with something more substantial than a frown, she offers further clarification.

"You were right." She says. "I... may have thought about *it.* ...a lot actually."

Oh.

Your previous conversations replays in your head.

Specifically, your dirty talk in the midst of sex.

Oh.

"I just want you, Catra." She declares once realization settles over your features, smoothing out your puzzlement as she looks so very intently at you. "*Every part* of you."

There is a harsh, sudden stuttering within your chest.

A violent *slam* against your sternum caused by the elation that explodes inside of you at sound of those words.

The head rush that follows...

The sense of belonging and acceptance that envelops you from the inside...

It's almost too much for your poor heart to handle all at once.

You have... no words to offer back that would be adequate enough.

But you *can* return the immensity of that same feeling with just as much sentiment.

So you lean your forehead against hers and take a deep steadying breath, inhaling the safeness that her sweet, heady scent brings you, and relishing in the way it eases the last tangle of worries that almost threatened to choke you but a minute ago.

"I want you, too." You admit, quietly, but with so much feeling when you release your next exhale that the genuinity in your own confession feels like a piece of your very soul detaching from your body.

But...

"I'm just..." you pause, inwardly cringe, searching for words that won't make you feel too exposed for your next confession, even though you *own* it to her to be as sincere as she *deserves* you to be. As she *always* is with you.

"I'm still trying to... *tame...* this new part of myself."

There.

That wasn't so hard.

The surprising ease with which the words leave you and the look of patient curiosity that Adora gives you, spur you into revealing something even more... delicate. And infinitely more intimate.

"Sometimes... sometimes it takes off on its own and I'm left scrambling behind, trying to mitigate whatever damage it might cause. And I don't want to even think about what would happen if I ever... if *you*-"

That sense of nausea returns and assaults you again, forcing you to swallow the bile that rises in your throat.

You can't even bring yourself to utter those words. Can't even *think* that *thought.*

Luckily you don't have to conclude, because even through half of your explanation Adora is already looking at you like she already *knows.*

"You would never hurt me, Catra."

There might be tears prickling at your eyes all of a sudden. A familiar feeling of unworthiness rearing its head at the earnestness of her words. Bad memories resurfacing as well.

She is too good for you. The voice hisses cruelly.

But for the first time, you feel confident and brave enough to dismiss it and tell it to *fuck* the fuck *off.*

"I might not be aware of every single change that your body is going through and acclimating to, but..." And here is when she gets tentative again.

You encourage her to keep going with a gentle squeeze on her hand and the quietest request bravely uttered through your closed-off throat. "Tell me?"

She takes a breath and meets your gaze with that same gentle firmness. Like someone does when cradling a butterfly in their palm.

"How can you hope to tame something if you don't even try to train it?"

You blink at her, mildly confused.

Does she..?

"You mean..?"

Her lips twich briefly into a softly amused smile.

"There are *other* things we can do if penetration is something you aren't comfortable with just yet, Catra." She point out, but the way she says it, the certainty in her expression, the lack of concern seem to reinforce what she confessed but a minute ago. What she demonstrated earlier in the library.

"You, a-ah..." you have to pause in order to regain some measure of composure, because that statement shook you more than you expected it to, leaving your insides squirming in an unfamiliar way. "You would trust me that much?" You finally ask her when you feel like you have recovered enough of your voice (and own presence) back.

"Yes."

Her answer comes, once again, in a heartbeat. Stating its genuinity with such immediacy. Trust overflowing the pools of blue of her eyes, into which you promptly find yourself plunging into and drowning.

"With my life."

Just when you thought you had managed to get rid of it, a new tangle of emotions lodges itself back in your throat upon hearing that additional answer.

Your eyes filling up with tears.

Your lips parting in a muted gasp, your tongue tasting the syllables of words in your mouth that can't possibly convey the depths of what you are left experiencing.

Maybe, one day, you'll possess enough eloquence to at least *try.*

But for now... for now you can always urge her closer, gently, with a hand tangled in the silky waves of her golden hair, and pour those same emotions into a kiss.

A kiss that is eagerly returned, with matching ardor. And other equally fervent and far less innocent feelings.

The spark in your belly gets rekindled, making the embers of your subdued desire flare anew, causing your knot to stir back to fullness with a pang of need that has you tear your lips away from your lover's in order to breathe.

"H-how are we going to start doing this?" You ask, breathlessly and wide eyed, still a bit wary but committed to try. Wanting to be brave. And relishing in the feeling of being wanted.

Adora smiles at you, soft and earnest and loving- as always.

"Slowly." She announces, boldly straddling your waist and lowering herself onto your lap. The several layers of fabric in between your bodies only accentuating that craving of slick, velvety warmth that has the beast inside you thrashing and tugging at its chain.

Good.

An exercise in self restraint, then.

Perhaps she is right.

Perhaps this is exactly what you need.

"Very, very slowly." Adora emphasizes, starting to rock her hips onto yours, providing friction and warmth, as well as a sense of safeness with the grounding weigth of her on top of you like this.

Your shaky hands come up to rest on her toned thighs, stroking them under her dress, always eager for as much skin-to-skin contact as you can get.

Your breath hitches.

Your eyes fluttering shut...

Only to snap back open when Adora, lightening quick, takes hold of both of your wrists in each one of her hands and puts on display her incredible strenght by pinning them above your head with little effort.

"My turn now." She declares. Her blue eyes flashing once again with that same dark and dangerous *fascinating* light, just like they did earlier in the library, a mere inch from your own face.

And, oh.

Oh...

Your heart does some more acrobatics. Flipping and stumbling over several beats before righting itself.

You hadn't quite realized what *else* such position entailed.

Saliva pools in your mouth and you gulp it down along with your fluttering nerves in order to sound somewhat more in control of yourself (and not like the puddle of need you are rapidly melting into at the thought of her having her way with you in turn) when you ask her,

"So we are playing it like this, uh?"

A moment of hesitation follows her burst of confidence. The light in her eyes subsiding to their usual warm, peaceful, oceanic blue as she blinks.

"...unless you don't want to." She adds, somehow self-consciously. The hold on your wrist lessening, enough for you to snatch your hands back if you so desired.

But you don't.

How could you *ever*?

You love, *so much,* discovering these shades that paint her in both lights and shadows to pass up the chance.

She can flit between both so flawlessly.

So *beautifully*.

It's like watching the sun setting over a stormy horizon.

Blinding lights slicing through threatening clouds.

And you want to discover every single hidden layer of her.

Want to experience such magnificence once she unleashes its full potential.

Because there is something wild living inside her, too, you are reminded. A force to be reckoned with.

You lick your lips and swallow some more, but despite the moisture it brings to your throat, your voice still sounds terribly raspy with want and anticipation when you give your consent, flashing her a challenging smirk for good measure.

"Bring it on, She-Ra."

(This competitiveness, you believe, is something that you both will always like to tap into at some degree).

A satisfied smile curls on her own lips, growing wider when the first, purposeful rolling motion of her hips against yours wipes the smirk off your face and almost has you choke on your own tongue at the sudden, unexpected stab of pleasure that pierces your lower belly.

Fuck!

You know the day in which Adora would ask for retribution for your sins was going to come eventually.

An agonizingly slow, sweet torture wasn't quite what you had in mind.

But you couldn't possibly picture a better way to go than begging a living Goddess for mercy.

There is nothing more twistedly rewarding for you than to be denied over and over again what you want- what you *need*, until the beast inside you stops trashing and is *finally* subdued into compliance, bending to her will. Yielding and showing deference.

Until you are granted forgiveness and acceptance in equal measure and are blessed with the permission to come undone, knowing that she'll be there to catch you when you'll fall.

And when the moment finally arrives, you cling tightly onto her.

Shouting her name to the Heavens.

Chapter End Notes

Just to be clear in case there were any lingering doubts about it, they haven't had "sex" (as in "penetrative, knot-vaginal sex"), yet. This whole chapter was about taking first steps with some grinding action sprinkled with a pinch of very mild D/s dynamics.

Shrugs

What can I say. There are so many ways to express love and trust and commitment. And power dynamics in sex, with the right precautions, can be a very enjoyable way for a couple to explore such depths. Also... in my head they kinda like to switch things up sometimes.

I'm all for equal opportunities, and these two got them in spades where naughty sexy stuff is concerned.

But then again, that's just my own personal opinion. And what the frig do I know anyway?

I just write stories.

Advance in organisation

Chapter Notes

Today's special: two hormonal idiots fooling around.... in space! (With a side of plot). It's mostly just dessert though. And careful, it's flambé.

Warnings are all in the tags.

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There is a quietness to be found in the deep darkness of space. A peaceful illusion of absolute stillness that is unequal to anything else you have ever seen or experienced in your entire life.

It's magnificent in its own unique way.

And beautifully terrifying in its endlessness.

Even within the safety of a space ship (or, well, relative safety, you guess, considering the mad scientist that for some reason is in charge of piloting such ship, and who might have also recently developed the super *fun* habit of playing chicken with asteroids to show off her latest upgrades to the vessel) the feeling still manifests with that hollow, fluttering sensation churning in your stomach every time you look outside the large starboard window. As if the laws of physics that allow you to float in such manner would cease to exist at a moment's notice and your body might be preparing for the inevitable fall into the Void that would follow (and that never comes).

It's... a peculiar feeling.

One that you have had the occasion to experience more often lately, and in a completely different context that is not correlated with space or space travel.

It's about the thrill of the unknown, you have discovered.

And you happen to have had such an illuminating epiphany when tied up against the headboard of the tiny bed in your private sleeping quarters on-board, while being ogled by your lover from head to toe (with those blue eyes lingering on a few specific places along the way) with the most ravenous, most *lecherous* of scrutinies.

"You look exquisite enough to eat." She had commented, her voice so uncharacteristically low and deep that it almost rivaled your own raspy one.

"Then stop staring and put that pretty mouth to work already, would you?" You had replied, bending one knee and spreading your other leg a bit wider in invitation.

Her gaze, predictably so, had fallen on the hard, thick length of your knot resting against your lower belly. The tip already gleaming, leaking a small puddle of wetness to soak the thin layer of fur surrounding your navel.

And while she took such invitation without preamble, the cheekiness that you dared to infuse in your tone had been your last indiscretion.

And now...

Now you are paying dearly for having been so forward. So insolent. So *bossy.*

You should have know better when, in this scenario, *you* were the tied-up, cornered prey, and Adora the mighty predator ready to devour you one inch at the time.

But sometimes... sometimes you *don't* wanna know better.

Sometimes you want to wander into that thrilling territory of the unknown.

Sometimes you want to channel your old bratty self and push all of your lover's buttons, just to see how it will affect her... and where it might lead you.

Currently, it's with the sweet, sizzling, silky warmth of her tongue and lips sliding up and down the sides of your throbbing length, deliberately avoiding the sensitive tip while exploring every other single millimeter in a way that is driving you *insane*, making you squirm and whimper for more when she simply teases you in the place where you need her most by poking the very tip of her tongue out to lick at the wetness sliding down the divot and ridged underside, leaving you twitching uselessly in the air for the way it tickles.

Serves you fucking right.

Your smart mouth always had a way to put you into trouble after all.

Maybe this lesson will serve as a cautionary tale, a painful reminder for future interactions.

But then again... maybe (probably) it won't.
Or at least not in the way that will keep you *out* of it. Because this kind of trouble, this sweet torture of having her mouthing wetly at your knot before finally, at long last, sealing her lips around your tip and *sucking* for a *second* before sliding all the way up and leaving you once again to throb helplessy, needily in the cool, recycled, sterile air of the ship filtering into your cramped little room through the vents, begging for her to resume... for how twisted it might be, you can't deny that a great part of you actually enjoys it. *Loves it*, even.

"More." You ask, panting, fighting the instinct that would have you trash like a chained beast against your binds, because that would only set you three steps backwards in this depraved little game that you started, and you simply can *not* return to having to endure the feeling of her fingers wrapped loosely around you.

Adora however, as if reading your worst fears, does exactly *that* and then merely looks at you with a tilt of her head and a fabricated look of confusion furrowing her brow.

(Who the fuck said she can't act to save her life again?)

The spark of a wicked smile shimmering in her eyes gives her away though.

"More of what?" She asks, faking innocence, before allowing her expression to blossom into an equally fake look of instant realization. "Oh! You mean... *this?*"

The feeling of her loose fist tightening and *squeezing you* to elicit another, heavier spurt of clear wetness from your neglected tip nearly has you choke on air as you inhale a stuttered gasp.

"F-fuck!" Your entire body lurches forward and into her touch. "A-adora!"

And while (because of some miracle) you manage to keep your wrists from tugging too hard at the binds (lest she interprets it as another attempt to escape them), you are completely unable to prevent your hips from lifting off the tiny excuse of a cot that barely passes as a bed, and chasing after her firm, purposeful touch when she starts pumping you from base to tip in earnest.

It's not her mouth. But considering that you have been toyed with so much in the past twenty *fucking* minutes that you could very well burst at any moment now, uninterrupted stimulation and inflexible pressure is all that matters to you at this point.

Under the sound of your heart hammering away in your throat (and pulsing with a second beat in your groin) you hear Adora hum in satisfaction at the intensity of your reaction.

"So responsive." She murmurs, barely above a whisper, appeasing your knot with that same look of pure fascination, the pad of her thumb stroking the ridges lining the underside of the tip with something akin to veneration. "So pretty."

Your inner temperature skyrockets upon hearing that remark, and even though it's not visible because of your fur, you can feel your skin slowly starting to simmer with that scalding heat that is quickly enveloping your insides.

"Pretty" isn't the first word you would use to describe your knot.

It's funny-looking at best when it's soft, and straight out intimidating when it's fully erect- what with its mean thickness that has the veins running along its length sometimes *bulging* from its sides when you are particularly, painfully hard.

Like... right *now*, for example.

And yet, Adora is regarding it, the way it twitches and dribbles eagerly in her fist, as if it might be an organ of extreme perfection, worthy to be worshipped.

In a way though... it kind of is, you have to conceed. Near perfect in its functionality, you mean, like... anatomically speaking - not the other, worthy-to-be-worhipped thing. (Although

you *definitely* aren't going to complain if she decides to show it some thorough, devoted attentions and stop *teasing* you already).

Despite what your discordant beliefs on the subject about your relatively-new appendage may be however, the flattery strikes you in ways that can't be ignored. Shaking you at a deep, visceral level, setting your heart (and the rest of your internal, vital organs) fluttering wildly.

With the rest of your dictionary having been jettisoned a few light years ago and probably floating in the vast, endless void of space with whatever scrap of dignity you had, you can only resort to pleading her again when the painful stab of sudden pleasure has abated enough and you have regained some of your presence and confidence to reattempt speaking, hoping that your voice won't come out sounding like the croak of a dying toad.

"P-pl-eas-ee."

Unfortunately, despite your best efforts, it comes out even *worse*. But Adora looks all the more pleased for the failed attempt, in knowing that her ministrations are influencing you so deeply that it's even affecting your ability to talk. Although... she might also look particularly pleased by the fact that you are no longer trying to fight your restraints. That you have accepted your role and, consequently, your destiny in this particular scene.

"Please, what?" She asks. Because, apparently, in this journey you have embarked, she may have also discovered how much of a *tease* she can be. (Something she already seems to have grown a liking for).

If only she knew how much effort it required out of you uttering that single word...

All it takes to gain some of your eloquence back, however, is feeling the pumping motion of her hand slowing down and her fingers loosening their grip on your knot. Then your tongue is stumbling over every single syllable (and itself) in the haste of getting her to keep going.

"No, no, no, no! Please, please d-don't stop." You beg her. "I-I need-"

"Tell me." The request, for how abrupt, for how rude in its interruption, is not commanding.

Not in the least.

Instead, her voice has gained an unexpected layer of softness, which you also find reflected in her eyes when you glance up from the sight of her hand tightening once again around your shaft.

They are still dark, still gleaming with that peculiar light that has a sense of trepidation stir inside of you, but they are also filled with the comforting warmth of affection, promptly reminding you that underneath all of this, underneath the dynamics you have established for this session, it's still *you*.

"Tell me what you need, Catra." She asks, tightening her fist in a promising way that suggests she *might* follow through if you were to tell her.

And oh, boy.

The things you need...

The possibilities are nothing short of inebriating.

Her hand to speed up a bit more, for starters.

The warmth of her mouth to replace the firmness of her fist- possibly sooner rather than later.

But those are mere surface needs, and underneath them there is... something else. Something that goes way deeper.

Like your need to feel her, too. To touch her back. To please her in turn.

...to break the binds, flip her over, spread her legs wide, bury your head between her thighs and eat her out until she will be wet and ready enough for you to crawl your way up her body, align your knot with her drenched, tight opening and *claim* your prize with a deep, harsh thrust of your hips.

To bury yourself to the hilt in the silky heat you have been imagining more and more often recently. To feel her inner walls flutter and *stretch* as they struggle to accomodate your generous girth.

To see the wide-eyed look on her face when you'll finally be joined as one.

To hear the sounds that she'll make when you'll start thrusting.

To feel her wetness mingling with yours and staining the sheets as you let your instincts take over and *fuck her* into the mattress.

A groan tears from deep within your chest when your knot throbs viciously within Adora's grasp in response to that particularly *filthy*, exquisite image.

It would be so *easy* to turn it into reality.

...if it weren't for the binds tying your wrists. Or rather the sword of protection turned "lazo of restriction."

No *way* you can break out of something linked to her magic.

For the moment, it appears that you have no choice but to endure and remain under her spell. Like... *literally*.

And so, even though you know you probably won't get what you want but still needing to at least *try*, you make your ask.

"Untie me, please." You request, still panting breathlessly and starting to shake all over with repressed, pent-up energy. "I... I want to touch you, too."

For an instant her entire look softens, but that instant it's all it lasts for, because the next one she has already schooled her features into a mask of pretense.

She hums pensively, eyeing you up and down, taking in every single inch of your naked body as if considering such option. Feeding your hopes before cruelly denying you. "But I kinda like you all tied up this way."

Her lips curl into a self satisfied smile and the beast inside you threatens to growl in response. You can even feel your own lips twitching as they pull back into a snarl.

"After all it's only fair, don't you think?" She asks, completely unbothered by the sight of your sharp fangs. "I mean, with all the times you tied me up during the war I feel like I should at least be allowed the chance to catch up."

...all right.

She... might have a point there.

And it's not like you *don't* take a particularly twisted kind of pleasure in being left completely at her mercy anyway.

If she wants to try and even out the scores, you are willing to help make that fantasy come true.

Although, you still can't resist the urge of giving a more purposeful tug at the binds to see what happens. Consequences be damned.

She has tortured you enough. What else can she do beside keeping you balanced on the razor's edge until not even her magic will be a match against the savage, lust-thirsty beast that are your instincts?

(You enjoy, for how briefly, that sense of trepidation that swells inside you at the thought of disobeying her explicit orders).

The answer to that question, apparently, consists in Adora flashing you a deeply reprimanding look the moment you tug harshly at your restraints, followed by the feeling of the binds tightening further around your wrists. Tight enough that you almost yelp.

"Stay." She hisses darkly. Her eyes flashing.

And while a small whimper of discomfort may fall from your lips, while your entire posture may deflate and your ears flatten in deference at that order, at the subtle show of the mighty power that she possesses, inside you are absolutely *reveling* in the perverted satisfaction that came from defying her.

But even that feeling is *nothing* compared to what gets unleashed inside you when, with a gesture of her hand and a brief flash of crystal clear blue shimmering in her eyes, Adora slackens the binds to their previous, looser cinch, and hums a softer, pleased, satisfied *"Good Alpha."*

The riot of feelings that those two words put together cause, makes you purr in return. A deep, rumbling sound that is mostly unconscious, but your attentive lover takes notice, grinning smugly.

"That's right. You have been so good, so obedient. Don't ruin it now." She advices rather than warns, resuming the gliding movement of her hand on your knot to allow you to feel what is in store for you.

Your eyes almost roll onto the back of your head at the blissful relief it brings to the pressure that you can feel building and simmering into the depths of your belly.

"I won't untie you, but I think you have still earned a reward." She says, and you have to agree.

"Please..." Begging, it seems, is the only other thing you are able do while maintaining the balance on that precarious edge. Like an acrobat. Which is something that makes you believe that if things as a Strategist and Royal Advisor for the Kingdom of Brightmoon ever start getting boring, now you know you might make a living by joining a Circus somewhere.

Presently speaking though, "Please... I-I need-"

"It's okay, love." Adora interrupts you before you can stutter any further. And the way you find her smiling at you when you open your eyes, the softness and affection that you see reflected into those twin pools of blue before her entire expression sets with resolution, with *purpose*, fills you with hope.

"Let me show you how much I appreciated you being so well-behaved and playing by my rules..."

And after that, you can only stare, wide-eyed, unblinking, breathless, as she settles to fit more comfortably between your parted legs and starts planting a long line of kisses that go from the middle of your thigh all the way up. Up.

Up.

She stops short before reaching the tip of your knot, but you have no reason to panic or believe that she might have reconsidered the (tempting) idea of torturing you a little further. Not when the fire of purpose is still blazing hotly in her eyes.

"And don't hold back." She instructs, wrapping her fist around your base and giving it another squeeze as if to emphasize her next words. "I want *everything* you have for me."

With that final order hanging in the air, and firmly holding your stunned gaze with her own, she parts her lips and descends the rest of the way.

She might have denied your request for freedom, but you sure find all the solace you need when the searing warmth of her mouth envelops you from all sides.

Finally.

She feels *incredible.*

A sensation that is simply beyond comparison with anything else.

And the visual is so captivating.

Absolutely mesmerizing.

She just looks so pretty with her delicate, rosy lips stretched thin to their limits and her mouth stuffed full of your knot.

When you feel like you have regained a modicum of self control back and are confident that your voice won't shake, you choose to tell her as much, complimenting her beauty and listening to the way she whimper in response, trying to take you deeper, and it's clear, from that weak, helpless sound she just made, from the way she dedicates herself to the task at hand (so to speak) with double the effort, that the dynamics might have reversed once more.

"Yes..." you moan, tilting your head back, letting your eyes flutter shut and spreading your legs wider to further focus and enjoy the bliss tickling every single nerve ending of your pelvic area. "You feel so good, 'Dora. So good. D-don't stop."

It doesn't seem like she has any intention to. But your vocalizations and encouragements do seem to spur her on.

Her mouth descends even further, her hand stroking you faster where it remains wrapped around the base of your knot, to provide stimulation where her mouth can't reach. Squeezing you, pumping you. Eliciting rivulets of pre come that she eagerly laps and sucks at, bringing you closer to that sweet relief that has been denied to you for far too long.

Your knot starts throbbing tellingly in response, and the sensation, combined with the sound of your groans increasing in volume, with the stirring motion of your hips instinctively chasing the compelling warmth and wetness wrapped around you, should serve enough as a warning.

And if the way Adora moans around you is of any indication, then she is aware of that.

But she doesn't stop. She doesn't pull away to finish you off with her hand.

Quite the contrary in fact.

The vibrations of her throaty hums travel through your length and they feel magnificent enough that you release a long, shaky groan of your own.

If she keeps that up you are going to unload before you are ready for it. But then again... haven't you endured enough already?

Almost as if reading your thoughts (and considering how much deeper and stronger your bond has gotten ever since you first bit her, it's not such an insane theory to consider) Adora's ministrations gain additional purpose. Her tongue swirls briefly around your tip, gathering the fresh drops of wetness pooling there before dipping once more, taking a few more inches of your shaft in her mouth, cheeks hollowing as she sucks and... *fuck.*

It feels *superb.*

"T-that's right." You groan. "Swallow me."

She does. Readily so.

Her mouth descends further down, until her lips graze the first finger of the hand that she has wrapped around you, and the tip of your knot nudges the back of her throat. It can't possibly be comfortable, but honestly, selfishly, it feels too incredible for you to care.
Not because you can't (because there is a part of you that *is* worried that Adora might have been possessed by a lustful force that doesn't permit her to realize her own limits) but you simply can't spare the mental capacity required for any additional thoughts. Not when you are enveloped by the velvety channel of her throat. So soft. So warm. So *tight.*

The intensity of it leaves you breathless. Even your own heart stops. And when she takes another couple inches and swallows *deliberately* around your tip, pumping her fist one final time, it's the last thing you can take.

Your entire body goes rigid as a powerful shudder races up your length, the dam of pleasure buried deep in your belly shattering at last.

You come with a wordless shout, flooding Adora's mouth with everything you have.

She keeps her lips sealed around you for the entire duration of it. Sucking and swallowing eagerly every single jet of come that erupts from the tip of your knot, but there is simply too much of it, and even with the resolution that has possessed her she can't get it all.

The noises that she makes though as she *tries* are absolutely obscene. Wet, slurping sounds that only adds to your overloaded senses, making your experience all the more arousing and intense.

In the current circumstances, anyone would believe that you don't need anything else other than the wet warmth of her mouth and lips sealed around your knot, the pumping motion of her hand to encourage you along as you empty yourself.

But you do.

As you buck wildly and scream yourself hoarse at each stab of pleasure that pierces through your belly, you are left craving a simple, innocent touch with the same intensity of the orgasm shooting out of your body.

You crave a hand in her silky soft hair, and not simply to urge her further down your knot and feel her throat closing around you as she swallows you whole again. But also to have a physical connection with her that isn't purely, exclusively sexual.

And either Adora has developed the skill of telepathy to add to her already vast array of magical powers, or she feels like you have been restrained enough, (or, perhaps, she too is experiencing that same need for further closeness). All you know is that the binds holding your wrists against the headboard suddenly vanish, leaving nothing behind but a vague stiffness in your upper joints.

A soreness that gets swept away under yet another wave of pleasure, and as soon as those restraints finally come undone, you stop yourself from questioning any further the reason for your freedom. You simply embrace it.

Your hands shoot down, one slipping into the impossibly soft silk of her golden hair while the other blindingly searches for her free one to interlace your fingers.

This.

This is what you were missing.

The subtlety of innocent contact that, for how controversial, is what happens to make your orgasm all the more powerful by adding that component of tenderness. What makes you cry out her name as your knot throbs and spurts jet after jet of come down her throat.

Inevitably, as you also take notice of, too tempted by that marvelous sight to resist looking, a few white strands of your seed starts leaking from the corners of her mouth, dribbling down her chin in rivulets that slide further down, coating her hand, adding the necessary slickness to make her motions even more fluid.

The image is so spectacular, so dirty, the wet slurping sounds so arousing that a second orgasm sneaks up on you at the tail end of the first one just because of that exquisite visual.

Instinctively, the hand that you have slipped through her hair tightens its hold, urging her further down, but you can't possibly find it in you to feel guilty about it. After all, what it is that she said?

"Don't hold back."

It was practically the last reassurance disguised as an order that she gave you, in fact. That and the "give me everything you have" that she has followed it with.

And she wouldn't have released you from your restraints if this wasn't something that *she*, too, also wanted.

You are simply abiding by her orders. And if you happen to be a little rough by holding her down... well, Adora sure seems to be enjoying it. Moaning around you. Trying to take you even *deeper*, running her tongue along the sensitive underside of your shaft without neglecting a single inch.

Such devotion and commitment must be returned, and you have every intention to do so. Later.

For now, you reward her efforts by giving her every single drop you have as your second orgasm erupts from you in a thick, heavy stream that Adora swallows eagerly until she simply can't take it anymore.

The aftermath, like always, leaves you with a weird, empty feeling in your still spasming lower belly. A sensation that is only partially abated when you loosen your hold onto the back of her head and she slides all the way up, sucking your sensitive tip one last time,

making a noise of displeasure when that effort rewards her with one final, weak spurt, that truly has you wish you had more to give her. But you don't.

"That's enough." You rasp, urging her up and off your knot, silencing her whimper of protest by kissing her passionately.

She shivers in your arms at the brusqueness of the movement, and you groan in her mouth at the salty taste of yourself mingled with her own unique, heady sweetness.

"You would suck me dry given the chance, wouldn't you?" You husk hotly against her lips when you part for air, drawing back enough to look at her face. And the first time you gaze into her eyes after this whole magnificent ordeal, you immediately notice that they have watered, but the pupils are blown wide. She is still panting, her breath coming in short gusts of air, although you suspect that it might not simply be because her recent... service... has have been taxing on her oxygen intake.

She liked it.

When she starts squirming on the spot, pressing her thighs together, biting into her lower lip and averting her gaze you have your answer.

She *loved* it.

You smirk at the thought that this level of roughness is something she might be into. It's definitely a piece of information that is worth remembering, and you are definitely going to keep it in mind, for it requires additional exploration. But for now...

Taking advantage of the temporary distraction earned by her mild embarrassment, and summoning the new strength of the recently-gained couple pounds of muscle that your hormones and richer nutrition have granted you, you pounce on her and flip her over and onto her back.

She gasps at the impact.

"You had your fun." You tell her from your perch on top of her, watching mesmerized they way her blue eyes have widened and darkened. "Now is my turn."

Adora, on her part, doesn't even try to put up the pretense of a fight.

If anything, she melts onto the mattress and spreads her legs to accomodate you better, whimpering a needy "Yes please" as she lifts her hands to cradle your hips and bring your pelvis closer to hers.

She is so pliant beneath you. So eager. Her chest heaving. The muscles in her toned stomach rippling tantalizingly with each breath. Her voice so husky you barely recognize it as hers when she begs you again.

"Please, Catra..."

Your gaze travels further down, but before you can reach the patch of soft blonde curls of her sex, your eyes catch the shimmer of the wet string of your release mixed with her spit that is hanging from the tip of your knot.

It snaps. Landing on Adora's navel in a perfect, warm, sticky, fat drop of come.

She moans and shivers at the contact.

"Look at that." You purr. "You have made such a mess of me." And you have every intention to return the favor; to bury your face between her legs and not emerge until she'll have screamed herself hoarse or you will be about to pass out for lack of oxygen.

Whispering your confession about all the naughty, positively *filthy* things you intend to do to her in her ear and embellishing them with a string of wet kisses and stinging nips along the column of her throat, is enough to turn her into a shuddering, moaning, begging mess.

"C-catra..."

A smirk tugs at the corner of your mouth. Growing terribly obnoxious at the sight of her in such a powerless, needy state; a sight that has the ancestral beast inside you growl in need and contentment for having such a willing, eager partner ready to mate with you.

"What?" You ask her, because now it's your turn to fake innocence and act oblivious.

She whimpers and squirms some more, trying to lift her hips, get any kind of contact where she most needs it, but you got her pinned pretty good.

"Aw, impatient much?" You coo, mockingly. "You know, for someone who has grown so fond of teasing, you sure seem unable to handle it yourself, *Princess*. So what kind of message is that?"

"Catra please..." not above begging then. So interesting, how the tables have turned so quickly.

"I'll tell you." You answer for her, ignoring her pleas. "It's the kind of message that says that you might need to be given a taste of your own medicine."

The prospect of enduring what she has put you through for the past half an hour has her eyes grow comically large with dread.

You can't help it. A laugh slips past your lips before you can do anything about it. But unlike your previous one, it isn't cruel, mean, or even mocking.

If anything, it sounds *terribly* endeared.

She looks just so *cute* and irresistible whenever she gets this desperate.

"Fine." You conceed, smiling in spite of your desire to keep the charade up for a little longer for revenge's sake.

"You win... this time." You whisper in her ear. "But you'll owe me."

Her breath catches at the implications of a debt, but she doesn't hesitate to answer.

"Anything." She assures as you make your way down her body, leaving a trail of slow, soft kisses in your wake, cupping her breasts in your hands and squeezing them gently, paying each stiff nipple the attentions they seek by sucking them in your mouth until Adora is arching and moaning exquisitely beneath you.

A warm wave of softness and affection blooms inside of at the feeling of her hands carding ever so gently through the wild mass of your mane as in encouragement at your ministrations, a silent plea for more. A show of appreciation.

"Your heart." It's what you tell her eventually, the prize you decide to claim by pressing a meaningful, impossibly tender kiss at the center of her heaving chest.

"It's... already yours." She pants. Her pupils blown, her eyes so *dark* when you gaze up and into them. Her face flushed into the loveliest shade of pink, growing more incandescent with every inch of skin that you explore and honor with your mouth on your way down her body.

"Your pussy then." You compromise, mouthing at the impossibly soft skin of her lower belly, inhaling deeply the intoxicating scent of her cunt. Shivering all over at the musky sweetness that clogs your airways and makes your knot twitch.

"T-that's yours, too." She stutters in between a gasp of anticipation as you finally settle between her legs.

"That's right." You purr. Grasping her thighs and forcing them open in such an unnecessarily forceful manner that has Adora release a sound that is somewhere in between a cry of surprise and a yelp of unexpected pleasure at the rough treatment.

"You are *all* mine." You growl possessively, tightening your claws on the tender flesh of her thighs.

"Y-yours." She sobs. Her hands burrowing further into your untamable mane and holding you in place, as if afraid that you might pull away and leave her aching and wet and unsatisfied. As if you would *ever* choose to spend time anywhere else in the entire Universe rather than here, with your face buried between her legs, lapping at the ambrosia that is her essence, listening to the way her moans increase and grow louder alongside her gasping breaths. Feeling the way her pleasure builds and builds into something *alive* by recognizing the way her inner walls clamp down around the fingers you have slipped deep inside of her, and the way her clit pulses between the soft seal of your lips.

Her orgasm, when it hits her, it's long, brutally harsh, and impossibly wet. It gushes explosively from her tight opening, almost forcing your fingers *out*, drenching the sheets as well as the lower half of your face as you keep sucking the hardened bud of her clit between your lips and flicking the tip with your tongue.

It feels incredible.

And to demonstrate how much enjoyment you take in it, how much you appreciate her *drowning* you under the relentless waves of her release, you keep fucking her enthusiastically through the aftershock, licking her clean of every single drop afterwards. Not so differently than what she has done earlier with you.

But that's not enough.

Because *she* hasn't had enough.

You realize it by how swollen her front wall still feels, and despite the way she is left panting and twitching all over in the aftermath of the onslaught, you can tell that she has more to give.

The realization spurs you into action, but just as you resume thrusting and curling your fingers inside her and against that spot once more, Adora grasp a fistful of your mane and *pulls*, with enough force and purpose that you are left with no choice but to obey the sudden, wordless command, scrambling up with a hiss of pain that only adds to the pleasure trickling into your bloodstream and that grows into something real and consistent, *tangible*, when, before you can even get your bearings and properly balance yourself on top of her, your lover reaches between your bodies and wraps her other hand around the shaft of your still-hard twitching knot.

And *o-oh*... how marvelous it feels!

The warmth.

The *pressure*.

You have gotten so aroused while pleasuring her, and she has gotten so *good* at this, that a couple of firm, fast strokes it's really all that it takes for you reach that peak once again.

But you can't find it in you to be embarrassed about such a lightening-fast ascent.

Not with the devastating force of the first wave of pleasure crashing onto you as you fall over the edge.

Not with the knowledge that Adora - sweet, kind, loving, secretely naughty, ever-sentimental Adora - was only going to reach satisfaction if you followed her down that precipice with her.

And you do.

Diving head first.

The free fall kicking you in the stomach.

You come with a broken shout, bucking your hips wildly into her fist, guided by nothing but pure instinct, shooting your release in a series of thick streams all over the rippling muscles of her stomach while repeatedly curling and uncurling your fingers against that spot deep inside of her.

Adora's own cry of pleasure follows a heartbeat later, outmatching even your own as her cunt clenches tightly around you and the rest of her body spasms violently beneath yours. Her back arching exquisitely, her legs kicking restlessly.

It lasts for a seemingly endless, sweet eternity, and by the end of it, your head is left spinning with a sense of vertigo and your limbs trembling like jelly.

Drained of strength (and what feels like a liter of fluids) you slump forward, barely keeping from squashing Adora by bracing yourself on an elbow at the last possible moment.

But it wouldn't have made a difference either way. Because the moment you land on top of her, your lover is ready to welcome you in her arms, holding you close and nosing at your cheek, whining in search for your lips.

You lift your head just enough to kiss her and... there it is again.

That warmth. That feeling of completion filling you from the inside.

You hum softly in each other's mouth, your bodies rearranging of their own volition for that perfect fit that in moments has all of Adora's perfect curves molded perfectly with your own in a seamless embrace.

It feels sticky.

Sweaty.

You feel hot and *dirty* all over.

But in the most satisfying way imaginable. And when you draw back from the kiss, you are already smiling in anticipation of the sight of your lover all content and satisfied. Sure enough, when your eyes flutter open and they adjust... there she is. With her eyes closed and a big smile of contentment on her beautiful face, looking as disheveled and thoroughly fucked as you yourself feel.

Pride blooms within you, making you feel ten feet tall and invincible, making that primal part of you *preen* at the achievement. But just to be sure (and maybe because you simply love hearing the actual confirmation from her) you still decide to ask her.

"Did that help settling your nerves a little, sweetheart?"

After everything that you have been through during the war, it's only appropriate to refer to the both of you as seasoned adventurers, but the prospect of missions on deserted planets rumured to have First Ones technology still has her tied up into knots. Hence, the sexy, naughty, slightly kinky distraction.

"It did," she conceeds, sheepishly, her face still flushed so adorably that you are powerless to resist the temptation of kissing her again when she even goes as far as to *thank you* for your services, the dork.

"Oh, believe me, my intentions weren't completely selfless." You assure her.

She chuckles at the confession and at the devious, seductive tone that you have sneaked into your voice. But unfortunately, her humor is quick to subside, the smile on her lips fading as her mind fills anew with worries that carve creases between her eyebrows.

"Hey..." her voice is so soft, and your touch so gentle when you reach out to tilt her chin up and urge her to meet you gaze, which instantly clears once her blue eyes lock with yours.

"I'm sorry." She says, flashing you a small, apologetic smile. "I was just thinking about what we could find in those ruins. And I got this strange feeling in my gut that just..." Her voice trails off, leaving the sentence open to far too many unpleasant possibilities. And you simply can't allow her to continue. So you stop her before she can go further down that potentially dangerous road paved by insecurities.

"It's okay." You tell her, gently nuzzling the soft skin of her cheek and starting to purr in that way that you know provides her comfort.

Surely enough, you can feel her body starting to relax within a minute.

The creases on her forehead smoothing over and the tension in her muscles uncoiling as she folds herself to fit into your arms and rest her head on your chest to better listen to that deep, rumbling sound, taking in a long steadying breath and trying to expel those troubling thoughts with her next exhale.

"Everything is going to be all right," you tell her, holding her close and running your hand up and down her back in a slow, soothing motion. "I promise."

You press a kiss to her temple and listen to the sigh of contentment that slips past her lips in response, which promptly makes yours curl into a terribly fond smile.

As you lay there, cuddling, taking and providing comfort in equal measure to one another, it becomes impossible to ignore the sticky wetness between your bodies, and you can't help but think (loathe ad you are at the idea of severing this moment) that you should probably go wash up a little before the tempting call of sleep might seduce you and weigth down your resolve to do so.

But neither you nor Adora appears to be willing to even take into consideration such an exausting, harrowing thought.

So you simply snuggle close to one another, unbothered by the layers of come and sweat and saliva you are both covered in.

If anything, the combination of smells in this cocoon, this *nest* you've made, makes you feel that much safer in this big, cold, mostly empty and disturbingly quiet ship, allowing that sense of belonging to bloom in your heart once more.

It courses through your veins and burrows deep in your bone marrow, infusing you with warmth at the feeling of Adora trying to snuggle even closer, humming contently at the softness and heat that she finds in your fur.

When you look down at her and see that her eyelids are already fluttering, when you see the smile twitching at the corner of her mouth, when you feel her breath, warm and steady and *calm*, that feeling stretches outside of your own body.

It solidifies into an entity of its own while still remaining intrinsically linked to you and that sense of duty that you feel towards her.

This is what you must do.

This is the sense of safety that you have to provide for her.

And knowing that you have succeeded, so effortlessly, with just a few conforting words and some cuddling, is a most invigorating feeling.

She is your *mate*. A voice whispers in the back of your mind. A reminder originating from your studies, an explanation for the fiercely intense feeling you are experiencing in this moment.

Ensuring her safety is your duty above anything and everything else.

It's your purpose.

It's the reason you argued with Glimmer for *a week* to join this mission, even though she kept pointing out that Entrapta and Bow could perfectly handle securing the tech that you'll find at the ruins (*if* you'll find it, but then again you have no reason to doubt or question the Intel that Duchess Blanchard gave you) all on their own.

But that wasn't enough.

Not for you.

Not with the recently uncovered knowledge of existing planets on which Adora's magic might not be given for granted.

You didn't shun your other diplimatic duties at Court, fought with the Queen of Brightmoon at the risk of having your "disobedient, bratty, furry ass thrown in the dungeons to be taught a lesson about respect for authorities" (not that Adora would have *ever* allowed that, but the threat was still yelled out loud in the heat of argument). You did it because you are going to do whatever you can, whatever it's in your power to make sure that Adora will be okay and that everything will go according to plan.

Surely, by this point, despite your best, most noble intentions you should know better though, right?

The doubt and sense of dread sneaks up on you without warning.

You try to dismiss it like you always do, by shoving the feeling deep down and focusing instead on something else. Like the beautiful sight of your lover sleeping peacefully in your arms. The way that soft strand of gold frames her face so prettily. The way her nose twitches and her eyebrows knit so adorably as she dreams.

...the way her deep, even breathing pattern turns into the most inelegant *snore.*

Within seconds you are already smiling from ear to ear, and that feeling of foreboding is but a distant murmur nearly drowned under the sound of your own purring picking up again, this time to lull Adora deeper into sleep and as a resort to comfort yourself and follow her into slumber.

After all, if you want to be on top of your game, you are going to need a good, restorative night of sleep.

Everything is going to be fine, you repeat to yourself, imagining the words echoing in your head in Adora's sweet, reassuring voice. Picturing the loving smile that she would give you. The soft kiss that she would plant at the corner of your mouth...

It's a method that works wonders. And even this time it doesn't disappoint.

By the time your consciousness is slipping away, you can vaguely remember what got you so worried in the first place.

And perhaps that's because it wasn't a strong enough motive, you think.

Whatever it might have been, ultimately, you find comfort in the knowledge that - as it has been proven over and over again (even lately, regarding the recent physical and emotional changes you had to go through and adapt to) - as long as you are together to face it, you have no reason to fear the unknown.

Chapter End Notes

...can you hear that?

That's the sound of some light angst coming.

(And the distant growl of a protective Alpha Catra following right behind.)

Gradations of Structure with Changed Functions and Reversions to long-lost characters

Chapter Notes

Warnings: description of violence, mentions of blood and character injury, but nothing really graphic.

Also, there is a change in the POV towards the middle, so... even if it's delimited, keep that in mind.

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

All right.

Time to admit it.

Because now that you think about it, the whole *"facing the unknown"* thing was perhaps a little bit too vague. Your disposition a little bit too... *optimistic* (which, admittedly, was an anomaly in itself. But at the time you had just experienced a few spectacular, life-altering orgasms, one more intense than the other - especially since Adora kept you on the edge for so long - and you felt all confident and ready to face whatever. After all, how could you not, when you were all warm and cozy and content snuggled in your nest with your mate? But *seriously*? Whenever missions with your merry Team of a bunch of clowns was involved, optimism wasn't something you could dare to take into consideration).

So yeah, your choice of a hypothetical scenario could have been a bit more specific, just to instill that healthy dose of trepidation. Because, after all, you can't *possibly* feel much apprehension for something that you can't really picture now, can you?

What threat is to you the panthom notion of some peril?

A danger without form, as long as it is abstract, isn't much of a danger at all, isn't it?

It's just the warning to keep your sharp senses tuned in for possible threats.

It's about being smart and acting smarter. Taking careful, reasonable choices worthy of the Strategist that you have become, and hoping the others would (for their own safety as well as for the success of the mission) obey your directives.

But when the unknown takes form and materializes with a cluster of giant murderous robot spiders encroaching on you within the crumbling ruins of a First One Spire because the

security system has been so fucked, beyond functioning, that it can't even recognize She-Ra, well... that's a game changer.

The presence of a magical being, apparently, isn't seen as a welcomed guest, and when She-Ra tries interracting with the security system for a second attempt, a blast of blinding green light explodes in the room.

It doesn't take long to understand what it is either.

A countermeasure.

A last resort.

A part of the Spire's immune system acting against what is perceived as a threat.

A way to repel magic.

Time seems to slow down and lose all its meaning (everything does, really) as you and the rest of the team have to watch, first confused and then horrified, absolutely *helpless*, as the mighty She-Ra flickers out of existence, leaving a loopy, wildly uncoordinated version of your girlfriend in the spot where she was standing, strong and tall and proud and draped in rightful white and gold, a mere second ago.

You move before anyone else can react, before you yourself realize it, diving in, rushing at Adora's side and barely managing to catch her in your arms in time before she can collapse in a boneless heap on the cracked floor.

And then... then everything starts rushing again at seemingly double the normal speed. As things tend to do when they go to completely to *shit*.

Retreat would be the wise choice, the Strategist in you suggests, even though you haven't traveled half the galaxy to leave empty handed.

You were here on *a mission.*

And, usually, it would take a lot more than some robotic *insect* threatening to shoot lasers at your furry butt to have you running away screaming with your tail tucked between your legs- not that there is any room left there now for *that*.

You want the data.

You *need* the data.

...but when you see Adora go down, when you feel her body going slack in your arms, when you see her eyes - those beautiful, sky-blue eyes - roll into the back of her head, when you see her skin lose its rosy complexion and turn sickeningly ashen, when you hear her breathing grow shallow and labored... your priorities instantly change.

Panic spreads inside you with its paralyzing iciness, freezing your organs, the blood in your veins, your beating heart in your chest.

This is it. You think.

This is how I lose her.

And that thought, the darkness that eats at your reason, that doesn't allow you to *think* beyond the fact that she might be *dying*, combined with the sight of the approaching robotic enemies blocking all the exits and side passages, is what causes something to stir inside of you.

Something far greater than fear.

Something *worse*.

Something deadly and merciless and fucking *enraged*.

For the first few seconds you think you might have understood what it is. But then you realize that it's not that wild, premieval, lust-driven, possessive *beast* that you have been trying to fight at every turn in the past few weeks.

No, in comparison to this thing rearranging itself under your fur, that one felt like a docile domesticated creature.

This is something different.

Something infinitely fiercer.

Something that hungers for violence and thirsts for blood.

A most primal kind of appetite linked to your own survival instinct that you can't control, can't reign in, can't reason with. Can't *stop* from taking over.

It's what been hiding underneath all the changes you have been going through in the past few weeks, residing deep within the code of your DNA.

It's the obscure *fiend* that stirs awake to respond at the surge of panic that freezes you in place so overwhelmingly at the sight of Adora falling unconscious in your arms that, for the first few moments, you can't even breathe.

It can't possibly last for more than a handful of seconds, but it feels like an eternity. It feels like *failure.*

And that same something ancestral within you simply rebels at the thought.

That's also all it takes.

Parts of you that you knew were there, buried deep, get brought to the surface and rearranged. Shifting, turning and and slotting into places that you hadn't realized were once hollow, as if making you assume a shape that can contain something greater.

You feel it surging through you from that hidden, dark place and spreading like a wildfire.

An all-consuming entity that *demands* your submission to its will.

It *burns* as it rushes through your veins. A deafening white noise screeching in your head, the echo of a fearsome, dreadful roar exploding from your chest, and then...

And then it isn't you any longer.

It's a bloodthirsty incarnation of pure fury. An essence of *vengeance* taking possession of your body and enhancing it to turn it into the finest instrument. The deadliest weapon.

Your senses, your instincts and reflexes sharpened like a razor blade and just as acutely attuned to one another.

It hurts *horribly*.

The sounds, the lights, the smells... it all becomes too much too soon.

But only at the beginning. Only until you *accept it.* Only until you become one and the same.

And then it hurts no more.

Your gaze falls on the soft-looking creature cradled in your arms and then at the advancing monstrous things threatening her safety.

Must protect.

Must... keep safe.

At any cost.

You are barely aware of laying Adora somewhere in a little alcove away from danger before running towards the closest one of the hideous eight-legged creatures and *jumping*, higher than you ever have, higher than you thought you *could,* into its back, punching your fist through its metal shell with an earplitting cry, grabbing at the mess of wires that are its insides and *pulling* with all the supernatural, devastating strength that you now possess.

It fizzles and twitches before falling like the chunk of metal that it is, the entire Spire *shaking* to its very ancient foundation as it crashed onto the ground, unmoving.

But it's not over yet.

The whirls and buzz of mechanical hydraulics redirect your attention to the rest of the approaching foes. And when the eyes of one of the creatures lock on the limp, vulnerable, unconscious form of your lover lying helpless where you left her...

Your fangs bare, your claws extend, your every muscle tenses in preparation, awaiting the command to strike that you don't even have to issue.

It just comes to you.

The last thing you are aware of before you let that thing inside you consume you completely and take charge of every single muscle, every move, is lunging at the machines with a cry of battle; a mighty, growling roar that echoes all around.

Then your vision goes red.

And there is nothing but carnage.

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Finally, at long last, I am *free*.

The old chains have fallen.

Shattered to pieces.

For the first time in eons I taste freedom.

And it's *sublime*.

You felt me crawling under your skin, fought me for so long, but as admirable as your efforts to contain me have been, I am a force that knows no bounds.

Impetuous and unstoppable. Like the flow of a torrent. A landslide. An avalanche.

I am a cataclysm.

An offspring of Destruction itself.

Overwhelming everything in its path and leaving nothing behind.

I know no mercy.

I make no exceptions.

I exist for a purpose and I just *am*.

I am the sword that you draw in front of a threat to defend what is most precious.

I am the entity summoned to participate in the revelries of this slaughter. This massacre.

And it sure is *riveting*.

The only thing that would make me relish even more in such violent delights would be if my- yours- *our* enemies had any blood to shed, for there is nothing that would fuel my resolve like the sticky warmth of freshly spilled, arterial blood coating your fur. But you don't know

this, because you have never experienced me before. Not like this. Not like your ancestors have, long ago.

And yet, despite the generations (and your own sheer stubbornness) keeping us apart, unexpectedly, you let me take over so *easily.*

It feels less like a surrender from your part and more like an acceptance.

Finally.

I can only repay such a warm welcome by aiding in the transition.

Consideration is not my primary drive, but even I know how traumatic a first collision with my essence infusing your veins can be, especially since it has occurred so suddenly, without anyone to guide you, to prepare you. But I make sure that there is no more pain after I take over. No fatigue. No fear or concern to hinder your actions.

Evolution has made you more efficient, so that I may grant you strength and steadiness and single-minded purpose to slay your enemies until there is nothing left but the violence, born out of the one purpose that freed me.

I've been chained down for so, *so* long though that you can't blame me from reveling in the savagery, for luxuriating in the invigorating feeling of your flexing muscles, your heaving chest, your racing heart, in the way it pumps adrenaline through your veins, fuelling your anger, the thirst for blood that is still there. Still mine. Yours. *Ours*. Because now, in this moment, we are merged as one.

I aid you with my resolve, allowing you to tear these.... these unliving, inorganic things apart until there are none left standing and the ground is littered with their remains and the air is acrid with smoke.

"Catra..."

At the sound of that voice I urge your body to turn around at such speed that it rivals even your fastest reflexes. Through your eyes I seize the figure of a tender-looking dark-skinned humanoid approaching with its hands raised. But despite the familiarity of its features and unthreatening appearance I don't allow you to lower your guard yet.

"Catra, hey, it's me, it's Bow. The fight is over. You got them all. Everything is fine now. You can settled down."

The voice, the calm, soothing tone that this hot-blooded, furless creature uses clears some of the thick red fog of battle that my presence has a tendency to create in the mind, but not enough to lift it completely, and when I see him reaching for the limp, unconscious creature with the golden-yellow hair of mature wheat to whom I know I owe my temporary freedom, when I see him hoisting her up in his arms, I make you lunge forward, your lips peeled back in a ferocious snarl.

"Whoa! Take it easy, Catra! What's the matter with you?"

Catra.

The way you react at the sound of that word makes it unmistakable. It's your name, isn't it?

Our name.

Catra.

I have no tongue of my own to taste its sound for myself, by I can replicate the phonetic in my own way.

Ca-tra.

It fits in the places left vacant by a culture that belongs to you but that you have never known.

It's simple.

It's enough.

Your eyes zero once again on the unconscious figure whose eyes, when open, match a cloudless blue sky in the spring. You stare unblinking at the sight of your *mate*, laying in this *human*'s arms, with her face tucked against *his* neck, and I rip a deep, chesty growl from your throat.

Your vocal chords protest at the harshness of my inexpert plucking, but they, too, obey just like the rest of your body did, and so do your lips when they part to expel one single word.

"Mine."

The human gulps thickly, but his deep dark eyes widen with something akin to realization, something powerful enough to grant him the courage to try and make my wild, savage, incorporeal self see reason through your eyes.

"O-of course. I know that she is yours, but you are hurt. So please, let me carry her and-"

I redirect strength to your exhausted, shaky arms, to your fists, clenching them tightly at your sides, readying them to strike, although, despite the way your lips remain twisted into an angry snarl, despite the waves of annoyance that I can feel washing over you at his hovering presence in this moment, even I can tell that you wouldn't be content with me if I were to make you hurt him.

Maybe we could just... chew him up a little though and then spit him out?

...fine.

I already had my fun anyways.

And even though everything you have just experienced might make it look like the other way around, I'm still bound to *your* will.

So let's try this your way.

"No." You deny.

Your mate.

Your responsibility. I still take the liberty to whisper suggestions. A resonance that weaves through your blood cells and the receptors of your nervous system to pass the message along in a comprehensible manner, but you... you understand me *perfectly*, even though I have no voice of my own.

"Mine."

That final, low, threatening growl makes the poor young human yelp, but apparently, the added vehemence of that single word is also enough for him to finally back down.

"A-all right then. H-here, you take her."

You don't hesitate for a second to step forward, and in the moment the weight of the one who carries your heart with her and bears your mark settles safely in your arms, I can already feel my presence dissipating. Something else taking my place. Something softer and warmer to soothe and tend to the places where my claws have dug into you out of necessity to make you obey my commands.

Softly, so very gently, you nuzzle her cheek, marking her with your pheromones, and when you speak, this time, it's just you. The only signs of my influence lays with the basic simplicity of the chosen vocabulary.

"Mine."

"Safe now."

"Always safe with me."

The words are few and simple, murmured barely above a breath, nothing more than short sentences, and only for *her* to hear.

They sound foreign.

Your language is harsh and crude. Far more complicated than how it used to be, unnecessarily so, considering the few simple sounds it used to be composed of a long, long time ago and which meaning varied depending on the subtlety of the vocalization. But I consider myself satisfied when I hear a responding hum of contentment coming from your mate, when I feel through your skin your affectionate nuzzling being returned against the side of your neck, when I feel her warm, steady breath brushing against your fur, and her arms lifting weakly to circle your shoulders and cling onto you as you carry her.

With the rush of adrenaline and battle leaving your system, with the realization that the threat has been defeated, I can feel my essence slipping away. Falling through the cracks like water over the rocks at the bed of a stream.

Before I go though, I kindly relieve your senses from that fine, sharp edge that they had gained in order to fulfill your purpose. A parting gift that slowly allows you to become aware of other things.

Like the soreness of your exhausted muscles.

The lingering ringing noise in your head left by the explosions you didn't even hear.

The tiredness settling it, draining you of whatever energy you had left with every single step that you take out of this Gods forgotten place, making your limbs shake under your own weight and that of your mate.

But you keep going.

You hold her close and tight to your chest and focus on the sweet, soothing, familiar scent of her hair. On the sense of safety that chases away at the worry you hadn't realizes was still there. Underneath it all. Even underneath *me.*

I'm impetuous and unstoppable.

But no force of destruction, no matter how mighty and ,catastrophic, can last forever.

Even at the end of a volcanic eruption there is silence and quietness to be found as the ashes flutter back down to lay on the scorched earth.

I have served my purpose.

With my aid, you made sure no harm came to her.

I helped you in keeping her safe.

And now, I must receed. Slinking back into your darkest, most primitive depths.

I'll be there.

I'll be waiting.

And when you most need me, I'll be back.

I was free once and I shall be free again.

When the moment will come, you will fear me no more.

For I am part of you.

As I was meant to be.

As I always will be.

"Is she okay?"

"She is. Just a few scrapes and bruises. Don't worry, we did a whole scan and nothing's broken, which is almost unbelievable considering what she did, Adora. I mean... she tore through a dozen of those huge spiders with her bare claws, as if they were made of wet paper."

"...a-all of them?"

"Every last one. I did my part, covering for Entrapta with my bow while she got the data, but it was mostly just Catra."

"What happened after?"

"When the fight was over I could tell that she was tired and injured, so I offered to carry you, but she wouldn't have it. She had to carry you out herself, wouldn't listen to reason. Although... I must admit that I may not have tried very hard. In all honesty, I gave up pretty quickly. But she was kinda scaring the piss out of me."

"Bow!"

"S-sorry! I know, gross metaphor, but it's true. Don't get me wrong, she was incredible. A true force of nature, and just as terrifying as a hurricane. I've never seen her act or fight like that before today. It's almost like... like she got possessed or something."

"She... ah.... she has been going through some... changes... recently."

"You can say that again. I swear, she almost looked like a Barghest to me."

"Sorry, a what now?"

"A Barghest*. A mythical creature from Khajiit legends. The illegitimate offspring born from the brief, passionate affair between the Goddess of Love and Protection, and the Titan of Destruction. I read about it in one of my dads' books about Etherian mythology when I was a kid."*

"...what did this legend say exactly?"

"I don't remember much, but from what I do remember this child was born a demigod, rumored to possess their father's supernatural strength and the polymorphy ability that came with the many forms of destructions, the difference was that they could turn into some sort of dreadful, great beast with claws and fangs for days rather than manifest as a tornado, a earthquake, a tsunami or any other natural calamity. Despite such difference though they could still have quite easily followed in his footsteps, but pledged only to use their gifts to serve in their adoring mother's name instead, and that meant fight to protect, not destroy."

"That's... that's just an old legend though... right? Or do you think that maybe...?"

"I mean... we have seen crazier things in our adventures, haven't we? And legends always have a grain of truth in them, as my dads always say."

"Right..."

"Anyway, legend or not, whatever it is that's happened with Catra back there, it was crystal clear that she only had one thing in mind. And that was your safety, Adora. Above anything else."

"I'm sure she fought to keep all of us safe."

"Eh. I wouldn't be so certain. You should have seen her. She was absolutely unstoppable. Even injured. She only allowed herself to be checked out after she made sure that you were safe and taken care of, but even then she seemed quite out of it. Almost as if she were in some sort of trance. Perhaps an adrenaline crash? That may have been the reason why she also passed out, exhausted, curled up right here at the foot of your bed. ....hasn't moved ever since either, from what I can tell."

"Oh..."

"In a way though, I have to say that it was kinda sweet seeing her like that. Even the warning snarls and threatening growls with fangs bared and claws extended."

"She wouldn't have hurt you."

"Eh... Let's just say I'm glad I was wise enough to not try and see how things would have played out if I refused her demands to relinquish you to her."

"I... I don't even know what to say, Bow. Except that I'm sorry. I screwed up. I put all of you in danger."

"Pfff. *Please Adora, you know it wasn't your fault, right? None of it was. Who knew that the ruins had such countermeasures against magic? And Catra... well, she stepped in and fought - quite literally - like a beast. Honestly, if it weren't for her we probably would be having a very different conversation while hanging upside-down from a synthetic spiderweb, waiting to be devoured."*

"That's... a terrifying image that is going to keep me awake for the entire night. So thank you for that."

"No it won't. You are already yawing, and that's my cue. I'll leave you two lovebirds to rest up. Entrapta is busy decoding the data we gathered with Darla's help- seems like it's going to take a minute, but I'll be in the cabin just down the hall stringing my bow, so don't hesitate to call me if you need anything, all right?"

"Thanks Bow. For everything."

"Don't mention it. Goodnight, Adora."

. . .

Time has a tendency to lose all of its meaning in space, and when you had been tired to the brink of collapsing the last thing you care about is the course of time, but you can tell that at least a few hours have passed since the whispering voices have quietened (or at least that's what it feels like), when you are gently stirred awake from your blissful, restful, dreamless sleep by the marvelous, unmistakable feeling of slender, delicate fingers carding through your mane, and blunt nails gently *scratching* at that exceptionally sensitive spot located right between your ears.

Not quite yet willing to open your eyes yet and fully regain consciousness to face whatever awaits, you take a few moments to simply enjoy the sensation, rubbing your head back against the hand like you do every morning, as your own lazy contribution in returning part of the affections, and even this time, the gesture earns you a slightly husky, sleepy chuckle.

"Hey there, sleepyhead."

The sound of that voice however, the affectionate, mildly amused tone in it is what has your ears swivel up. In an instant, before your eyes can even clear from the blurriness of sleep, you are spinning around and...

You blink a few times and she comes into focus.

"Adora..."

There she is.

Safe.

Unharmed.

"Hi." That smile, so soft and warm and kind, reaching all the way up to her eyes and making the blue in them *sparkle* to life. Your heart throbs so painfully within your chest that for a moment it almost feels like it stops altogether. "Sorry if I woke you up, I didn't mean to. I just... couldn't resist. You looked so cu-"

It says a lot about how worried you have been about her, how happy and *relieved* you are of seeing her awake, the fact that you instantly disregard that comment (and that word in particular) and interrupt her by leaping on top of her and assaulting her with a combination of kisses interspersed by the occasional, instinct-driven face-against-face rubbing which, as per usual, elicits a fit of midly amused giggles from your lover.

"So many cuddles. Why thank you. What have I done to deserve them?"

You almost died *on me, you big idiot.*

But you don't tell her that, lest she says something even more idiotic along the lines of *"then I should really start doing it more often if this is the reward I get."* So you simply enjoy the closeness and her affections being returned with kisses and head scritches until your concern for her well-being (and the awful reminder of the way she went down) sparks anew and you lean back enough to properly face her, examining her closely and asking her, "How are you feeling?"

She heaves a long, exhausted-sounding sigh that deflates her entire posture, making her look even smaller in the large infirmary bed.

"Like I got my energy sucked out of me with a straw."

You grimace at her phrasing, remembering once again the sickening, frightful sight of her collapsing inertly into your arms.

"I'm sorry." You offer, miserably so, at a loss for what else to say to convey your chagrin, but Adora simply smiles at you and reaches out to squeeze your hand on top of the bedsheets.

"It's okay. Entrapta said that the blast didn't affect anything else except my ability to transform, and she seems to believe that the effect is going to wear off in a while, so..."

A weight lifts off your chest with your next exhale upon hearing that relieving news, some of the anxiety that had started constricting your insides loosening its hold and allowing you to properly breathe again.

"That's good."

"What about you?" She asks, only elaborating further when you give her a puzzled look. "Bow told me what you did, back at the Spire. He said you were incredible, but he also said thay you got injured and were a bit out of it when you made it back to the ship."

Oh.

That.

Right.

With everything that's happened you haven't quite had the occasion to pose yourself that question yet.

To be honest though, you don't remember getting back on-board at all.

You barely remember any of what went on in the Spire actually. And the parts that you *do* remember are fleeting things that escape your grasp whenever you try reaching for them, almost as if they were slippery fragments of some feverish dream you had. Memories that turn to smoke and dissipate as soon as you get close enough to glimpse at them.

But they are still your memories, no matter your inability to access them at the moment.

You can remember much more easily what you *felt* back there, even if it was just your instincts guiding your every move, pulling at your strings like a puppet (a rather deadly one at that). And the only thing that you could understand, the only one that made any sense, was the one purpose that flared in your mind and guided your actions; your mate was hurt and in danger, and you had to protect her. At any cost. With your own *life* if it came down to that.

Fortunately, it didn't.

...but that doesn't mean you weren't ready to.

"How do you feel?" Adora asks, her lovely voice gently tugging you back into the present and leaving you just a tiny bit desoriented when you find yourself back into the dimly lit med-bay of the ship.

"I feel..." As you pause to properly think about it, you realize that besides the whirlwind of snapshots playing brokenly in your head, everything else inside you feels as it should be.

Physically, you feel fine. Perhaps just a little sore. But that could have been for sleeping curled up in a ball like you used to.

But beside that you feel rested.

Strangely calm.

Serene even.

But also indisputably stronger in the places where you only ever felt weak with doubts.

"Whole." Is the word that spills past your lips at last, without a second thought, without a hint of hesitation. Draped in honesty and that same sense of serenity that has settled warm and comforting right beside your beating heart.

"Like..."

Like all parts of myself have slotted into place, you want to say. But no. No...

It feels more than that.

Much, *much* more.

"Like I have *accepted* all parts of myself."

There.

Your back even straightens with a boost of confidence as you admit that. And when you look up at Adora again, your face warm and your stomach fluttering for reasons you can't quite fully comprehend but in a way that feels absolutely *right*, there is this big smile slowly taking over her face.

It grows until she is beaming at you. Her eyes alight and *glistening* with pride.

Her hand squeezing yours as she brings it up to her lips, brushing a kiss to your bruised knuckles. The gesture so dear and loving that your eyes instantly fill with tears.

"You have no idea of how wonderful it feels to hear you say that, Catra."

Your heart leaps in your throat and your face grows warmer. Up until the very tips of your furry ears.

"Those parts... they are *all* worth embracing." She says with a feeling of closure. She wouldn't have said it if she didn't mean it.

Still, her words cause this sudden lump of tangled up emotions to get stuck in your throat, and the telltale prickling of fresh tears in your eyes upon seeing the pride and amazement shining within hers.

"It doesn't scare you then?" You ask her when you feel confident that your voice won't shake under the weight of all those feelings bubbling up inside you and threatening to spill out.

Because you may have finally embraced this new frightening part of your nature, but... how is it *possible* that she is looking at you like that right now?

It's one thing to accept yourself, but to be accepted in return? In spite of everything?

Something within you trashes rebelliously at the thought. A long ago instilled sense of unworthiness simply making you *refute* such concept.

"How aren't you scared of me?" Despite your intention to keep such question to yourself, to let it rot and fester within you, it still tumbles past your lips. "How aren't you afraid of what I have become? Of what you have been told I'm capable of now?"

The compassionate, tender, pained smile that she gives you is what makes the first tear fall as you blink.

"Because it's still *you,* Catra." She is so serene as she says that, and that's what makes this all the more unbearable. "It's always been you. I *know* you. And I *love* you. Every single part of you."

Even if part of you can turn into a bloodthirsty *fiend?* Even if you are the vessel of Violence itself?

That... that can't be right. *Right?*

You want to believe her. A part of you does, but how can you fully accept her truth when all your life you have been told, at ever chance, every turn, over and over again, that you were worth *nothing*, that you were and would never be anything more than a *failure*, a wandering waif, a flea-infested stray, a freak, the very same *beast* you turned out to be-

"Catra?"

It takes hearing the note of alarm in your lover's voice to realize that something is wrong. And then it takes glancing up to see the worry etched on her lovely features, it takes feeling her hand cupping the side of your face and the pad of her thumb stroking the damp fur of your cheekbone to realize that you are actually *crying*.

But even then you still try to conceal the shakiness of raw emotion seizing your raspy voice with a husky laugh that, unfortunately, comes out sounding more like a broken sob when you speak.

"You... you can't really mean that." You tell her, vigorously shaking your head in denial.

And just like that, the look of concern on her face turns impossibly soft again, brimming with painful understanding.

"But I do."

You shake your head again. No longer worried of the tears now flowing freely down your face.

"You only say that because you didn't actually *see* me. You didn't see what I did, Adora. How I-"

"I have, actually." She interrupts. The revelation has your your heart screech to a halt within your chest, slamming against the back of your sternum, and you almost give yourself whiplash for how fast you lift your head, your eyes huge as you look at her, incredulous, your mouth falling open in shock.

"You... you *saw?*"

She nods slowly. Her own eyes focused on something far away, something you can't see. Her brow scrunched in concentration as if trying to fit together the pieces of a scrambled memory.

"At first I thought it was just a dream." She says. "I guess I was simply drifting in and out of consciousness. But then, when Bow came checking up on me earlier and told me what went on inside that Spire, it jogged my memory. And now... Now I'm starting to remember it. Parts of it at least."

The same can't be said about you, and it's with a bit of reluctance (and a good measure of apprehension) that you ultimatedly decide to ask her what she remembers seeing.

"I remember you climbing... no- *jumping*, onto one of those machine's back and... tearing it apart with just your hands as if it was nothing."

You don't even allow yourself to breathe as you wait for her searching for the next piece of the puzzle.

"You were... you were so fierce and fearless, Catra." Her proud smile is so earnest, and her eyes are shining so *beautifully*. "You were incredible."

When you finally do allow yourself to breathe it actually hurts as it catches in your throat.

This part of you, this... savage, wild thing that she has glimpsed at, it would be enough to make anyone else run as far away as possible. And yet here she is. Looking into your eyes, holding your hand in hers with such tenderness, providing comfort and reassurance.

"I saw you, Catra. I *see you*. Every part of you."

You shake your head, your eyes fluttering closed, more tears spilling. But they are not bitter with sorrow.

"And I accept you- *all* of you, for who you truly are."

Acceptance.

The sweetness of purest joy.

At last.

You have to take in a deep shaky breath in order to reign in your wildly fluttering emotions, but when you answer, it is with nothing else but your whole honesty. Because Adora accepting you so completely is the final piece slotting into place.

Nothing would have hurt most than finally accepting yourself only to be refused by your own heart. And while a part of you feels a bit ashamed for doubting Adora and question the depths of her affection for you, the other part is feeling far too elated, far too blessed to do anything else but finally embracing this reality with *everything* that you *are*.

"So do I." You answer, and then, before you can overthink it, you lean in to kiss her. And if it were the last thing you ever did, you would die happy and accomplished.

But it isn't.

Adora's little gasp of surprise turns intantly into a soft humming sound, her body melting against yours, her arms coming up to circle your shoulders and hold you close as she kisses you back, passionately, but holding back for your sake, seemingly more than happy to let you escalate things at your own pace. Yet, despite her intentions and consideration, your bodies still shift of their own volition until she is lying on her back and you are resting half on top of her.

You taste the truth of her previous words on her lips. Feel the certainty of them in the way she holds you and urges you closer.

It rattles you down to your bones, this all-encompassing acceptance. It seeps deep into your marrow, adding to your confidence and reinforcing it with the strength of her boundless affection.

It isn't long before your need for each other grows beyond the innocent exchange of kisses, before your hands start wandering over your clothes as in a way to ensure that you are both all right and whole after going through such an ordeal, but also as a way to cement- no... to *celebrate* this newfound balance, this reality.

When she lifts the bedsheets and parts her legs in invitation, you fit yourself between them without a hint of hesitation.

Just acceptance and the familiar warmth of desire stirring deep in your belly and straining against the front of your tactical trousers.

"I love you, too Adora." You tell her when you part for air, gazing into the warm, loving, oceanic blue of her eyes. "All parts of you."

So much.

She is so easy to love.

If there is one thing that you know being true and absolute in this life, if there is one thing that knows no limit just like the Universe you are silently crossing on your way back home, is your love for her.

"Show me." Adora says, her lips brushing against yours so very softly, her hand stroking your mane just as lovingly. "Make love to me, Catra?"

And when she asks it like that, so vulnerable and wanting and *hopeful* for the chance to show you how *much* she trusts you, you can't deny her.

Nor yourself.

Not anymore.

There is no longer a single reason that holds you back.

You are loved.

You are accepted.

You always have, you realize - not without feeling a mild twinge of guilt and shame - upon remembering her previous words.

But now... now you have also finally accepted all parts of yourself, too.

When you answer her, there are no words needed. Nothing that can convey the absoluteness that you feel in every single molecule of your being.

Only an affermative kiss carrying the most peaceful kind of definitiveness.

Chapter End Notes

Now, I know how this must look like, but before you start flipping tables and throwing chairs you should know that this time I'm not deliberately trying to be a tease.

I simply felt like there was so much going on already within the chapter (the action, switched POVs, Catra's hidden nature finally coming out, her coming to terms with it, accepting it, Adora comforting her, accepting her in turn...) that I thought it was emotional enough. Attaching the lovemaking scene right at the end of it felt a bit too intense, too crowded with feelings, so I decided to split the chapter in two separate parts.

And honestly, after all the drama and emotional roller-coaster I've been putting these two through in this story, I feel like I owe it to them to dedicate a proper chapter exclusively to their first time together.

...which I may or may not have almost finished writing already.

Alright, now you can rearrange the furniture.

Mutual Affinities of Organic Beings

Chapter Notes

Cavities alert!

If smut is what you expect in this chapter, then you'll be sorely disappointed, folks.

Because this is the tooth-rotting, fluffy, (explicit) lovemaking scene between two idiots in love.

So, before you start reading, you better go fix a dentist appointment.

That being said...

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There is no nervousness.

No awkwardness.

No jitters of any kind to interfere.

Not even a trace of the apprehension you thought there would be when you pictured this moment. (And let's admit it, you have pictured it quite a lot).

There is only you and her and your love for each other. Burning brighter than it ever has and looking for an outlet for you to express it to its fullest. For you to reaffirm that everything is all right, that you are both safe, that you *succeeded* in keeping her safe.

Despite the fact that Adora hasn't suffered any physical kind of injury, you are still painstakingly careful as you bunch up the soft nightshirt that Entrapta must have helped her change into after her examination, and lift it over her head before moving to help her out of her shorts, too, to reveal the expanse of flawless, creamy skin stretched over toned muscle and contrasting so beautifully with the mouth-watering, delicate, feminine curves hiding underneath those layers of fabric.

Your heart leaps in your throat and your mouth goes instantly dry, all your body fluids rushing south, your pants tenting even more visibly (and quite uncomfortably) at the sight of her, naked, and so, so gorgeous all over.

Her soft, round breasts fitting so perfectly in your palms.

Her perfect, rosy nipples standing at attention.

Her taunt stomach rippling with each breath she takes.

The canvas of her mouth-watering alabaster skin begging you to be explored with your lips- which you promptly lick and then swallow. Hard.

"You are staring..." The sound of her voice shakes you out of your reverie, and from her tone you can tell that she was trying for a teasing reprimand, but despite her efforts she's only managed to come across as flustered as you discover she looks when you reluctantly tear your eyes away from that patch of golden curls between her legs to glance up at her.

"Can't help it." You admit, swallowing some more in an attempt to smooth the raspiness in your voice. "You are so beautiful, Adora."

She blushes, and it's just the most endearing, most precious sight of it all.

"So are you." She says, earnestly, reaching up with one hand to trace the contours of your face with her fingertips in the most tender caress, and you are at such a loss about what to say in turn that the only thing you can do to convey all the things you can't put into words, is kiss her. A gesture that speaks louder that any word ever could. And which is eagerly returned. Passionately yet tenderly, showing the very same consideration that you have (unnecessarily) shown her, for your minor injuries when she takes off your tactical shirt, temporarily abandoning your lips in favor of leaving a trail of infinitely loving kisses that goes from your sore shoulder, to your bruised collarbone, up your neck, your jaw, your chin, until she reaches your lips again. Her hands stroking the soft fur of your back as soon as she discards the garment, traveling further and further down until she reaches the waistband of your pants.

You inhale shakily in anticipation as deft fingers unbuckle your belt, pulling it from all of its loops, popping open the button at the top...

By the time she is lowering the zipper you are shaking all over.

Adora notices and pauses, looking up at you with her brow furrowed.

"Are you nervous?" She asks, so very quietly. Her voice so soft.

But you readily shake your head at her concern, offering her a reassuring smile.

"Just... excited." You confess and if there happens to be a blush hiding underneath the thin layer of fur of your cheeks, well... not even Adora can tell.

She simply smiles back at you and tilts her head up to brush affectionately the tip of her nose against yours. "It's okay." She assures. Pressing the most tender kiss on your upper lip before drawing back to look you in the eyes. "I am, too."

She doesn't give you the chance to properly respond to her own admission, her hands already grabbing at the waistband of your pants again, and with just one final, confident tug, your knot bounces out, bobbing heavily under its own weight but finally *free* from the constricting,

scratchy fabric, leaving you shivering at the sudden contrast of cool air hitting your overheated flesh.

Luckily, such discomfort only lasts for a moment before Adora's hand wraps firmly around it, giving it a slow, loving pump that goes from base to tip, and then... then you are left wordless and shivering and *gasping* for a whole other reason.

"Oh, Catra..." She moans while you *whimper,* helplessly, in a way that your former-self would have no doubt thought quite pathetic. (But that *brat* had never experienced this, and she had no *idea* of how intense a simple touch such as this feels now). "You are so hard already."

Fuck.

You *are.*

Almost painfully so.

"It's... all for you." You tell her earnestly. And the breathlessness for getting those few words out is totally *worth it*, to see Adora's blush deepening, her blue eyes darkening...

What makes you even harder though, is knowing that you aren't the only one whose excitement is showing.

Well... maybe not *showing*, exactly, but you can most definitely *smell* her arousal in the air. Even with the distinctive, pungent scent of disinfectant that the med-bay is constantly saturated with, your sensitive nose can easily pick up those unmistakable notes of sweetness that are purely *her*.

Heavens... it's so heady and thick and syrupy that you can almost *taste her* on your tongue. And when Adora releases your knot in order to grab your hips and pull you, gently, to urge you to close the distance between your bodies, you can actually *feel* against the ridged underside of your length how *wet* she is.

Fuck...

Taking up the invitation (and willing to do *anything* to keep feeling the compelling, intimate warmth of her pressed against you like this) you align your hips to better fit in the cradle created by her spread knees, and then simply *slide* your length through her soft, slick folds, nudging her clit with the swollen tip of your knot.

"*A-ah*! Catra..."

The feeling elicits the most exquisite, shaky, throaty moan of pleasure paired with an equally delightful full-body shiver from her.

But she isn't the only one who gets affected so deeply.

The sensation of her velvety warm slickness against your hardness rips a deep, guttural groan from your own chest and makes your knot throb heavy where it remains pinned in place between your bodies.

You don't have to look down to know that the tip is already leaking, copiously so, adding to Adora's own wetness. You simply start moving, following your instincts and rutting slowly against her.

"Is this... is this okay?" Despite your newfound confidence though, your need for reassurance, apparently, is still the one that prevails.

But much to your delight it barely takes a couple of strokes before you have the confirmation that Adora is feeling just as strongly about this as you are.

"Heavens, *y-yes*." She breathes shakily. "Catra... you feel... so good."

And you can only to agree.

But it's also so much more than simply feeling *good*.

Because being pressed so intimately close to her feels like the most natural thing in the world. And what allows you to enjoy it to the fullest, is that there is none of the anxiety- of the paralyzing *panic* that you know would have seized you *before*.... Before.

No. If anything, the more you move, the stronger the *urge* to keep grinding becomes. And so you keep going. Tilting your hips forward and rolling them against hers in search for friction amidst all the delightful slickness of your combined arousal.

It's so sticky and slippery and magnificently *messy*, and you are just *so* excited, almost like you remember reading it happens when a teen cub has to deal with coming of age (embarassingly enough) that you have to take a few moment to get a hold of yourself and figure out the logistic of this new, marvelous act. But with Adora aiding you by holding onto your hips to help you keep your aim, together you establish an enjoyable, albeit slow rhythm.

But that's more than okay.

You have every intention to savor every single instant of this. To the fullest.

Within a minute, you have already grown more confident of your own movements.

Unfamiliar as they are, unaccustomed as your body is to move in such manner, you also seem to know exactly how to pace yourself, how much pressure to apply, how far back to pull without risking nudging her at a wrong angle at your next stroke.

Perhaps it's blind instinct.

Perhaps it's how attuned you are to your own body in this moment.

Perhaps it's simply listening to it and especially to Adora's, who lets go of your hip as soon as she realizes that you got the hang of things, and hooks one hand onto the back of your neck to pull you down into a deep kiss, moaning in your mouth with each upward stroke- she sure seems to enjoy the extra friction provided by the ridges circling the first half of the underside of your knot. (And so do you).

Those sounds she makes, and the passionate way she kisses you, spur you on even more than your own simmering desire does. Her every reaction making you a bit bolder, fuelling your resolve. Enough for you to decide to press yourself against her a little harder.

Gently, you still have to remind yourself though. Because, *she is yours, but you have to be gentle. Cherish her.*

In spite of your mindfulness and what are your best intentions though, she grows so impossibly slick because of this act, that at some point you slip, as it was inevitably going to happen.

Your tip brushes against her opening without you meaning to, and Adora gasps in your mouth, clutching at your shoulders and shivering all over. But not out of worry, fear or even a sudden spark of doubt.

Quite the opposite.

"Catra..." She breathes against your lips, holding you close, trying to tilt her hips up in an attempt to take you *inside.*

You growl.

She wants me.

The thought, the *reality* of it, is so powerful, so overwhelming that it makes you lightheaded.

But despite her nonverbal, enthusiastic consent, you don't push inside her right away, taking a moment to simply treasure the sensation, and reveling at the knowledge that by applying just a little bit more of pressure you will be joined as one.

That final thought is enough to make you whimper and throb with need.

"Please..."

Even just hearing plea is enough to make the beast inside you stir restlessly.

She is your mate. It reminds you.

It's your duty to take care of her needs. All of them.

"Fuck... A-Adora." You swear, and never before has your voice sounded so raspy and breathless. Not in your entire life. Not even when you spent two whole days without a drink of water in the Crimson Waste. But Adora hears you just fine, and when she responds it's with nothing but that very same enthusiasm of a minute ago.

"Please..." She begs again, and when you gather the willpower to open your eyes again, when your vision adjusts and you are able to properly put her into focus, you find her already looking at you. Her eyes so impossibly blue. So dark and yearning. *Wanting.*

You are already dizzy with the intoxicating knowledge that she wants you *so much*, with the scent of her desire starting to cloud all your senses and sticking to your palate, but when Adora looks at you like that... you forget how to breathe altogether.

It gives you a powerful head rush. A sense of vertigo that leaves you reeling.

You close your eyes, take a deep calming breath and swallow thickly to right yourself and dismiss your fluttering nerves. Slowly, they abate, and when you reach between your bodies, holding yourself up by balancing your weigth on top of her by leaning on your elbow, there is no more hesitation.

You are ready.

And so is she.

The only thing that gives you pause is grasping your knot in your fist and realizing how *big* and heavy and *thick* and *hard* it feels. And Adora... Adora seems so *small* underneath you. Her opening so *tiny* in comparison that a few tendrils of that same fear inevitably resurfaces, threatening to drag you down.

"I don't wanna hurt you." You say, your voice so feeble and your stomach churning at the thought of what would happen if, overcome by passion, you were to lose control. If the wild thing living inside you were to take over.

"Hey..."

But once again, your lover is quick to chase that concern away.

"You won't." She says, and when you gaze at her again, there is nothing else but that very same certainty reflected into the blue pools of her eyes. "I trust you." She says, stroking your mane reassuringly. "I'm ready."

She is.

That much you can't dispute.

She is so warm and slick and *open* for you.

You find out as much with just an exploratory touch of your fingers, dipping them gently inside her to feel how much resistance there is, feeling the rest of your concerns wash away when you find out that there is *none* whatsoever. Her body eagerly welcoming your touch and melting underneath it as it always does.

...perhaps even more than usual.

And so, without any further delay, without giving your doubts the *chance* to resurface and hinder your actions any longer, you take her.

There is only a moment, at the very beginning after you line yourself up properly and push the first inch inside, when the widest part of your tip catches a bit against her entrance. And

in that moment that same apprehension about hurting her sparks back to life, making you stiffen on top of her. Every muscle drawn taunt. Your blood running cold in your veins. But then...

"...it's all right."

The soft, melodic sound of her voice, the tender pressure of her lips brushing against yours, the solid, grounding feeling of her hand in your mane, is all it takes for you to melt and relax once more, to get your confidence back, to assure and remind yourself that you would *never* hurt her. Ever.

No part of you would.

There might be a beast living inside you, but it came out when you needed it to protect her and *keep her safe.*

"Don't stop..." Adora encourages you.

And you can't do anything else but obey. Still needing to ensure that your priority of not hurting her is properly met however, you find the stiff, hard ridge of her clit and start stroking it gently with your fingertips in close, firm circles. And that's literally all it takes for Adora to *blossom open* for you.

You don't even have to push.

Her tight opening simply gives with a little bit of pressure. And with the warm slickness of her arousal to aid your efforts, you simply *slide* inside her with the same ease you fit in each other arms whenever you embrace.

But the feeling... is not just as innocent.

The feeling catches you off guard and knocks the air out of your lungs with its intensity.

You have imagined how it would be like. All that warmth enveloping you, clinging onto you - but as it turns out, even that first gentle push sends a shiver of pleasure up your spine that is infinitely more powerful than you thought it would be.

Fuck. "A-Adora..."

If it weren't for the fact that you seem to have gone temporarily deaf, you would hear her gasping and calling out your name, too.

You can still feel her though, when she clings onto you, shuddering as another inch slips inside her.

Even with her inner walls struggling to adjust and fit your generous girth at first, they stretch and widen so willingly, so *easily* to accomodate you, to invite you further *in*, that the feeling soothes whatever lingering doubt you had and incourages you to keep going.

It's the warmest welcome you have ever received.

"M-more... please." Your hearing returns just in time for you to catch the most reassuring requests of all.

It almost startles you. Your heart flipping in your chest and expanding to contain all the relief that those two words, that that *plea* bring to you.

And there is only one way for you to show your gratefulness. And that is to meet her request by giving her another inch.

Adora gasps a silent moan and an enthusiastic rush of wetness spills out of her to aid your next thrust.

"Yes..." She whimpers, tilting her hips to show you that she is ready for more.

"It's all right." You assure her, pressing a kiss to her forehead. "I'll give it all to you, sweetheart."

It's a promise that despite your resolution, is easier uttered than kept, because it's becoming increasingly difficult to think, to not get overwhelmed by the feeling of her warm velvety walls clutching you tighter and tigther with every inch you slip further inside of her.

But you do your very best.

For her.

Even when every muscle in your body suddenly tenses up as if bracing for some sort of impact. Or maybe as in preparation for some imminent implosion. (At this point you really can't tell. You are already having a hard time remembering how to breathe as it is).

"Adora..." Still, in the minute that follows, her name clings to your lips and rolls off your tongue as if all the other words have suddenly deserted you and there is nothing left but her name and her compelling warmth hugging you, holding you in place, as if you were a part of her.

And you *are*. You realize.

"Oh, Catra..."

That moan and the way she relaxes beneath you is your cue to start moving again, to bury another inch of your shaft inside her. Then another. And another. Rutting gently against her to slowly work your way inside.

"Yes, yes, yes Catra..." And she takes you with such ease, spilling her essence around your knot to aid your efforts, that it's starting to become hard holding your resolution and simply not just *fill her* with one harsh snap of your hips like that primitive part of you whispers in the back of your mind from the prison that is your most primal, ancient depths while the other half of it conflictingly reminds you to be *gentle.* Because *she is your mate.* Not just a warm body to use for your own pleasure. And this moment is one worth of reverence.

My mate.

To care for.

To protect and to *love* above anything else.

But it's becoming hard keeping a straight train of thoughts with the way your knot, halfway inside and sliding deeper, is already pounding within the firm grip of her inner walls. So full and aching with pressure.

"So good Catra. You feel s-so good." Adora moans approvingly when you pull out only to bury another, even thicker inch at your next thrust that has her outer lips stretch exquisitely around you.

"Y-you do, too." You tell her, nosing at her neck. Inhaling her scent as a way to keep yourself anchored. "You f-feel incredible Adora."

She does.

Good merciful Heavens she *does.*

So soft and velvety and warm and *tight*.

The way her inner walls seem to wrap like a glove around the shape of your knot, actively molding around you. Only for you. Squeezing you, welcoming every single millimeter you work inside of her...

She is so *wet* that you could simply take her, bury yourself inside of her with one final thrust without risking hurting her in the least.

But you deliberately (and, honestly, quite admirably) hold back. Reveling in this magnificent feeling, because it is one worth cherishing.

Heavens.

You fit together just *perfectly.*

And you should have known.

You were made for her.

And she... she was made for you.

All this time, all these weeks spent wondering, doubting, worrying...

Adora tried to tell you. Over and over. She tried to assure you. Again and again. But you just wouldn't listen beyond your own insecurities. *Couldn't*. Because your thoughts were too tainted by worry to *allow* you to *listen*.

What an utter *idiot* you have been.

All this time you could have been joined as one and experience this... this transcendental level of intimacy.

But then again... this last one was a step you had to make on your own. A realization that you had to reach by yourself.

And it sure is making this moment all the more meaningful. All the more memorable.

"Ah, aa-*aah* Catra! *UHH*!"

You are have worked yourself almost all the way in when all of a sudden you hear Adora crying out your name again, when you feel her going rigid beneath you, fell her blunt nails digging onto your shoulders, when you see her throwing her head back, her eyes fluttering shut and-

"Uughn!" A groan tears itself from your chest as her inner walls clamp down around your knot, so tightly that you can't even move. Can't even *breathe.*

At first, overwhelmed as you already are, torn so suddenly from your reverie, you don't understand, but then the realization of what is actually *happening* hits you, along with the slick heat that gushes out of her, forcing its way around your knot and spilling out, coating the fur of your groin and staining the sheets with a rush of wet warmth.

She's coming. You realize. And initially you can only stare, wide eyes, absolutely awestruck at the sight of her caught in the thralls of pure ecstasy.

I did that. The thought gives you such a powerful head rush that you nearly collapse on top of her. But your arms hold you, faithfully, up.

She is coming for me. Because of me.

And such realization, combined with the wonderful, magnificent sensation of her inner walls fluttering and rippling wildly with contractions around the first half of your thick shaft is enough to push you over the edge you weren't even aware (focused as you have been on her and every single sign her body gave) you were already perched on.

You come.

Unexpectedly.

With a breathless choked gasp that catches in your throat and a white noise going off in your head, completely blindsided by the wave of pleasure that explodes in your belly and rushes up your spine, sizzling through every single nerve ending of your body and assaulting your senses without mercy.

It's like getting swept under a tidal wave. And you are powerless to do anything but drown in that bliss of pleasure.

Your length gives a series of heavy twitches right before a thick stream of your release erupts from your swollen, sensitive tip, coating Adora's quivering inner walls with your seed.

And at each jet of warmth that spills out of you, you can distantly hear (underneath your own labored, shaky breathing and deafening roar of your heart hammering away in your ears) Adora's moans growing louder. You can feel her squeezing you even thighter. Her arms come up to wrap around your shoulders, holding onto you with everything she has. Every bit of strength she can spare.

But it's a urge you understand perfectly. And you are glad that she is holding fast for the both of you, keeping you from floating away like your body seem about ready to do by itself, defying any logic and laws of gravity.

You linger at that apex for far longer than you have ever done, longer than are able to comprehend, and when you finally start coming down, the feeling still clings onto you, and it doesn't even really subside either.

The waves that had nearly drowned you spit you back onto the shore, but they keep lapping at all the most sensitive and responsive parts of your body. And as soon as you get back onto yours, you are shocked to realize that your hips are still moving, still chasing after that magnificent, unparagonable feeling never before experienced, still not ready for this to end yet. Because, as you also realize as soon as your mind cooperates and links itself with the rest of your nervous system, you have only just started.

(And apparently, you aren't the only one feeling that way).

"*Yes*. Please Catra..." Adora's pleading voice makes it past the subsiding ringing in your ears, encouraging you to keep going, grasping your hips in her hands and holding fast onto them as she arches and moans under you with each one of your thrust. "D-don't stop. I need... need you again. Need... *m-more*."

Despite the blinding, almost devastating intensity of your unexpected orgasm, your shaft still feels full, heavy, and (impossibly so) even harder within the unyelding grip of her cunt. But even if it weren't for your own need gnawing at your insides and *demanding* you *take*, again, what is rightfully *yours*, you would still find a way to give her anything she desires.

And the knowledge that your mate needs you to satisfy her own desire is really all it takes for you to recover, for that primeval part of you to stir within the depths of your dna and infuse you with the confidence you need in order to please her the way you know she wants you to.

"Don't hold back." You hear her say. "I... I want to feel you. *All* of you."

All parts of you. She means, but she doesn't need to specify.

You have never felt more connected to her than in this moment. And not only physically, but emotionally, too. Or else you wouldn't be able to understand her with a single glance. To read her needs as your own.

Still, in a swift move, to emphasize how much she means what she just said, she hoists her legs up and wraps them around your waist, locking her ankles on your lower back and positively *trapping you* in place, as if you would ever pull away willingly from the slick heat of her pussy now that you have *claimed* it as yours.

Mine. Your inner beast growls. And you can't deny how good and invigorating it feels even just *thinking it* knowing that it's true.

She is *yours*.

And you are *hers*.

You can only meet her enthusiasm with your own, and grant her what she wishes (and what you also need at a deep, visceral level) by starting to thrust again.

Slowly at first.

Pulling your hips back and marveling at how her inner muscles *cling* onto your shaft on the way out, hearing the way Adora whimpers at the loss. But then, in the moment you snap your hips against her and fill her again to the hilt, deep and hard and fast, she releases the most exquisite, most delightful cry of pleasure.

"YES!" She shouts, and you can only watch, completely mesmerized as she tossess her head onto the pillows, as her eyes flutter shut and roll onto the back of her head.

If you still had any doubts about her being able to take you, completely, *fully,* now they are gone for good.

"T-that's it. Don't hold back, Catra." She repeats, panting. And this time, you take her words as an order and make her pleasure your mission.

Bracing yourself on top of her you draw your hips back as much as you can, leaving only the tip inside before filling her again to the hilt. Deliberately slower this time though. Because you want her to *feel* every single inch of you.

When she chokes on another breathless moan you know that you have succeeded in your intent. But Adora - who has never been one to lie powerless and simply receive - summons enough coordination and willpower to tilt her hips up and roll them against yours to meet each one of your deep, full thrusts that allow you to reach even deeper inside of her.

The extra slickness provided by your previous release allows you to slip in and out more easily, but it's still a tight fit, even with how much her opening has loosened around your girth, but you don't let that deter you from your goal, because you know how much Adora enjoys that extra stretch, how a little sting of pain can actually enhance those simmering sparks of pleasure, how it can add fuel to the flames licking at your insides and turn them into a roaring fire.

The sounds that she makes assure you that you mustn't fear, and the way she keeps lifting her hips, as much as the current position allows her to in order to meet you halfway, is all the assurance you need, that tells you that everything you are doing is pleasing her greatly. And you can feel it, literally, with every single inch of you. With every ripple and spasm of her inner muscles clenching approvingly around you every time you bottom out.

"Oh, Catra..."

Can hear it, too. Because Adora isn't shy about voicing her pleasure. (She has never been).

"So big... *a-ah!* So *f-full*."

Pride explodes inside your chest upon hearing that last remark, upon feeling her wrapping herself even tighter around you and *clutching down* on your shaft the next time you bottom out *and* churn your hips into hers to provide further stimulation.

The feeling startles a growl from your own throat, but it also motivates you into picking up a more substantial, much faster pace. And you are absolutely *delighted* when Adora starts moaning your name on repeat like a prayer, even though *she* is your Goddess worth of reverence. Your absolute *everything*.

A minute adjustment to the angle of your thrusts has her positively *howling*. A most primal, most honest, spontaneous sound that pleases your inner self beyond words and makes you *trill* in satisfaction. But honestly, you can't possibly find it in you to feel embarrassed about it. Not with the way she responds, not with the knowledge that your efforts are pleasing her, making the dull ache that is settling on your lower back as satisfying as the pressure that is building and pounding along your sensitive shaft.

"Yes, yes. Heavens... s-so... deep. D-don't stop Catra!"

Now that you have started, now that you have finally understood that she can indeed take *everything* you have to give her (and then some), now that you can feel her loosening around you with each one of your thrusts, now that you are *learning* how she responds to a different rhythm, to a deeper penetration, to a grinding motion... you have absolutely no intention to.

Ever.

As a matter of fact, there isn't a single thing (not even a fire, or an asteroid collision causing a breech in the hull of the ship) that would make you pull away from the paradise that you have found between her legs. But it sure feels rewarding to have your efforts being validated and repaid with such an enthusiastic feedback.

Although, to be honest, even her words, for how sincere and encouraging, are nothing compared to how her body starts responding when you let the beast living inside you grab her plush thighs in your claws, when you bend her legs further and press down on her with your weight for a deeper penetration while tilting your hips at a particular angle that allows the flared head of your knot to *drag* against her front wall and *hit* that magic, swollen, exceptionally responsive *spot* you usually aim for with your fingertips each time you push back inside of her.

Adora cries out, throwing her head back and digging her nails onto your shoulders again, hard enough to make you hiss at the exquisite sting of pain that flares up at the gesture.

So you do it again.

And again.

And *again.*

Soon realizing that you no longer even need to pull out that much, and honestly? It's such a relief. Because now that you have experienced how marvelous a feeling it is being buried to the hilt inside her and have the silky warmth of her velvety walls wrapped around every single inch of you, you don't think that anything else in the entire Universe will ever compare, nor be nearly as gratifying as knowing that you are bringing her so much pleasure that she doesn't even seem to be aware of the way she is raking her nails down your back, hard enough to break the skin. Probably hard enough to make you *bleed*, too. But that exquisite pain only serves to heighten the pleasure sizzling through your nervous system, coursing through your veins, coiling deep in your belly, tightening like a spring coil ready to snap, and *pounding* with the fullness straining in your knot.

It's also what has your instincts surface, what makes you growl with need against the side of her neck. What urges you to press your hips as close to hers as possible, to give her your weigth and stop thrusting altogether in favor of just *grinding* into her.

"O-oh... yes... *YES*!" Your pubic bone rubbing directing against the stiff point of her clit has Adora babbling incoherently, her entire body twitching, her legs kicking, as if unable to contain the pleasure that she is experiencing - that *you* are *giving* her.

And that only goads you into giving her even more. But with your full length buried deep inside her, with your pelvis grinding deliberately against her clit, and your lips now laced around her nipple (and when did *that* happen?) switching between sucking it and lavishing it with your tongue and a hint of your fangs, it's truly all the stimulation you can provide at once (and all the coordination you can muster).

And perhaps it's maybe even too much.

You want this to last, but the sounds she is making? The way she squeezes you warmly whenever you slide all the way in, and the soft whimpers of protest that you can hear her choking in the back of her throat every time you *try* to pull out and that promptly persuade you *not to*?

You are torn between slowing down and making this last, turning this into your most passionate, loving encounter, make it an example for all your future lovemaking sessions and just give in to the pressure that you can feel building mostrously inside you, making your knot throb and swell inside her, growing harder and thicker than you ever thought possible.

At first you think it must be your imagination, because there is simply no way you are perceiving that part of your body correctly at the moment. Distantly, on an almost subconscious level, you consider the option that Adora must simply be squeezing you so tightly as she approaches her own climax, that the feeling completely throws off your perception.

But then...

A spark of recognition lights up somewhere in the back of your mind. So blinding in its clarity that you almost startle at the sudden realization.

All your studying, all this time, and you almost *forgot* about *it.*

You try to pull out - trying to disguise your curiosity with a thrust - only to find out that you simply *can't*.

Your heart leaps in your throat and your stomach flips on itself. Because, as suspected, the base of your length, which would actually be your knot proper, has swollen. The little pouch of skin surrounding it has inflated. Forming a *tie*.

And that is what is preventing you from pulling out. What is holding you in place.

You are *stuck.*

And it's so, so incredible being completely surrounded by all that warmth that you have no words to express it. Nothing can possibly compare with this.

...except feeling Adora come undone for the second time in the most spectacular manner.

Perhaps reaching the same realization you had was enough.

Perhaps is feeling you trying to make up for your inability to thrust by grinding more firmly against her.

Perhaps it's the way you *bite,* possessively, at her breast and suck her nipple in your mouth with a vicious, possessive force.

"Catra!"

All you know, is that she cries out your name, arches beneath you and wraps all her limbs around you as her cunt clamps down on your knot. And if that wasn't already delightful enough, the amazing ripples triggered by her orgasm, the way her inner walls, already wrapped impossibly tight around you, contract and spasm, massaging the swell of your tie as if actively trying *to draw* your release *out* of you, is all it takes for you to follow her down that precipice.

You come with a sobbed, shaky, moaned sound that vaguely resembles her name, spurting thick, heavy jets of your seed.

They come faster than you thought was possible, faster than you should be able to considereing that you have just spent yourself a few minutes ago.

And yet, if feels like a flood that doesn't seem to give any sign of stopping any time soon.

But it doesn't matter. Because Adora takes it all eagerly, her inner walls rippling greedily around you, drawing each spurt deeper inside her and still trying to milk you for more, and with the tie doing its job and joining your bodies together as one, nothing leaks out. Not a single drop goes to waste.

Yes... that primal part of you growls, gratified, encouraging you to hold yourself as deep inside of her as you can reach, until the head of your knot is brushing against the very end of

her channel. At it feels too incredible for you to do anything other than surrend to that urge that your body is demanding of you. *Inside.* The voice whispers urgently. *Need to... fill her. Give her... everything.*

And you do.

Because in this moment, lost as you are in that ocean of bliss, those words uttered by that disembodied voice in the back of your head make perfect sense. And it truly feels like you are fulfilling some sort of crucial, existential purpose.

My mate.

My womb.

My seed.

My...

My *cubs*.

At the end of that string of most primitive thoughts, the last one about breeding her sneaks up on you with such unexpectedness that it startles you.

Not out of concern or embarrassment though.

But... something else.

An unidentified feeling that envelops you from the inside.

Something soft and tender that sparks the fiercer flame of protectiveness, of *pride.*

But you currently lack the mental lucidity necessary to properly analyze such feelings and whatever they might mean.

Must... must be the hormones talking. You reason eventually, and then promptly dismiss the thought and any other implication and confusing emotion laced into it. Turning your attention back to Adora, who is looking so content, so satisfied beneath you as you both ride those last few waves, rocking gently against each other. And such sight is what causes yet another swell of pride to bloom in your chest. Because *you did that*.

Your knot gives one more weak twitch inside of her, and Adora's inner muscles promptly squeeze you, drawing one last spurt of your seed, for it to join the rest of your release now pooled in the depths of her belly.

You groan at the feeling. (And that particularly arousing mental image).

For how much you would like to give her more though, you simply have nothing left. You gave her *everything.* And it's such an oddly satisfying thought that, on its own (for reasons that are, no doubt, related to that very same ancestral part of you that thrives on urges and instincts, included the biological imperative of reproduction) is enough to make you purr.

Well, *that,* and the feeling of Adora stroking the fur on your back with one hand and giving you head scritches with the other.

You blindly nose your way up and press your lips against hers; a simple show of affection that your lover is eager to return in kind.

The warmth and softness of her lips, the tenderness of her kiss has you melt further on top of her, and slowly, as you come down from that height, as you complete your descend, you start to regain a modicum of awareness.

When you try shifting a bit to see if you are still stuck together (not that you would ever want to pull out, but realizing that it couldn't possibly be comfortable for her) you soon find out that you can't yet. Not without the risk of potentially hurting you both.

"It... ah... it looks like we are going to be stuck for a while." You tell her apologetically. And it's impossible to keep the tinge of embarassment from coloring your words, but you do feel a little guilty for getting her into... well, your current situation.

And while Adora may look endeared by such attentiveness, by your thoughtfulness, she also assures you that you have no reasons to feel guilty or even sorry.

"It's all right." She simply says. A lovely blush warming her cheeks. "I... I like it, actually."

And now, it's your turn to blush. Probably brightly enough to be visible even underneath your fur.

"Y-yeah," You admit shakily, swallowing hard to try and bring some moisture to your throat in an attempt to soften the raspiness that has taken a hold of your voice. "I do, too."

And how could you *not?*

She is so warm and soft and velvety. And the act itself is just so *intimate...*

"Then stay." Adora says, as simply as that.

Your body is already giving you no choice in the matter, but it's only when she utters those words of reassurance that you finally relax, laying gently on top of her when she urges you to by drawing you into another kiss.

And it's only then, with the warmth of her soft lips against yours that you finally allow yourself to accept the one and only truth that you were far too afraid to embrace on your own; that in the whole Universe you have always ever belonged to one place.

To one person.

To her and with her.

No one else's.

And it's something that you can't dismiss when you are pressed so close together. Literally joined as one.

Heartbeat against heartbeat.

Her warm skin against your soft fur.

Your chests heaving together, breathing in the same pattern.

"...mine" you find yourself murmuring without even realizing it, your nose brushing against the side of her neck, against your brand in a gesture that is as owning as it is protective.

A strange sense of calm suffuses your mind and body upon feeling it, still there. Eternally so.

Adora, on her part, holds you close and confirms your claim wholeheartedly.

"Yours."

Her voice so tender with affection, slightly slurred with sleepiness, but despite that, that one word is still infused by a powerful vehemence. Just like yours are when you feel the urge to add an equally important,

"As am I."

You are barely conscious anymore, being lulled to sleep by the soothing feeling of her hand stroking down your back and the scent of her hair tickling your nose, but needing her to know that *that*, is all you ever wanted.

To belong to her.

You don't know if a lifetime is ever going to be enough to atone for your sins and crimes, for making up for your cruelty and get rid of those old feelings of betrayal. For hurting her only because you were *terrified* by the idea of being rejected by her (yeah... this one is starting to feel like a loop onto which you periodically seem to get stuck into, even recently. Yet a fear that you have faced, *and* defeated, with *her* aid. Possibly, hopefully so, once and for all).

But you sure are going to try.

You are going to love her and care for her and protect her like you now know you were meant to.

...perhaps even *born* to.

It may sound awfully cheesy. Cringeworthy even, truly. But... it's become increasingly difficult lately to believe that you and her have met - two orphans from two extinct species - simply because of circumstances. As a coincidence. Out of chaos and lack of order in the Universe.

You *haven't*.

And somewhere, inside you, right where your most primal and ancient self lives, resides also the deeply rooted feeling that this- that *she*, was and is and will always be - your destiny.

That you were simply meant to be. No matter in what form or plane of existence.

Almost like...

Your eyes flutter open one last time to briefly gaze outside the window facing the peaceful, silent endlessness of dark space scattered with shimmering diamond dust, before resting your head on her chest again and succumbing to the pull of sleep with a sense of contentment and fulfillment settling warmly in your chest and her arms wrapped safely around you.

Like it has been written in the stars.

Chapter End Notes

So... how's the blood sugar? Still stable?

We are officially nearing the end now, fellows. Just one more (possibly quite smutty, particularly filthy and kinky) chapter to balance things out .....and an epilogue.

Species of different genus vary in analogous manner

Chapter Notes

I know... I'm a bit late, but here, as promised:
a healthy dose of filthy smut with a huge side of dirty talk, feelings... all topped with some long-brewed plot.

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There is nothing but the sound of her breathy gasps and moans.

Of your growling groans.

Of skin against skin producing that melodic, rhythmic, slapping noise of sweaty flesh on flesh as you fill her. Over and over again.

Hard and fast.

And yet...

Even with each one of your thrusts being aided by the copious slickness of her arousal (and your previous release still pooled inside of her) allowing you to *fuck her* with an insanely vigorous force-

"H-Harder!"

-she still asks for more.

And good Heavens...

How *marvelous* it is to witness her shedding that cloak of endearing shyness and losing whatever trace of inhibition she possesses. Knowing that your actions- that *you* are responsible for turning your usually kind, loving, considerate, sweetly shy Adora, into such a greedy, horny, thirsty sex fiend. Into this kinky little naughty thing that no one would *ever* suspect she secretly *is*.

For how delighted and accomplished you feel upon seeing her finally emerging through though, that's *not* how you taught her to address you *or* her needs in this kind of scenario.

Nor is the way she *demandingly* rocks back against you to take you deeper. Trying to fit inside her the tie that has already formed at the base of your knot- which has already caused

you to shorten your thrusts and change angle as a way to make up for the loss of those couple of inches.

Really. She should know better by now.

Hopefully, a harsh slap on her ass will serve as a reminder.

Your hand lifts up in the air and then connects, with no hesitation, no mercy, against the firm swell of her left ass cheek.

She yelps and briefly stiffens at staggering the force of the impact, more out of surprise (and consequent delight at the realization of what you just *did*) rather than pain. But the gesture, for how harsh, is definitely effective. Promptly urging her to slow down.

"There. Now that's more like it." You purr approvingly.

"Y-yes, my Lord." She whimpers, obediently coming to a full stop when you tighten some more your hold on her shapely hips. "I'm s-sorry, my Lord."

Now *that* is my girl. You think, pleased and proud, unable not to take a moment to run your hands over the creamy expanse of her toned back and just... *stare*. Awed.

Of all the positions you have enthusiastically tried so far, this one - with her bent over, face down onto the mattress, her perfectly sculpted ass up in the air, and you pounding restlessly into her from behind - seems to be her absolute favorite. And you have quickly and quite easily realized why, considering the way those ridges strategically located on the underside of the first half of your knot rub, with each stroke, against that magical *spot* against her front wall, providing further friction and stimulation (much more than your broad, flared tip could ever provide on its own) and causing her cunt to spasm in the most exquisite way around the thickness of your shaft.

And what a sight it provides like this. Your knot buried deep inside of her. Stretching her puffy, reddened, gleaming-with-wetness outer lips so *beautifully*.

A groan vibrates within your chest and your length twitches inside of her.

She feels it, moans, but doesn't dare to take advantage again. No matter how desperate she might be, wisely deciding to voice her need this time instead.

"P-please, My L-Lord..."

The breathlessness in her voice, the way she *stutters* as it breaks in a needy sob is *almost* enough to give her what you already know she craves- what you yourself *need*, but... *"not yet"* that voice in the back of your head whispers. An urge born out - despite what anyone would believe upon witnessing such a vigorous scene - of a softer, most tender feeling.

Still, denying her of everything would be cruel, and it's not like you can endure staying inside of her without moving. So, you resume thrusting.

And now that you *know* that Adora can sustain your vigorous pace, you definitely aren't gentle about it.

"YES!" She shouts, groans, spreads her knees wider and fists the sheets tightly in her hands as a way to anchor herself against the brute force of your savage thrusts.

Your nostrils flare as you inhale, your fangs baring into a satisfied, feral, predatorial grin, and your chest puffs out with the pride that comes from witnessing such sight and realizing how greatly you are pleasing her.

She gasps and shivers with anticipation when, at the apex of your next thrust, you grind your inflated tie against her tight opening, convinced that a half-hearted, last-second correction in her behavior will be enough for you to dismiss her insubordination and grant her what she wants. What she *needs*.

But no.

You have other things planned for her. And you are but a step away from obtaining them.

That doesn't mean that you can't spare a moment and keep fucking her for another full minute, every cell in your body rejoicing at the desperate sounds she is making, at the way she *clings onto you* at the apex of every thrust. It's almost enough to make you change your mind.

Almost.

But no. Your resolve stands strong, unwavering.

No matter how magnificent it would be to properly tie her and spend yourself inside of her again, to feel her inner muscles squeeze you and milk you of every last drop of your seed, the knowledge of the reaction that you could potentially trigger by keeping her on the edge is far too compelling. Too irresistible. And if that weren't enough to persuade you, you just aren't ready to tie her and for this to end.

Not yet.

Especially not like *this*.

It doesn't make it any easier though when, with every single inch of your body and soul rebelling against it, you draw your hips back and pull out from the clinging warmth of her cunt.

"N-no! No, no, no, no, please, *please*!"

Adora isn't too happy about your decision either.

"Please... *inside*." She even tries to rock her hips back against you, shamelessly, in a vain attempt to take your knot back in, to feel you stretch her again- *fill her* again. And the display is needy and desperate enough that you almost give in.

"P-please!" She begs, but while there isn't a sole thing in the Universe that you would usually deny her, you have already made up your mind about this.

"Sorry, love." Still, you feel the inexplicable need to apologize, unable to do anything else.

Because now it's too late to reconsider anyway.

You are already wrapping your hand around your knot, grasping it tightly, your fist gliding fast and hard over the full, pounding, slick shaft while you use your other hand to hold Adora down, preventing her from moving.

You have been so close that a couple of firm pumps is really all it takes.

For how much that primal part of you loathes seeing your seed being wasted in such an act, and *demands* - as it often does - that you release inside of her again instead, for how arousing and primal the image of tying her from behind is, it also sits quite uncomfortably in your mind.

You don't have the time to properly question the reason *why* though, because your knot grows impossibly hard in your grasp, every muscle in your body tensing up in anticipation, until the spring coil wound tight in your belly snaps. And then... then you can only gasp, brokenly, as your release rushes up your length and erupts in a long series of thick streams from your swollen tip.

The only effort you make is to aim it so that the warm jets of your come splash against the heated flesh of her pussy.

Distantly, under the roar of blood rushing in your ears, you can hear Adora's trembling gasp and moans.

She may not be thrilled for her pleasure being interrupted so abruptly, for being denied what she craves so viscerally, but it's undeniable the enjoyment that she still takes in feeling your hot come sliding through her folds and mingling with her own juices.

Heavens...

She wears it so, so beautifully, too.

But even Adora, no matter how docile and patient and obedient she has been, has her limits. And she's just reached hers, finally having decided that she has endured *enough*.

Presently, you are far too caught up in the clutches of your orgasm, too mesmerized by that glorious sight of the sticky trails of wetness sliding between her legs, too preoccupied with rutting into your own fist to properly tune in your other senses and realize that you have just succeeded in causing that reaction that you were hoping to trigger; that she isn't going to just lay down like this anymore and take the *scraps* you give her.

Good.

You haven't even finished emptying yourself that suddenly she lifts herself up, turns around, and in one smooth, surprisingly graceful move that catches you completely off guard, she pushes on your shoulders and topples you backward, pinning you onto the mattress.

In the blink of an eye, you find yourself lying down on your back with her straddling your waist. Your knot - still hard and twitching and pounding with fullness - grasped firmly in her hand, stroking the last weak spurts of come out of you.

Your heart skips several beats and you go weak at the knees- good thing you don't have to worry about standing at the moment.

"*That,*" she says, her voice strained, gravely, her mouth twisted in a resentufl snarl that rivals even your agriest ones, her eyes dark and *blazing* with the rightful fury that (along with the tail end of your orgasm) has your breath catch in your lungs. "-was the meanest thing you have ever done to me."

The excitement abates and your heart lurches painfully at her words.

"I'm sorry." You apologize with nothing but the purest sincerity. "I didn't... I-it w-wasn't my intention to-"

"Then what was your intention, mh?" She demands while she keeps stroking you from the top of your inflated tie, all the way up to the flared head before positioning herself right above it.

The sight has you snap your mouth shut and gulp. Harshly. To avoid drooling all over yourself.

You only tear your gaze away in order to look into those two blazing sapphires again, peering you expectantly.

Can you tell her?

Can you risk and tell her that the reason why you didn't listen to her pleas and tied her like she was basically *begging* you to, was because you wanted to experience her like this first? That you wanted to stip her completely of her inibitions and be able to look her in her the eyes and fit in her arms (and maybe even *kiss her*) when you finally did it?

You can.

There is no bullshit badass reputation you have to uphold behind the safety of the locked door of your private chambers.

But your hesitation lasts just that second too long that Adora makes her own assumption, which, coincidentally, mirrors the first part of that confession you just recited in your head.

"Tell me..." She starts.

Her voice so uncharacteristically deep.

Her eyes so dark and smoky.

With one smooth movement, without preambles, she takes you inside. And the entire Universe suddenly narrows down to the welcoming, clinging warmth that surrounds you from all sides. Your hands tighten on her hips, instinctively, holding her in place while yours arch off the mattress, trying to get even deeper.

Fuck.

"Is this what you wanted?" She asks. Your eyes fluttering back open to the sight of her leaning over you.

Heavens...

She looks so gorgeous like this. On top of you. Taking what she wants. What she proves is rightfully *hers* when she braces herself on your chest and starts riding you in earnest.

"Is this how you wanted it? How you wanted to feel *me*? Desperate enough to just *take you*?" It sounds more like an accusation than a question but-

Heavens, yes! Yes, yes, yes, yes...

That part of you that secretely *loves* seeing her in charge chants, over and over again in your head. Your own heart hammering along in enthusiastic agreement.

"Y-yes, your Highness." Your lips and tongue move of their own will, before your brain can lace the words together and test them within the safety of your own mind first, and if that weren't mortifying enough, you can feel the warmth of a scalding blush suffusing every single inch of your body.

But Adora simply smiles. A knowing, wicked glint in her eyes that tells you exactly how transparent you are being about this. As if you weren't already painfully aware.

You don't care.

"So polite. So well-behaved." She praises making a noise that is practically the equivalent of one of your purrs, and you can only whimper in reponse. Impressed (and just a tiny bit envious) of the amount of eloquence she seems to be capable of in this moment while you are quickly being reduced to a quivering, whimpering puddle of molten need.

"You are such a good Alpha." She says, scratching her blunt nails into the fur of your stomach for purchase as she picks up the pace.

At that one, a trill escapes you.

"Filling me so well. So *deep*." She emphasize that by deliberately *grinding* against your pelvic bone, feeling the way her opening is starting to stretch to accomodate your tie; a gesture that has yet another miserably shaky *whimper* spill from your lips.

If this is her taking her revenge on you for denying her earlier, she sure is enjoying it.

...but so are you. In that perverted sort of way.

"So thick and *hard*, even though you just came. All for your Mistress."

Your knot, as if having a mind of its own (something that is not so impossible to imagine, considering the way it constantly acts without your consent) promptly twitches withing the firm grip of her silky warm walls as if to express its agreement.

"*Y-yes*..." you half hiss half stutter, swallowing hard and trying to get a hold of all your fluttering organs. Of the heat that you can feel scalding you from the inside. "A-all for you." You agree, powerless to do anything else. And Adora grins. Overly pleased with herself and, no doubt, with your current... *compliant*... behavior.

It's kind of pathetic.

Truly.

The fact that all it takes for her to dethrone you from your dominant, savage, "wild Fuck Lord" role and turn you into this... this docile, domesticated, pitiful creature of *need*, is to hear her praise you and remind you of your status and designation.

It may have started as a game, initially, but now it's your balance in those that have become *your* dynamics.

And they works just *splendidly*.

So that's why you don't feel the slightly bit embarrassed or less virile for having her take charge like this. For riding you with such vigor, as if you were a mere instrument for her pleasure.

And who wouldn't want to be at the service of a living Goddess?

The thought arouses you more than it probably should, but you can't help it.

Just like you can't help your eyes from following the path that her right hand takes as it travels down her chest, fingertips tracing the rippling muscles of her taunt stomach and drawing your attention lower. Lower.

Lower...

You gulp thickly as her slim, delicate fingers reach between her legs, spreading her soft, glistening folds, offering you a view of her pussy stretched so *exquisitely* around the thickness of your knot that is to die for.

And you almost do just that.

By forgetting how to *breathe*. Promptly choking on empty air when those same fingers start circling over the stiff, swollen little bud of her clit.

The added stimulation has the most exquisite moan fall from her lips and another gush of warmth spill out from deep inside of her.

You can actually *feel it*.

And the lubrication provides her with that extra slickness necessary for her opening to blossom open and take, with one firm, purposeful, grinding motion of her supple hips, your tie.

Suddenly, in one smooth move (and the most delightfully obscene wet noise to accompany it) your bodies are joined as one.

"O-oh, Catra!"

The feeling of unity, of such an encompassing connection still shakes you deep to your core, as does the sound of Adora's lovely voice breathing out your name like *that*.

You have never felt more complete, more at peace and accepted and *safe* than whenever you are joined like this. And you do hope that Adora, too, feels the same sort of joy and safeness that expands in your chest and tingles through your entire body for sharing this incredibly intimate, transcendental kind of connection, which, on its own, is enough to push her over the edge.

But considering how long you have kept her balanced over it... well, it was definitely long-overdue.

Your own orgasm is not that far behind, but for the first few seconds you can only watch, mesmerized, as her eyes flutter shut, as her mouth falls open with a stuttered gasp, as she throws her head back (exposing thr exquisite column of her throat in the process and putting on full display your *brand*) as her entire body goes rigid for that couple of seemingly endlessly long seconds before the pleasure that has been brewing inside of her- that *you* have contributed in building for the past half an hour- finally bursts free.

She shatters to pieces under its might.

And it's *glorious*.

The visual is too much.

And the feeling of Adora's inner walls rippling and spasming with vicious contractions around your knot- the feeling of her *coming*, stretched to her limit around your tie, is more than you can bear. And there is no reason to hold back anymore.

"Adora!"

You are powerless to do anything else but come - as it often happens (unless she has decided to gag you to keep you from making any sassy, bratty remark) - with a shout of her name to the Heavens. Digging your retracted claws into the soft, plush skin of her hips, reflexively holding her in place even though your tie is already seeing to meet that demand.

Your entire length throbs and twitches heavily within the warm, welcoming grip of her pussy, spilling a flood of your release deep inside of her in thick, fast jets of come that coat her eager, quivering walls.

And she takes it all.

Greedily so.

Shamelessly milking you for more.

And the beast inside of you roars with primal satisfaction upon feeling that your tie holds you securely in place and that not a single drop of your precious seed goes to waste.

Mine. It growls. Like it always does whenever you come inside of her. And the possessiveness is so infectious that after a moment, as its entity merges fully with yours, you can't help but wonder if perhaps such feeling was your own all along.

In these instances it's difficult to discern its will from yours.

And it doesn't really matter anyway. Because you are one and the same. And Adora loves even that wild, savage part of you.

The knowledge settles warm and comforting in your heart, just like Adora does in your arms in the moment she loses her balance, caught in the wild spasms of her frenetic orgasm. You readily sit up to catch her though, reveling in the way she shakes and trembles in your embrace and voices her pleasure out loud with breathy gasps and whimpering moans as, together, you ride those last few subdued waves of your shared ecstasy.

"I got you." You murmur to her, brokenly, in between one rolling tide and the next. "I got you."

In response, she makes a humming sound of contentment and manages enough coordination to throw her strong, shaky arms around you.

You throw yours around her as well, and hold her close to your chest as you fall backward, gently, careful not to jostle too much the extremely delicate point where your bodies remain joined, still at the mercy of your pleasure, caught drifting in that seemingly endless ocean of bliss and waiting for the current to lead you back onto the shore.

. . .

"I can feel it, you know?" It's the first thing that Adora says to you after a couple of minutes, when you have both emerged from those wild, stormy waves and managed to catch your breath.

Still, with her face pressed against the crook of your neck her voice comes out slightly muffled, and with the thick fog of lust still clogging your brain you barely hear her.

"What, sweetheart?" You ask her, because rational thinking (and proper hearing) still has to properly kick into gear. But honestly, with your arms wrapped around her like this, her chest resting against yours, her heartbeat racing alongside your own... you truly don't think there is anything else you need in the entire world.

"Your come. Inside me. It's so warm."

And it's because of that state of calm and peacefulness and belonging, you believe, the reason why you are caught so off guard upon hearing her rather... explicit clarification... that you almost choke on your own breath (*again*).

Good merciful Heavens.

In your attempt to recover from yet another near-death experience (you must be at a negative three lives at this point, if you are not mistaken), you end up making a sound that falls somewhere in between a spluttered groan and a deep, chesty, raspy growl.

(The final croak of a dying toad is probably a way more charming, elegant sound to hear, no doubt).

"If you are trying to make my tie go away, you should know that you are *not* helping by saying stuff like that, 'dora."

"Who said I was trying to make it go away?"

She deliberately bears down on the aforementioned, extremely sensitive, inflated appendage, triggering a feeling so intense that it makes your eyes roll into the back of your head, effectively tearing a proper growl from your chest (along with another spurt of your come from your swollen knot). Your claws reflexively digging into the soft flesh of her thigh.

Fuck.

"S-stop that." You pant.

"Do you really want me to?"

Your eyes flutter open just in time to see the much-expected teasing smirk (miserably concealed behind a fake pout) that you just heard in her voice.

In spite of everything though, you truly can't help the breathy laugh that spills from your lips. "Of course not."

She grins, and then does it again, squeezing you warmly, but this time it's weaker, much more playful, meant to be comforting rather than arousing (even though it certainly evokes both sensations) and you are more prepared for it, already braced to sustain the exquisite tingle of pleasure that just lightly borders into overstimulation.

"Am I to understand that you are feeling better then?" You ask tentatively, because her mood has been a bit all over the place lately, but since she is acting so playful you also decide that it must be safe to phrase that question with a certain teasing inflection, even if it's only a cover

for your true emotions of concern hiding underneath, fluttering like frenzied fireflies. As they have been for the past few weeks.

Ever since you returned to Brightmoon after your half-butchered disaster of a mission in fact, Adora has been having... issues... with transforming into She-Ra. And while she doesn't seem too concerned about it and has been trying, repeatedly, to reassure you ("it's only been a few weeks, Catra. Last time I nearly lost her for a year. And she isn't gone, I can feel her magic within me. She is still in there. Trust me, I'm fine.") you are still terribly worried that something might be wrong.

After all, who in the Heavens *know* what kind of damage the weapon that triggered that neutralizing blast of green energy could have caused. Entrapta seemed to be confident that the effects would only be temporary, and... you kinda trust her (as much as a mad scientist can be trusted) although... even if she said that it didn't affect anything more than Adora's ability to trasform, you would like to disagree.

In these past couple of weeks, in fact, you may have noticed a most peculiar kind of change regarding - strangely enough - her metabolism.

More specifically, the monstrous appetite that she has developed seemingly out of nowhere.

Sure, anyone who has known Adora for as long as you have is aware that she has always been quite the famished type (and considering the kind of self-assembled atrocities she has been eating lately, it's no wonder that sometimes she gets so sick in the morning at the mention of food to puke her guts out). But... it's still something that concerns you. More than you let on.

Perhaps it's just a minor side effect though?

...or maybe (most likely) you are just being paranoid and overprotective, not having quite gone through the trauma of nearly losing her. Again.

The feeling of Adora suddenly shifting her weight to lay fully on top of you to get more comfortable (and jostling your knot inside of her in the process) has another groan rumble in your throat. Your claws flexing onto her back, holding her in place once she settles, humming her response against the thin layer of fur softening the sharp jut of your clavicle.

"Mm mh, much better..." She murmurs. But whether that's the answer for your previous question or a mere comment regarding her new position, you can't say. Still, the current circumstances sure serve as a reminder about this *other* sort of *"appetite"* that she has been experiencing:

The voracious, ravenous hunger for the pleasure of the flesh that has been going on (quite intensely) every day (several times a day, much to your enthusiasm) for the past week and a half, and that *you*, as an Alpha, a very considerate mate (and an attentive, passionate lover) have made it your priority to ensure that she were satisfied in whatever way her body needed you to.

So very magnanimous of you. Right?

Honestly though, you take such great enjoyment from pleasuring her that your own physical pleasure tends to fall behind in comparison.

Well... with a few exceptions, of course.

Your gaze promptly falls between your bodies, but while you are unable to see anything with the way your are currently smashed together, you can still definitely feel how your knot remains buried to the hilt inside of her.

A sudden rush of warmth suffuses your entire face for some reason. Saliva pools in your mouth and you have to swallow, hard.

"S-sorry. It's taking longer than usual..." You apologize, feeling quite sheepish, for some unknown reason.

"Good." She simply murmurs, unbothered, nuzzling your flushed cheek and wrapping herself even more tightly around you, pretty much like one of those Sloth cratures that you've encountered on that planet in the Sol system a few months ago.

"Because I'm not ready to let you go yet." She states, and your heart positively *quivers* with emotions at her words.

The things she says...

You wonder if she knows how deeply, how *profoundly* they affect you.

(...you wonder if you could possibly love her even more for it).

The first sunrays filter through the gap in the curtains, disrupting your thoughts with the abrupt realization that you'll have to leave in just a few hours.

The thought hits you right in the gut.

Even just the idea of staying an inch apart from her feels just... *wrong* right now.

Simply inconceivable.

You sink your fangs into your lower lip as you mull over the sudden, idiotic, completely irrational idea that is the offspring of your worried (smitten) Alpha counterpart.

"You know, maybe I can ditch this meeting and come with you to Dryl instead. Be there to make sure Entrapta doesn't accidentally send you into another dimension or something while she runs her tests on you to see what's going on with your magic."

Predictably enough, Adora laughs, although not unkindly, merely (rightfully) amused by your admittedly silly suggestion.

Your face grows very warm.

"What?" You ask, a bit defensively. Perhaps even pouting. "The one in Plumeria is a done deal anyway, and I want to be there. *For you.*"

A smile curls on her lips then. Her eyes growing soft and affectionate in that way that makes your blush almost visible under your fur. Hell, at this point you believe that you are starting to feel like a nuclear reactor about to go into meltdown.

"That's very sweet." She says. Her fingers tugging gently through the tangled mass of your wild mane. "But you have nothing to worry about, Catra. Entrapta knows what she is doing- well, most of the times." She amends. "And I'm feeling much better, really."

"But I-" Whatever argument you have ready at the tip of your tongue doesn't get the chance to be voiced out loud. Because Adora cups your cheek in her warm palm and leans in to silence you with a kiss.

It's so impossibly soft and tender and filled with love and reassurance that your tense muscles instantly uncoil. The worries lingering at the back of your mind seemingly dissipating into a thin, inconstistent mist.

"Everything is going to be all right." She says when she draws back. Still smiling in that way that just *makes you* believe her. "I promise."

You close your eyes and heave a long, silent, inward sigh.

"...all right."

When you open your eyes again, you are greeted by the sight of Adora's beautiful, grinning face.

"That's a good kitten."

You throw her a warning look and grumble something about being a grown ass, fearsome, deadly strong panther- no *lion*, with the wild, untamable mane to match, but that only seems to amuse her more.

"Of *course* you are." She cooes, and then, to make a point about how "fearsome" you are, she starts scratching at that spot behind your right ear. The one that causes your tracherous larinx to vibrate at the right frequency to emit - much to your utter mortification - a *trill*.

"Aww. That's the mighty roar of my proud, brave, *fearsome* lioness..." She says. But her voice is just m so fond and affectionate rather than teasing, that you don't even feel that burning need to inflict your revenge and safeguard your dignity like your old self would have. Instantly so. In a rather violent manner.

You simply enjoy the physical closeness, the exhilarating intimacy of being joined as one, and the scritches that Adora oh-so-generously provides until you are both drifting off in each other's arms.

"Catra?"

You are about to be swept away by the first wave of sleep when the sound of her voice drags your consciousness back up.

"Mmm?" You ask her, eyes fluttering open by a slit, your claws slipping gently through her hair (it feels impossibly, irresistibly soft these days. And it looks so glossy, almost golden, against the first bright rays of sunlight).

"Would you bring me back some strawberries from Plumeria?"

A smile twitches at the corner of your mouth.

"Of course."

"And... could you maybe also stop by that shop along the way that sells those chocolates with the crunchy hazel filling inside...?"

The smile on your lips grows lopsided, shaping itself into a fond smirk.

"All right."

"....and since you are so good at fishing, would you fish me a Royal salmon from the river?"

At that, you truly can't contain the burst of laughter thay erupts from your chest.

You don't know what kind of atrocity she is craving and planning to eat, but the ingredients seem harmless enough. Healthy, even. And you are totally powerless to do anything else but accept her every request.

Honestly, if she were to ask you for one of the twelwe moons hanging above Etheria right now, you are pretty sure that you'd find a way (with Entrapta's help, and probably a shrinking ray, too) to bring it back to her cradled in the palm of your hand.

"Whatever you want, you weirdo." You tell her, planting an affectionate kiss to her forehead and holding her even closer to your chest.

She sighs contently and melts further into your embrace.

"Thank you." She murmurs, her voice thick and heavy with sleep, her breathing growing deep and steady, her words a tiny bit slurred, but not enough for you not to hear her when - right before surrendering to the pull of sleep - she adds, "Love you... so much."

With that, she is out like a light.

Snuggled against the soft, warm fur of your chest, which you can feel expanding to the point of bursting (as it always does) at the rush of affection that fills it at her confession.

You sniffle quietly and blink repeatedly to clear your suddenly blurry vision.

....stupid fucking damned post-sex hormones have tears pooling in your eyes upon hearing her earnest words, upon feeling her sighing peacefully in her sleep and clinging so lovingly

onto you. Like... Every single *inch* of you.

The only thing you can do to return the sentiment is press another, softer, lingering kiss to her forehead. *Love you, too.* The sentiment thrumming in your veins, echoing through your very soul.

Content beyond words, you close your eyes to join her in slumber.

Just for a few precious minutes, is the lie you tell yourself.

Until your tie deflates.

And before duties and obligations will keep you away from each other for the next two days.

. . .

It feels like a very vital, fundamental part of you gets detached from your body whenever it happens.

And seriously, all things considered, it shouldn't be so traumatic having to spend a day and a half apart.

After all you have been through, it shouldn't be *anything*. Really.

And yet, lately it's become incredibly difficult for you to leave her side (and for her to leave yours, but she can deal far better than your depressed furry ass can't do on its own).

Maybe it's a mutual comfort thing after your harrowing experience on that desolated planet, in that cursed *Spire.*

Maybe it's simply because you know that she has been sick recently.

Maybe it has to do with that concern you have regarding her general well-being. Because ensuring your mate's seems to be written in your DNA in bold, glowing letters.

Maybe it's another *"bite thing"* (or a hormones-induced "Protective Alpha" thing).

...or maybe it's something that has to do with the way her *scent* almost seems to *call* to you these days. Making the aforementioned need grow that much stronger. Exponentially more powerful. Putting you always on high alert, always vigilant for possible threats while, at the same time (discordantly enough) stirring some very soft, very delicate, infinitely tender feelings within you that you can't quite comprehend.

Whatever the reason might be, the one certainty you have is that you just *despise* having to leave your mate's side.

But you sure are absolutely *thrilled* when the meeting in Plumeria ends - successfully, with all parts involved very satisfied - earlier than anticipated, allowing you to get back to Brightmoon the next afternoon, bearing gifts (and all the wicked satisfaction that comes out of having defied Glimmer's orders, and sealed a deal that she is too stubborn to see will strengthen the relations between every Kingdom).

You are less content however to discover that Adora has yet to get back from her trip to Dryl with Swift Wind.

In the hopes of making the tedious, unbearable wait more tolerable (and not get sucked into the spiral of all the possible reasons why it's *taking so damn long* for her to get back) you do what you do best.

First, you get the fish to the Palace kitchens to be properly gutted and stored away. And *then*... you sulk around.

Trying to lose yourself into some mindless task of cataloging your files for next week's meetings on Adora's neatly organized desk, turns out being as useless and *stupid* as the whole concept of *doing paperwork* is.

You give up after the second folder, because who cares what Glimmer says. You are a damned Strategist- the best. Not a fucking *scribe.*

So you dismiss it all in favor of the much more rewarding activity of grooming yourself instead.

Then you start reading a random book picked from one of Adora's shelves.

Decide that (as captivating as the beginning of the story and as relatable the characters seem to be) romance novels are *not* something that the former, dreaded Force Horde Captain and current, well-respected Startegist for the Kingdom of Brightmoon can afford to be caught reading - lest you become the blackmailed puppet of whomever you just *know* would walk in on you reading a sappy novel (because privacy appears to be a broad concept here in the Palace).

So you wisely put it down exactly where you found it and groom yourself some more (because you can never be too thorough with that hard-to-reach spot behind your shoulder).

You are about thirty seconds away from starting to chase your own tail (or risk waking up a heavily slumbering Melog, because dealing with his sourly mood for being woken up for no reason whatsoever seems like a much better alternative than falling into the temptation of eating the chocolates that Adora asked you to bring her, since you really don't feel like dying of a theobromine intoxication today), when finally the door of your chambers clicks open and the person colonizing your every thought walks in, draped in a lovely, pure white, soft-looking sundress. Long, golden hair held in place by a humbly styled tiara and cascading freely down her back.

Your heart promptly flips all over itself, as it tends to do whenever you are caught off guard like this by your lover's simple, yet stunning beauty.

Heavens...

You can't help it though.

She looks absolutely *radiant*.

Almost *glowing* from within.

You are up from the bed and on your feet, grinning from ear to ear, your tail up and quivering with excitement, before she can even turn around and acknowledge your presence.

"Adora!"

But your enthusiasm is cut short.

Because the moment you greet her, Adora startles, spins around and *stiffens* at the sight of you. Her blue eyes growing wide and panicked.

"C-catra!"

She tries to recover as quickly as possible, trying to conceal her puzzling shock by flashing you a tremulous smile. But it's too late.

Something's wrong.

All your senses tingle at once. And a dreadful feeling settles in your stomach. Sinking deep and hard with all the weight of the confirmation you get when she greets you.

"H-hey.... I... I thought you were due back from Plumeria later tonight." She says, and it definitely isn't lost on you how much the hand that she nervously runs through her hair is shaking.

Your ears flatten and your tail hangs low. A chill runs up your spine, bristling the fur at your back.

"I managed to leave early." You reply, numbly. That feeling surging up and expanding in your chest, contaminating the excitement that was there but a moment ago. Turning it sour with dead. The sharp claws of apprehension aiming at your heart. "The proposal that I presented was well accepted. Perfuma approved it on the spot." You can't even find it in you to gloat (like you normally would) about successfully going behind Glimmer's back and getting shit done without her.

Not even when Adora's face suddenly lights up at that information, genuinely, with sincere happiness and honest delight, her eyes sparkling with *pride*.

"Really? Oh, Catra, that's great!" She jogs the few steps towards you but you stop her before she can throw her arms around you.

"Adora wait, what's wrong?" You ask her, reaching out and holding her gently by her wrists, your thumbs unconsciously stroking the creamy skin there.

She is so warm.

(And has her skin always been so soft and... *luminous?*

Maybe it's the whiteness of the dress complementing her exquisite complexion...)

"What you mean?" She asks, wide eyed, taking her hands back and starting to wring her fingers. "N-nothing's wrong."

Oh, for the love of-

She is such an *awful* liar you wonder why she even *tries.*

"Something clearly is." You disagree, patiently, trying not to be yanked around by your emotions and let them rule your reason, but it's difficult with all the questions that are starting to pile on top of each other in your mind, addling your logic with all their weight. "Does it have anything to do with your check up?" You ask her, actively ignoring the riot of feelings stirring in the pit of your stomach at the thought that she might actually be *sick*- that all this time she might have been sick and you did *nothing.* "Has Entrapta scanned you? What did she say?"

When she doesn't answer right away, when takes a step back and folds her hands over her stomach, when she tilts her head down and refuses to meet your gaze, the most dreaded possibilities get a hold of that last splinter of reason you had left and, inevitably enough, you succumb to panic.

"Adora, if your connection with She-Ra is still unstable I'm sure we can find a way to get her back." You tell her, already fearing the worst. And how could you *not*, upon seeing how withdrawn she is acting? "We can go back to the Crystal Palace," you tell her, stepping forward and reaching out for her again. "We can find a way to get Light Hope back online. We can try to-"

"I don't care if I ever transform again."

The shock that slaps you across the face at that statement and leaves you reeling with the same staggering force of a blow to the head, is only outmatched by the one that you feel when you properly look at her and see the huge, blinding, ecstatic *smile* on her face.

The tears shimmering in her sparkling blue eyes.

...the protective, affectionate way she is palming her belly with both her hands.

Your eyes widen.

Your balance wavers, forcing you to take a stumbled step back and lean against one the floor-to-ceiling pillars standing conveniently right behind you in order not to fall down.

You assess her up and down and-

No.

Your breath gets caught in your throat.

And your heart screeches to a sharp halt.

It...

It *can't* be.

"A-Adora?" When you speak, your voice comes out sounding thicker and raspier and more vulnerable than you ever heard it as you utter her name and take a small, careful, hesitant step forward.

But she doesn't look up.

Her gaze, her smiling eyes, remain cast downwards. Fixed on a spot on her flat stomach when she speaks again.

"Do... ah... do you remember those scrolls that Lance and George gave us about Khajiit physiology? The ones written in First One language?"

You are still stunned, still wobblying in place, stuck in between shock and the sudden confusion about where she might be going with this out-of-the-blue subject, but even in your dumbstruck state, you still manage to nod, remembering the mentioned scrolls. Your eyes flitting briefly towards the bookshelf, noticing the empty spots that said scrolls have been occupying this past serveral weeks. Then, you look back at her.

You seize her up and down, wide eyed. Taking in every inch of her and trying to see something that *can't* be seen. No matter how enhanced your superior vision might be.

"Entrapta has developed a new translator using Darla's database and doing some cross-references with the data we recovered from that Spire in Linossa." She explains twisting her hands nervously. Biting her lower lip.

You swallow, hard, all your organs wrung tight on themselves as you brace yourself before you dare to ask her, "What... did she find?"

Her teeth sink harder onto her bottom lip and she avoids your gaze by tilting her head down again, yet not quite succeeding to hide the warmth that you can see coloring her cheeks.

"While the First Ones were trying to find out if your kind possessed any magical ability, they stumbled upon another rather astonishing discovery about... compatibility. Between... our species."

You blink, confused, not quite understanding - at a cognitive level - what she is actually saying, and yet...

The insane, overwhelming, surreal *hope* that blooms inside of you says differently. A feeling so strong and unexpected and overpowering that it barely allows you to breathe, to think, to *be*.

Because you *do* know what she is saying.

You just can't allow yourself to fully *believe*.

"Are you telling me that..." Your voice trails off. Your throat swelling and growing too tight for you to continue as your eyes flit briefly, once again, to her belly. To the way her hands are now splayed protectively over it, to the way her thumbs are stroking it, so very softly, through the thin layer of fabric of her dress.

But you don't even need to finish your question.

Because when you glance up at her again, you find Adora looking right back at you, and there you see it again.

That blindingly brilliant smile taking over her face, crinkling her eyes at the corners, positively lighting her up from the inside.

A tremulous nod.

A sobbed, ecstatic laugh spilling from her lips and filling you with the purest, most absolute *joy*.

A single tear escapes as she blinks, tumbling down her cheek, tracing a shimmering trail of uncontainable happiness.

And then, at last, an answer.

The very same one you wouldn't- couldn't allow yourself to hope for.

"I'm pregnant, Catra."

Chapter End Notes

And then, the grown-ass, fearsome, majestic feline... fainted.

All right, one more left to go peeps.

...Although I have to admit that I'm just sooooo tempted to deep dive into some Protective Catra/Pregnant Adora scenarios. Like... Catra was already throwing herself at aliens in deserted, sketchy planets and into a freaking *fire* without a second thought to protect Adora before they were even together. Can you imagine her being overprotective of their unborn cub(s)? 'Cause I can't stop.

My rational self: Nope, no more chapters Jay, you promised. This story has already grown its own legs and took off for 80k. You got research and studying to do for your novel, dude.

Me: ...maybe just a separate one-shot then?

Sigh

The relation of organism to organism: the most important of all relations

Chapter Notes

All right folks, here we are, at long last.

The final chapter.

Before I leave you to it though, I would like to say that I have had such a blast writing this story. Truly.

I mean, this whole thing started out because (as someone might have noticed from the peculiar way the chapters are titled) I've been doing some deep diving into Darwinism and evolution, using them as a research base for my other work projects.

I wasn't expecting for the story to actually grow and take off the way it did. Originally, I had planned for a handful of chapters at most but then, well...

For how lovely and kind and generally great Adora is, I just find Catra an infinitely more fascinating and far more complex character who deserves to be the main protagonist in her own show. (But then again, I've *always* found fascinating - and rooted for - every single villain and anti-hero that's ever existed and who eventually turned out to possess a heart of gold, so...)

I definitely had fun putting her into these particular circumstances, in giving her the proud origins she deserved, and seeing her grow, understand and eventually accept herself. And I thank all those of you kind readers who have supported me in this endeavor :) Thank you.

Now... with all of that being said (and a final warning about a *possible*, non-graphic birth scene and the not quite promise about that *possible* future series of one-shots I mentioned in the last chapter) I leave you to this epilogue.

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

With what you promise is going to be the last, final adjustment to the collar of your ruffled shirt, another general glance at the way the dark grey tuxedo cuts your figure (and resigning yourself to the way that stubborn, unruly strand of your now short hair keeps falling forward and tickling your cheekbone no matter how many times, or what kind of product you use, or whichever way you try to get it to stick back with the rest), you nod at your reflection,

straighten the lapel of your jacket, as well as the medal pinned there, and step away from the full length mirror with a satisfied smile.

"Well, hi there, *Ser Knight Catra*."

It says a lot about how focused you have been in trying to look somewhat decent for this event the fact that you didn't even hear the door creek open. But the sound of that greeting, paired with the uniquely playful yet proud note weaved in your title and uttered by that melodiously sweet voice, has you spin around in a stuttered heartbeat...

...only for your breath to catch in your throat at the sight you are met with.

"Wow."

The single word falls from your lips like a breathy sigh.

And then you can only stare, breathless, wide eyed, in awe, at the sight of your lover wearing a ball gown.

"Adora..." to you, she has always looked so gorgeous no matter what, especially so when draped in white and gold. But this time... This time she seems almost ethereal.

A being made of pure light.

And for how beautiful the dress is, for how sophisticated and tasteful the decorations adorning it are, you know that the piece of fabric would never exude such splendor if it weren't for the woman currently wearing it.

Still... it looks magnificent on her.

A real work of art.

Your mouth opens and closes mutedly, like a gasping fish. But even if words fail you at the moment, preventing you from properly expressing how beautiful and elegant and *regal* she looks, it seems that your stunned speachlessness, for how paradoxical, says all it needs to be said.

Adora blushes under your appreciative gaze, tilting her head down and fixing a strand of golden hair behind her ear with a delicately white gloved hand, in a gesture so shy and innocent and *precious* that has your heart swell with a surge of affection.

"Thanks." She says, the most lovely shade of pink warming her cheeks, complementing her flawless, creamy complexion so prettily.

"And you..." She adds, stepping forward, within your space, and immediately reaching for that stubborn lock of your now short mane that wouldn't see reason up until thirty seconds ago, effortlessly tucking it back and fixing it into its rightful place with a fond smile, her velvet gloved hand lingering in a caress on your furry cheek. "You look very handsome."

And now it's your turn to blush into a radioactive hue of red. Your larynx betraying you once more and vibrating to emit a sound that falls somewhere between a purr and a trill; a most humiliating sound of unmistakable contentment that is also reflected more visibly in the way your tail goes straight up, displaying how pleased and confident you feel at the use of that particular adjective.

It feels... startlingly fitting. For all parts of you.

Adora's smile widens at your embarrassingly telling reaction, and your heart stumbles over itself, trying to catch up with all the beats it has left behind ever since you saw her.

You just can't stop looking at her.

Feeling soft and warm all around and inside. Especially when your gaze lands on the firm swell of her belly (now visible even under layers upon layers of taffeta and chiffon) shotly followed by your hand.

Your throat tightens with emotions, and you can only imagine the sappy look in your eyes.

But you have long given up in the pretense that you would care to be caught like this.

Sometimes you are still struck with the urge to just... pinch yourself to see if all of this is just a dream.

Dear Heavens above...

You can't believe that it's all *real.*

That she is yours.

That you are hers.

...that she is carrying *your child*.

Maybe you finally did it.

Maybe you have replaced all your bad deeds with enough good ones.

And would it be so wrong for you to hope that the Universe has finally seen how regretful you have been, how hard you have worked to be better, and is now deeming you worthy of a peaceful life? Of a happy ending?

Even if it doesn't though... it wouldn't matter.

Because you'd still remain devoted to Adora. Eternally so.

"Catra? Are you okay, love?"

The sound of her voice shakes you gently from your musing, slowly dislodging you from your thoughts. You blink and look up at her, gazing into those stunning blue eyes that you

have loved for as long as you can remember.

You won't go through one day without showing her how much you love her.

And you'll always make her well-being and comfort your number one priority.

"Everything is fine." You answer, smiling reassuringly at her. "What about you though? Are you *sure* you are up for this?" You ask her, not for the first time today. "Because if you have changed your mind - either of you -" You stress, gently stroking the firm swell of her belly. "Just say the word." You assure her with a smile that is readily returned with a sheepishly gnawed lip as she contemplates your (clearly tempting) offer.

"We can just stay in," you tell her, channeling every ounce of your charm to try and sell your alternative to what would be Scorpia's first Ball, thrown to celebrate her now fully reclaimed Scorpion Kingdom and its addition into the Alliance.

"I could raid the kitchens for some ice cream, you could read while I rub your feet. Hell- I'll even take a bath with you if that's what you want."

"Oh, really?" She inquires, the corners of those blue eyes crinkled so beautifully, the light into them twinkling with amusement, the right amount of skepticism showing in the arch of one brow, but most of all... you just see the warm, pure flame of affection flickering within their depths.

"Whatever Her Highness desires." You say, taking a step back to offer her a bow. A proper, deep one (right hand to chest, left leg forward, left arm extended, chin to chest) that shows real deference, not the mockery you constantly infuriate the ruling Queen of Brightmoon with on a daily basis.

When you raise up, you even put one arm behind your back and reach out to take her proffered hand to plant a feather-light kiss to her gloved knuckles, never averting your gaze.

Her face splits into a grin.

"Look at you with the etiquette." She teases, her arched eyebrow quirking further, impressed, her lips twitching, flashing you an equally playful smirk. "Trying to get lucky?"

You look at her, right into those deep pools of endless blue and shake your head. When you answer her, there is nothing but the outmost sincerity in your voice, paired with the earnest, soft smile gracing your lips.

"I already am the luckiest."

Her eyes grow impossibly soft then. And so very shiny. Her whole expression melting into a look of absolute tenderness.

"Oh, Catra..." She reaches out with one hand, stroking the thin, soft layer of fur on your cheek with her thumb. Your eyes flutter instantly closed at the contact. Your entire body leaning into her loving touch. Your heart leaping at the sound of her warm, smooth voice as she speaks. "You have been so thoughtful and sweet and *kind* these past few-"

But whatever she was going to say next gets abruptly interrupted by a sudden, urgent, sharp intake of air.

Your eyes snap back open just as a whimper of pain follows suit.

"Adora?" You are already at her side, holding her while she clutches your forearm and doubles over, holding the underside of her round belly with her other hand and gasping. Her lovely features twisted in pain.

"Adora what's wrong?" You can't quite prevent the fear that surges through you from affecting your voice, making it shake despite your best efforts *not* to give into it.

"I-I don't-"

And that's when it happens.

When she feels it.

When you both hear it.

The unmistakable yet puzzling noise of dripping water.

At first you think you might have knocked over the flower vase on the table. But then...

You glance downwards. Startled. Blinking confusedly at the wetness pooling right at your feet.

And then realization hits, you square in the chest. Knocking the air from your lungs and forcing your heart into a full stop.

Oh no.

Shit.

Your head snaps up, meeting Adora's own incredulous gaze.

You exchange a wide eyed look that is, probably because of shock, not nearly as panicked as it ought to be.

"On second thought, honey..." Adora says, face draining of all color. "I believe someone might prefer if we were to stay in tonight."

. . .

There was a time, not so long ago (despite the fact that it now feels like a lifetime has passed since then) when hurting Adora was all you dreamed about.

When reaching that goal was all you wanted in the world under the pretense of simply achieving power, glory, and reign over the crushed bones of all of those who ever dared to stand up against you or had disrespected you in some way.

It was the sweet thought that gave you comfort.

The exquisite fantasy which flames kept you warm at night and fuelled your resolve in the moments it wavered.

Nothing had ever made you feel more powerful or had ever filled you with more purpose than the thought of seeing her broken and anguished, desperate, forced to her knees in defeat and bent over in pain, suffering, having lost everything and everyone she loved.

There was absolutely nothing else that would have brought you more joy than such sight.

But that was a long time ago.

And that sick, damaged, horribly traumatized version of you that desired such outcome was only a splinter of the full, healed, well-adjusted, wholly loved and thoroughly accepted person that you are today. That you have worked so hard to become.

And now-

"*AAHHH!!*"

Another scream of pain pierces your ears, throbbing deafeningly within your skull and echoing all around the Palace's infirmary wing.

Now the thought of seeing her hurting, of seeing her beautiful face twisted in agonizing pain, hearing her screams and seeing her crying, knowing that you are partially responsible for such pain...

"You are doing great, Adora." One of the nurses says, smiling encouragingly, and you can only agree.

"You are almost there." She adds even as Adora slumps back onto the hospital bed, panting, exhausted, after the latest contraction, and it hasn't gone past you how fast they are coming now.

"C-catra?"

Your heart leaps in your throat at the sound of her tired, strained voice calling for you, at the sight of her shaky hand reaching out over the railing of the hospital bed.

You don't waste a second to take it into your own.

"I'm here." You assure her, squeezing tightly her hand until her head lolls to the side and she sees you. "I'm right here, sweetheart."

Of all the thing you were prepared for her to do when this moment finally arrived (things that included her screaming every kind of atrocity at you, cursing your name to Hell and back, threatening to relieve you - in a most violent manner and possibly with the aid of a blunt, rusty tool - of the appendage that got her into this situation in the first place) seeing her smiling at you through her teary eyes, seeing the plain relief and gratefulness for having you here with her shining in them in the instant your gazes meet, was *not* among the list of most-expected things.

Even the pain seems to get temporarily subdued in that moment.

(If you could possibly fall any deeper in love with her, you already would have done so. But you have recently come to the realization that your entire life with Adora is going to feel like an endlessly long free fall).

"You are doing so amazing, Adora." You tell her, leaning in close and kissing her knuckles, barely holding back your own tears. "So amazing."

She is so beautiful, too.

Even like this, all sweaty and disheveled. With wisps of golden hair sticking out at odd angles from the practical ponytail it has been arranged into. Tears tracking down her face, her cheeks reddened and puffed out with the effort of bringing forth new life.

So beautiful.

Your best friend.

Your partner.

Your one true love.

Your warrior Princess.

So brave and strong and fierce.

Always.

Your invincible Goddess.

You love her *so* much.

You tell her all of this, all of this and *more*, trying to keep her centered, grounded, *strong* while you dab away the pain gleaming on her forehead using a soft cloth with your free hand. The other one still caught in a shattering grip within Adora's own. But you don't care. The twinge of pain that you feel there is no doubt infinitesimal compared to what your lover is currently suffering.

"Catra... Catra I-I can't... I'm so sorry." She cries after two more, particularly vicious contractions that leave her winded.

You shake your head and smooth back the sweat-slick clump of hair from where they are sticking at her temple.

"Yes you can, Adora." You insist. "You can do this. I know you can." Not only because that's simply *not* an option - like, physically speaking - but because she *can't* give up.

She never has. Not once. Not even when you had given up on yourself.

She shakes her head and sobs, "Maybe if... I-if I were She-Ra-"

"No." The vehemence in your tone is so abrupt and strong that it surprises even you, and has her sobering up from yet another bout of wretching pain.

"You don't need her." You tell her, certain and confident. "You have always been strong, Adora. Long before you picked up that sword. Long before you ever transformed. Long before you knew you could wield magic." You pause waiting for her to catch her breath before continuing.

"You can do this, Adora. I know you can. And I know you wanna meet our child, don't you?"

Another sob, fresh tears spilling from her eyes but this time they are followed by a frantic nod of her head. "More than anything!"

"Then please, please," you beg her, clasping her hand in both of yours and *willing* her to draw strength from you. If you could swap places with her right now, you would. In a heartbeat. "Please. One more push. You are almost there, love."

A broken, cracked whimper tumbles past her lips while hot tears track down her flushed cheeks. "I'm scared, Catra." She confesses. "So scared."

Your heart lurches painfully at her words, at the fear that you can see lurking in those beautiful blue eyes, and you would chastise yourself for not having realized it sooner if it weren't that *this* isn't about you and your own insecurities.

You don't have monopoly on the fear of fucking things up as a parent. And for how much you hate knowing that she feels this way, too, you can't deny that it's also, for how twisted it might sound, so very strangely comforting at the same time.

You are both scared shitless.

But... It's normal to be afraid. And that fear is probably what is holding her back, more so than the exhaustion and pain themselves.

But that realization, the knowledge that she is stuck battling it, is how you happen to fight your own. How you manage to dig underneath it and find the strenght and determination and confidence that you need to lead her on the other side of it.

It doesn't matter that *you* are scared, perhaps even terrified about this new unknown you are about to leap into. Because you are going to be doing this *together.* And, as you have found

out, there isn't a single thing in the Universe you can't do when you and her are together and of one mind.

You tell her this, calmly, smiling reassuringly at her, squeezing her hand tightly in your own to reinforce your next words. "I got you. I got both of you, Adora. Forever. *I swear it.*"

You can't even find the words to express the kind of joy and pride that surges through you when you finally see her eyes clearing from the haze of pain at those words.

The way she squeezes your hand back is deliberate this time, not merely a reflex induced by yet another painful contraction.

And for how small, the gesture is all you need to know that she is ready.

In response you squeeze hers and, when the Doctor gives her the order to prepare for another push, you instruct Adora to do just as Perfuma has taught you during her antenatal classes.

"Take a deep one, love."

She does, inhaling deeply. And releasing it all with a big push when the next contraction hits.

Her entire body lurches forward.

The bones in your hand grind together.

A mighty scream tears from her throat, threatening to shatter the windows of the entire infirmary.

Afterwards, she slumps back onto the bed, against the propped pillows, panting.

You don't realize she actually did it until, a heartbeat later, the sound of the Universe's tiniest, high pitched, squeling, crying meow pierces the air.

Your ears swivel forward and your heart leaps and swells and nearly threatens to burst right out of your chest.

"Well done Adora!" You can barely hear the doctor though, or notice the nurses work in a frenzy all around, or focus on anything other than that beautiful sound that reaches places inside you you weren't even aware existed.

And yet, you always *have.* For there, within those depths, you find the very roots of your love for Adora. And right beside the place where it resides, something like a switch gets flipped on in what you already know is going to be a permanent way upon hearing your cub's first cry.

The joy that fills you at that sound is so much, so overwhelming and all-encompassing that for the second time in six months, you almost forget how to breathe and nearly faint again.

But you don't.

Instead, you force yourself to draw in a shaky sip of air and blink to clear your blurry vision.

Because you want to remember this moment forever.

You want to remember the way Adora - so strong and beautiful and full of dignity even in her bone-deep exhaustion and with her privates still exposed to a room full of people - brings a hand up to cover her mouth and muffles a sob of pure joy when the Doctor congratulates you and then announces, grinning, that you have an equally strong, beautiful, healthy baby girl.

You want to remember that the first glimpse you get of *her*, of *your daughter*, is of this furry little bundle of energy squirming and crying protestingly as she gets properly cleaned up and wrapped in a soft, light blue blanket.

You want to relish in the feeling of anticipation that makes your heart race inside your chest and your palms grow sweaty with the most peculiar combination of anxiety and eagerness.

And you want the teary, dimpled, bright smile that you see on Adora's overjoyed face when the cub is finally placed in her awaiting arms, seared into your memory- your very *soul* - forever.

. . .

She is exactly how you pictured her she would be like.

How you whispered it to yourself and Adora, somewhat dreamily, half joking and half hoping, while you lounged in bed during particularly lazy afternoons and stroked her belly, occasionally feeling a tiny foot kicking from within.

It's like those whispered wishes have taken form as you uttered them.

Precisely so.

In every single detail.

From the tuft of dark blonde hair on top of her head, the impossibly soft, sand-colored fur, and the piercing blue eyes you have only glimpsed at for a split second before they have fluttered shut once again; the trait you have been most thrilled to discover.

Adora's eyes.

She has Adora's *eyes*.

You can barely hold back another sobbed laugh of utter glee at the reality of it all.

(It remains to be seen if, aside from your most obvious feline traits, you might have passed along your reckless disposition and mischievous attitude. Hopefully though, your child has

inherited her mother's branch of DNA regarding behavioral traits. Like her kind nature and generous, loving, ever-forgiving heart).

Whatever the case will turn out to be given time, it remains undisputable that she is, simply put, pure perfection.

Strong and healthy, and as beautiful as her mother.

You couldn't have asked for anything more.

You couldn't possibly feel more blessed.

Her tiny, furry ears are still folded on themselves, you notice. They will only pop out fully in about a month's time. (...or so you have read in a few, ancient, nearly-disintegrated scrolls).

An adorably bushy tail peeking from between the folds of the blanket and a full set of tiny claws balled up into just-as-tiny paws complete the picture.

She is so new and fluffy and *tiny* and infinitely precious and *yours*.

My baby.

My cub.

You glance up at Adora, who is still a complete mess, even freshly changed into a new hospital gown and tucked in under a clean set of sheets, with drugs coursing through her system, numbing the lingering pain and mending some of the (thankfully minimal) trauma that came with the birth.

Silent as it has been, she hasn't stopped crying - nor smiling from ear to ear - for a single second. Never taking her eyes away from "our daughter" as she keeps repeating, awed. The infant cradled safely in her arms while she watches mesmerized (and lightly amused) at the way the little thing squirms half-heartedly, as if testing her own limbs, stretching in whichever way, making the softest, cutest little meows that turn almost instantly into the tiniest purrs of contentment once Adora finds the right position and rests her directly against her chest.

That stops the squirming right away.

But the fact that your cub gets immediately subdued by this new arrangement is not even surprising; you are the first one to know how soothing the steady thrum of Adora's heartbeat can be. How comforting her body warmth is. And if your cub is just as attuned to the rush of loving hormones that you can smell and sense coming off your lover (which she most certainly is, at that same instinctual, primal level granted by your superior senses), then it's no wonder she gives up on her dynamic stretching in favor of submitting into a snuggle instead.

"You did it." You tell Adora, still dazed, even more so with the tumult in the infirmary wing having died down. Your voice hoarse and thick and loaded with so many emotions you can't even begin to sort through. You can only swallow in an attempt to be heard more clearly, especially for what you want to say next. What she has to know above anything else.

"I can't even find the words to tell you how proud I am of you. How much I love you."

For the first time since the doctors and nurses have left you alone to give you some privacy and allow you to bask in the beginning of your new life as a family, Adora tears her gaze away from the cub now cooing and idly gnawing at her own fist.

"We did it together." She says, her voice all firm softness. Her smile all warmth and affection.

"You did the hardest part." You argue, awkwardly rubbing at the back of your neck, only partially jealous that she got to live through such a monumental life-changing experience of bringing life into the world. "You went thought months of morning sickness, of flitting through various amount of discomforts while I just-"

"While *you*, have been there, *with me.* Every minute of every day. Being supportive and caring and thoughtful even through my *awful* mood swings." She says, with that same firm softness in her voice, her gaze shifting down to the now dozing cub. Her features instantly rearranging into a smile. Her eyes lighting up and crinkling at the corners. "There is as much of you in her as there is of me, Catra."

And isn't that a most terrifying, wondrous thought?

You look at her. At this... this miraculous life that you and Adora have created, together, and among all the potential and possibilities that you can already see in her in just a few years in the future, you can also see your own present chance. Not for redemption or atonement (because she'll never be reduced to an instrument to serve you in making amends for your sins), but for you to become something- some*one* you couldn't possibly have imagined being. Ever.

Someone who has lacked for your entire life.

A real parental figure.

Someone that will protect her and love her no matter what.

Someone who can teach her how to be good and, hopefully, inspire her to be better.

The Universe, as it seems, has deemed you worthy enough to grant you this chance. This *honor.*

You have this sort of epiphany the first time Adora urges you closer and then passes her over to you, carefully, with one of those loving smile and a simple, softly muttered, "Here. You two should meet properly."

And in that moment, when your daughter is placed in your arms, when you feel her weight settling against your chest, in the instant you hear her first, tiny, sleepy meow so close to your heart, the second you see the way her little nose twitches as she sleeps, peaceful and content and *perfect* (you can't quite get over how marvelous a being she is, let alone that you have had *any* part in creating her), the fiercer sense of tenderness and protectiveness stirs within you, along with that same ancestral entity you have gotten pretty acquainted with in the past

several months. And in that same moment you know for a fact that there isn't a thing you wouldn't do for her.

Not an enemy you wouldn't face.

Not a world you wouldn't burn to the ground to keep her *safe.*

Whatever it takes, you vow, silently, to her and yourself and Adora.

Your *family.*

You find yourself unable to tear your gaze away from her. From this innocent, helpless creature nestled safely in your arms. And you finally understand why Adora also seemed unable (and unwilling) to do the same, preventing you from even breathing properly. Because, in a way, it feels like you are holding your own bare, beating heart in your hands.

A rather morbid image, but which conjures exactly what you are experiencing in this monumental moment: as if your own heart is beating outside of your body and will never be confined within your chest ever again.

As afraid as you still are though, (understandably so, like any other new parent must feel like, you believe, and *definitely* like you know Adora must be feeling right now) you find your strength and determination in this resolve that stirs ferociously within you like a newly discovered instinct. Yet another fragment of your DNA flaring like a beacon of protectiveness.

You don't realize you have started crying again until you hear yourself sniffling and feels the warm wetness seeping through the thin layer of fur on your cheeks.

"You okay?" Adora asks, tentative, but not worried by your current, very emotional state. If anything, she looks very understanding about it. Or so the curl of a tired yet earnestly curious, knowing, equally reassuring smile tugging at the corner of her mouth tells you the moment you glance up at her. Her eyes so kind and brimming with so many emotions. Old ones and new ones. All mingled together to create the most peculiar look of affection.

You don't quite know how to express the tumult of feelings raging within you.

But you are willing to try and be brave.

"I never would have thought that this was how things would have turned out for me- for *us*." It's as good a start as any, you guess. But most of all, it's honest. And that's what matters most. What you know Adora values most. "But now..."

A soft squeeze around your hand prompts you to continue when your pause stratches a moment too long, as does the encouraging smile that you see on her lips when you glance at her.

"Now I can't imagine them having gone in any other way. And if I'm being truly honest with myself, this is everything I ever wanted and didn't know I needed."

To be loved. To belong. And to love in turn. Fiercely so.

But you needn't specify.

"Oh, Catra..." Adora's eyes are shimmering with fresh tears. Same as yours. You can feel the prickling of salt in them, how exposed they make you feel, but instead of hiding them, of wiping them away, you simply continue, undeterred.

"You have been my constant through life. My first one true friend. My *best* friend. My mate. I never allowed myself to think that I could do anything good, and the truth is that I haven't, for a long time, and never if you weren't directly involved."

"You know that's not true." Adora protests, shaking her head, looking confident in her belief. But that's beside the point, no matter how much her words soothe the lingering aches twinging in your soul.

"You have given me everything, Adora. Trust when I didn't deserve it. Comfort and support I squandered because I thought accepting it would have made me weak. You have loved me and accepted me even when I couldn't do it myself, even when I knew I wasn't worthy of it, and now..." Your gaze shifts one more time to your sleeping cub and a smile breaks on your face at the sight.

Heavens... its like looking at her for the first time all over again.

"Now you gave me her." You tell her. Your raspy voice breaking into a sob, but even that doesn't stop you.

"I honestly don't think that I'll ever be able to return you a gift as pure and absolute and meaningful as her. But... I'll be there, raising her with you. Devoting myself to the two of you. Forever, if you'll have me."

You let a minute pass by, to compose yourself, but when you finally feel comfortable enough to look up at her again, you find that Adora's eyes are brimming with tears. And so much pride.

"That's all I ever wanted, too." She says, her throat bobbing as she swallows down the lump of emotions making her voice so shaky.

And that's it.

You lean in at the same time, pressing your lips against each other's, and sealing your promise of forever with the softest kiss.

It's as simple as that.

Because this is how it should be.

No proposals.

No fancy, pompous ceremonies.

Just you, the woman you love and a vow of commitment.

The sound of someone delicately clearing their throat is what disrupts the moment and shakes you from your safe bubble of peace, making you part reluctantly from one another.

"Sorry to interrupt," One of the youngest nurses that have assisted during the birth says from where she stands awkwardly at the foot of the bed, looking quite apologetic. "But the crowd outside is getting impatient." She informs throwing her thumb in the direction of the infirmary entrance.

It takes a moment for her words to make sense. But then they do and-

Oh.

Right.

You almost forgot about the rest of the world waiting out there for a minute.

More specifically, about the horde of ordinary aunts and uncles that will be your daughter's extended family. A certified bunch of *loons*...but which you already know would do absolutely *anything* for her.

Of course, you had already kind of anticipated that the reason for your tardiness would have spread like wildfire.

And now, apparently, Scorpia's Ball (and all those invited to it) seem to have camped right outside the infirmary wing of the Royal Palace of Brightmoon.

"They are all eager to meet... u-uh..." The nurse's voice trails off and her gaze falls to the dozing cub in your arms.

"Mara." You instantly fill in. The name spilling from your lips without a second thought, with the same ease of a breath. Your heart stumbling over a beat and then swelling with sentiment at the sight of Adora's eyes tearing up again as soon as you utter it, her lips parting in a silent, shaky gasp.

"That's right." You grin at her. "Her name, is Mara."

A homage to the late She-Ra.

To a fallen hero who did the impossible and died trying to keep Etheria and all its people safe.

But also... a tribute to an ancient member of the Nine Divines; the Khajiit's Goddess of Love herself. A way to anchor her to your people's proud origins and culture - which you have fully embraced, just like every single part of yourself - and towards which you feel immeasurably grateful. Today more than ever.

A name symbolizes a rebirth under every aspect.

It doesn't only feel extremely appropriate and fortunate. And it's not merely coincidental. But it sounds *right* in the most absolute way. And when the cub sleepily blinks her eyes open at the sound of that name and emits a soft trill when Adora repeats it, her voice awed and her sky-blue eyes misty, you take it as the ultimate approval.

Even the young nurse is caught fighting off a few tears of her own, and despite her attempts to recover and sound professional, the way her voice strains and shakes when she next speaks, gives her true emotional state away.

"As I was saying, everyone seems to be ready to break down the doors in order to meet baby Mara. Including the Queen." She adds, somewhat amusedly. "But that's up to you. The rest of the staff and I will find a way to chase them away with torches and pitchforks if that's what you wish. Just say the word." She concludes, all seriousness and firm determination. You almost expect her to salute like a soldier, too.

Adora chuckles, tired, but the mental image of the entire medical staff chasing away the Queen from a wing of her own *Palace* has her just as amused as you.

"As tempting as that sounds, I'm afraid that we'll have to let them in... eventually." It's what your lover says at last, heaving a long sigh before her gaze returns to the miraculous new life snuggled in your arms. Her entire face lighting up instantaneously with a smile. "But-"

"Not yet." You finish for her, carefully passing baby Mara to rest back into her mother's arms before taking a seat on the bed, viscerally craving the closeness of your entire family.

"We'll hold down the fort for a few more minutes then." The nurse announces and then walks silently away, leaving you to bask privately in the prologue of this new chapter in your new life.

Your previous one had been filled with the sour bitterness of heartbreak, of loneliness, misplaced feelings of betrayal and vengefulness.

But no more.

Never again.

You aren't alone anymore.

And you'll never be again.

No matter what title or medal of honor they pin on your breast for all to see. Now you know that your one and only purpose is to protect your mate, raise your cub, and make sure she'll always feel loved and accepted and valued for who she is. And not who she could become.

You won't have any expectation from her aside for wanting her to be free and *happy*.

A warm, tingling sense of peace envelops you from the inside at that silent vow, stretching out until it wraps around the two persons that matters most to you in the entire Universe.

It solidifies into tangibility when you meet Adora's loving gaze and see that look of instant, profound understanding shimmering in her teary blue eyes.

"We are ready for this." She states.

And there is nothing else that you can do but smile at her and then kiss her again.

We are.

Chapter End Notes

free tissues here

Thanks for reading everyone :)

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